THE COLLECTED WORKS OF GEORGE POTTER

What if ordinary men decided to act like a government?

What if a woman refused to allow society to control her self opinion?

What if time stopped for the least likely person in the world?

What if a famous pulp fiction writer woke up in a strange body and a stranger future?

What if the universe itself had a plan for all of us?

What if a low-paying job opened a window on the world?

What if?

Why not?

The guy could write a grocery list and it would break my heart. Or make me smile with quiet contentment. Or fill me with wonderment. Or make me laugh. ~ from Introduction by Claire Wolfe

George Potter's first book is a wonderfully diverse peek into both his interesting life and creative mind. Ranging from songs to short stories to essays and poetry and beyond, *Symbols Flow* similarly ranges from words of simple beauty to gritty depictions of the complexities of interactions with thugs of differing kinds. ....Potter is a keen observer of humanity, and an insightful, creative weaver of words. A reader may not *like* all the tapestries he weaves, but each is dexterously crafted, designed to provoke feeling as well as thought. .... [A] powerful package, and, we can hope, the first of many volumes from George Potter. Symbols flow, indeed.

~ Sunni Maravillosa, proprietress of Sunni's Salon,
a webzine of individualist culture
(http://www.endervidualism.com/salon)

What a selfish bastard. The rest of us hacks are content with some believable action, a coherent plot, maybe some snappy dialogue. If we accomplish two or more of the above in a single session it's a morning well spent, say we. "Feh!" to this, says Potter. Oh, he can do all that shit too. But is he content with that? Will he leave us mortals a little self respect, the illusion of a few laurels? He will not. No, he's also got to be the most insightful of observers, the most discerning of the subtleties of the human universe even while he's clocking you over the head with those very subtleties. Damn him to hell. Just try to read micropiece without simultaneously weeping over the stupidities of humanity and rejoicing over its transcendent heroism. Try reading Roberta-especially if you're up on your Heinlein-without glorying in your membership in the Master Species. Try reading the short poem An Enemy of the People without wanting to strangle Potter with his own intestines because he wrote it and, goddammit, you didn't. Just try. I double dare you.

George deserves all the rewards a literary career could ever bring, and he deserves to get them good and hard.

~ Joel Simon, author of Walt's Gulch

SYMBOLS

FLOW

GEORGE POTTER

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DEDICATION

For the women and men of
The Writers Block & Outlaw Trail.

They can't shut us all up.

Out there, the motor throbbed out the bass notes of its powerful song,
and the whole wide road waited.

~ Jules Varwig

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The essays, stories, songs and poems contained within this volume were made possible by a life lived interacting with interesting people. There is no way that I could possibly thank every person who deserves thanks. But, as in all things, some have made a bigger impact than others. Consider this my feeble, doomed to fail attempt:

First my parents, Ann and Sam Potter, who raised me to distrust authority and think for myself. No greater gift can be bestowed on a child.

To my brothers and sisters, who—through good times and bad—never let me forget they loved me: even when they didn't like me much.

To the writers and editors of the Golden Age of science fiction and fantasy, who filled my childhood with their mad dreams and glorious visions. My life would be considerably smaller without the raving of Heinlein, Anderson, Simak, Bester, Piper, Vance, and so many others. You did not write for me or my generation, friends; but some of us found you.

To the old school of anti-state.com: Clay, Carl, Paul, Sean, Aaron, Andy, Bill, Bob, Rachael, Gene and Jeremy. Thanks for the agreements, the arguments and the mind opening.

To Claire Wolfe, for being a friend, a mentor and an inspiration. I love you, Claire.

To Jules Varwig, brother-in-arms and flame. Inspiration and encouragement from you created most of these stories. I hope you enjoy them and many more.

To Samual Potter, brother-in-fact, and the reason I'm a writer. Thanks for wanting to hear stories, bub.

To Pagan and Dare2BFree, for their labors creating this book. To K. Carpenter, for her covers and editorial insight.

And to every man and woman out there writing a line in the hope that it will inspire the fires of free-thought and free-life in a heart and a mind. We have a hard row to hoe, but—as I said in the dedication—they can't shut us all up.

Welcome to part of my mental web, to a section of my slice of the symbolflow. I hope you enjoy it.

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INTRODUCTION

by Claire Wolfe

I don't remember exactly when I first encountered George Potter. But I remember where. It was in an all-night truck stop somewhere in the South. I've never actually been in the South. But George's auto-biographical essay "micropiece" put me right there on the night shift, in the middle of a micro-society of truckers, night-dwellers, and... well, Americans.

I was blown away.

Since then I've seen George write everything from songs to science fiction. He can write in any genre or no genre, as you'll see within these pages. But never once have I known George to write anything that wasn't absolutely, totally, beautifully, mind-bendingly *good*. The guy could write a grocery list and it would break my heart. Or make me smile with quiet contentment. Or fill me with wonderment. Or make me laugh.

When George first asked me to write the introduction to *Symbols Flow*, I told him that, as a writer, I wasn't fit to touch the hem on his garment, let alone write the intro to his book.

George's abilities so exceed most of the story writers practicing today (and compared to George, most really are just practicing) that I thought this book should be published by a major New York publisher. The introduction should be written by some literary luminary. That literary light would effusively announce George's arrival on the scene.

But no. George told me he wanted his work published "small." He wanted his stories to appear in a book that would be largely read by freedom Outlaws and freedom outriders–by libertarians, outsiders, wild thinkers, rebels, free-market anarchists, gulch-dwellers, and various and sundry folk who slip between the cracks or slide away from the norms. That is, he wanted this book mostly to be read by his friends and the friends of his characters.

So I'm being given an honor I don't deserve. But here goes.

If all of the above sounds absurdly gushy, consider the current state of short-fiction writing. Although I believe George would stand out in *any* crop of writers, the current crop is one it's easy for George to stand above.

Once, in the early half of the twentieth century, nearly all the big magazines published short stories. *The Saturday Evening Post*, for instance, was famous for publishing top quality fiction by America's best writers. Dozens of magazines fostered the careers of dozens of America's story-writing greats.

John Steinbeck. William Saroyan. John O'Hara. J. D. Salinger. William Faulkner. Ernest Hemingway, F. Scott Fitzgerald.

And of course, in science fiction (one of George's preferred genres) there were lights like Isaac Asimov, Heinlein, de Camp, Bradbury, Clarke, and H. Beam Piper.

It was a phenomenal time–from about the 1920s through the 1950s.

Then came the rot.

As people watched more TV, the great general-interest print magazines began to die. Their world fell apart. Today, the few major magazines still publishing non-genre fiction print only a rarefied few writers. Their doors are often completely closed to unknowns. So the markets for commercial fiction writers dried up, and the breeding grounds for great short stories went with them.

At the same time literary fashion began to demand that mainstream short stories be virtually plotless and better yet, nearly actionless. The fashionable short story of today is a few thousand words of a character study about someone uninteresting doing nothing much. Miserable characters absorbed in small, private misery.

Genre fiction still thrives–mystery and science fiction in particular. Even there, unfortunately, most writers earn a fraction of what their counterparts did in the golden age. (George is adamant, though. He doesn't care whether he makes money; he writes for love, and it shows.) But outside of genre fiction, it's a sad, sad world for writers and readers of short fiction.

So George stands out in today's sadly reduced story-writing crowd. But in my opinion, George would also have held his own in the days of Fitzgerald and Faulkner. And remember, this guy is as fluid and fluent with his non-fiction as his fiction, and as poetic with his fiction as his poems. His works have depth. And breadth. Autographical stories like "Ghost" and "Stray Dog" take you onto rugged streets and into the worst of police state USA—the Cook County Jail. "Lullaby" lifts you to a magical (yet heart-rending) realm where loved ones unite

across space and time in ways that are impossible to believe yet impossible to resist.

His characters, like the young "Xangurl" have their problems. Sometimes we wouldn't wish their lives on our worst enemies.

Others, like the artist of "Stilled Life," bemuse. Or they may amuse. Or outrage (as "Roberta" might do, depending on your philosophical persuasion). But George's characters all move through the world doing things that are unfailingly interesting and often worthy and filled with fascination.

In a different era, you'd have already been reading George's stories in national magazines, This book *would* be published by a major New York publisher. And I leave you to speculate which literary luminary might be writing its introduction.

But you can be sure that that luminary would give praise just as effusive as mine.

Prepare to enjoy...

Claire Wolfe is the author of *The Freedom Outlaw's Handbook*, *How to Kill the Job Culture Before It Kills You*, and *I Am Not a Number!* She is the creator of the contrary mid-nowhere town of Hardyville and co-author, with Aaron Zelman, of *The State vs. the People* and the young-adult novel, *RebelFire: Out of the Gray Zone*. She lives in an undisclosed location somewhere in the West and has a fine time practicing freedom Outlawry.

PROLOGUE

The nans observed the throwback on the viewscreen. As usual, it was sullenly working on the fetish it had been building for days.

Nan087 sighed, the breath causing her ethereally lovely face to pulse with a blush. Nan096 touched her sibling gently, in sympathy. The throwback was their ward, and it was obvious to them that it must be destroyed. Intractable. Stubborn. Refusing to co-operate. The nans were designed to nurture and heal, to guide and comfort. The throwbacks gruff refusal of their love hurt them physically.

"A shame the project will suffer a setback."

"Indeed. Our calculations will have to be revamped. The Thinkers were certain that pulling the code and mental records from the early 21st, as the collective meme was truly getting started, but well before the Overmind began to gentle the Flock would result in a worker prototype that would happily immerse itself in collection, but retain the true human spark of creativity."

Another sigh. "A new subspecies. An imaginative worker. Instead, we got a true throwback," she shuddered. "An individualist." She whispered the filthy word, a word forbidden to all but the highest castes.

"Truly an illustration of how much better the Overmind has made the world. Look at how he works so diligently on his useless fetish! Some mystical mindset or habit, obviously."

The object in question was a bizarre assemblage of trash the throwback had demanded for the very little co-operation he was willing to spare. Mostly worthless things from his era whose very use had been long discarded and forgotten.

"Remember the only two smiles we got from it?" Nan087 asked. "The first when we told it that The Thinkers had built a starship. How its eyes lit up!"

"Yes, and the second when we allowed it to have the little box of plastic and copper trinkets from the House Of The Past."

"A shame. But there's no use putting it off. Dispose of it. Then we shall have these painful memories wiped."

They entered their orders.

He waited.

They should never have told me about the starship. Sealed their fuckin' doom right there.

Maybe not all of humanity had been reduced to this repugnant beehive culture. Maybe some had escaped. Maybe there was a free culture elsewhere in the solar system. Or the stars. The thought made him smile, and shiver slightly, from a desire deep in his bones.

Maybe. To a guy like him, maybe was a powerful word.

He wasn't sure the device would work. The spring/needle hammer worked good, and the steel chair leg should be stout enough. Like everything else in The House Of The Past, the buckshot had been vacuum sealed. Still... centuries old.

The door irised open.

Guess I'm about to find out.

Two Proctors entered. Perhaps this overmind thought them 'tough' looking, and perhaps to the degenerated 'people' called The Flock they were. To him they looked like slightly overweight Star Trek fans.

"Your disposal has been ordered," they said in unison, no trace of emotion in their voice. "As is customary, you may make a short statement to be sourced and held in memory for The Flock."

They watched him load the 12 gauge slug with uncaring ignorance. He cranked the spring back.

"OK," he said, raising the crude gun. "Live free or die, motherfuckers."

The explosion in the cramped room nearly deafened him. The buckshot at close range tore chunks from the Proctors and put them down. Joy sang in his heart as he loaded another shell. It hadn't destroyed itself or killed him. It had worked.

He ran towards the spaceport, along the route he had memorized.

If I can get there. If I can figure out how to fly the fucking thing. If...

If. *If* was enough.

He ran, the joy in his heart mingling with the defiance that defined him, his 'last words' ringing though his mind, blotting out all fear.

He ran, ready for that choice.

NON-FICTION

micropiece

For Lily Elizabeth Potter, beloved daughter—who owns my life, my love and my labor.

interface: entrypoint

I am a micropiece.

I stand at one of the uncounted entry points to the market; amid the grand swirl and flow of symbols and goods that constitutes the practical life of the swarming human race.

I am an interface, a sentry keeper, a minor sentinel. I am the crux of the purchase, the endpoint of property transfer.

I watch the security system, looking for thieves.

I keep this lone post along the vast web of intestates clean and well lit, attractive to the potential customer—another oasis of sense in the black of night and the random movement of the road.

To me the hordes bring their needs, and to me they lay their money down. With me they trade value for value, and the goal is to satisfy us both. I do not love my job, but I do it well, for it has to be done—and the value it gives back to me is both necessary and acceptable.

What I do is minor, but not unimportant. It is common, but not base. What I do is help complete the vast and intricate puzzle of the human market. It is a puzzle of unimaginable size and complexity, one that will be forever worked at yet never completed, for the puzzle grows as the human race grows.

It will never be completed, but still we will lay the pieces together and try to make them speak sense from chaos. We continue working on it for the same reason we continue breathing— because it keeps us alive.

I am a minor piece, but sometimes I still smile at the thought of being involved in such a beautiful puzzle.

I am a micropiece.

I am a cashier.

kings of the road

In this day, when a five-year-old song becomes an "oldie", and a ten-year-old movie can be considered "a classic", the truck stop off exit 81 on Interstate 78 in Belden, Mississippi must be viewed as an artifact—an ancient edifice of Lovecraftian stature. It has stood here for over

forty years, changed hands a dozen times, endured the changes those years have brought and managed to thrive. The reason is simple:

We sell fuel. Diesel.

Diesel is the fluid that powers the engine of American commerce. It is the effluence of dinosaurs and prehistoric plants, distilled and made volatile. It powers the monstrous engines of the Macks and Reos and Freightliners that rule the highways of this land mass. The eighteen wheelers you curse as they blast by you on your way to work, pulling a hundred solid tons of freight from here to there at speeds that would send our ancestors into shock. The kings of the road, the merchant princes. The metaphorical descendents of the clipper ship captains who plied the Atlantic between the old world and the new, seeking a fortune and most often simply making ends meet. They run on diesel. And so does the truck stop. But there are other forms of fuel.

Food.

We have a restaurant. It's not a fancy restaurant by any means. Truck stop fare, greasy and simple. The prices are oddly high, and the service may sometimes leave a bit to be desired, but the fact that it is always busy is the basic testament to its worth.

You can sit down and order three eggs, a crispy pile of hash browns, toast or biscuits, grits or home fries, and a massive slab of bone in country ham dripping with grill grease and flavor for less than seven dollars. Beat it, I dare you. Confront yourself with that eye popping load of food, enough to feed a small family, a platter that looks ready to explode, and tell me where you could get it better.

Perhaps it isn't what you want. That's no surprise. Because you are not being catered to.

The truckers are, with this simple extravagance. Men with no real home but the road, no waypoint but truck stops like this. The waitresses are their sisters, the cooks their mothers, and I their old friend they met not long ago, always ready to fuel them up and get them on their way with a minimum of fuss and bother.

Fuel comes in many forms.

We sell other things. Beer, candy, chips, smokes, truck supplies, soda, tools, phone cards, and so on. But that is all gravy, next to the fuel.

We cater to these distant sons of the merchant princes.

We cater to these kings of the road.

small changes

I work third shift, graveyard, late shift, last shift, night shift. Call it what you like, because the name doesn't matter. What matters is that I begin my work day at midnight and end it at eight AM. What matters is that I find myself out of synch with the majority of the human race.

The worst thing about third shift is that you begin busy; the second shift drive home rush, the closing bar rush. Cranky people wanting to get home and unpredictable drunks trying to sober up a bit at the only restaurant for miles that's open after midnight. And then you end busy, with the first shift going to work rush. More cranky people, barely awake, fueling up and seeking caffeine. They come in hordes, and they want you to hurry. In between is a long stretch of deepening boredom, of nothing to do. You find yourself cleaning, ordering, straightening, doing busy work, just to make the time pass. By the time the morning rush arrives you are tired, bored, annoyed and ready to go home and sleep. But things start jumping.

So far I have maintained control. I have not yet punched the remaining teeth out of an asshole trucker blaming me because his fuel card hasn't been authorized. I have not yet verbally destroyed the skinny bitch who complains in detail about the deli food yet buys it without fail every morning. I have not yet raised hell with the 6 am second register cashier who is never less than 20 minutes late. 20 minutes as I fiend for a cigarette with a line snaking all the way to the back beer coolers, trying to be polite to people who roll their eyes and whine that they are going to be late for work, or that there's no coffee made.

The best thing about third shift is that I am, for the most part, my own boss. No manager, no supervisor. Just me, a waitress, a cook and a dishwasher. This means I am pretty much the king of the truck stop during the eight hours I am required to be on duty.

For some, that would be a recipe for trouble. Carte blanche in the middle of the night, doing an alternately boring and frustrating job for low pay and little appreciation. Some might start stealing, or sleeping, or drinking, or selling drugs.

I decided to use it as an educational experience.

I decided to see if I could, in my own little way, manipulate the market.

And the results were quite satisfying.

Take the coffee problem. Once the morning rush begins, it's damned near impossible for me to get off the register and make it to meet the massive demand for it. Every morning I would put up with a symphony of complaints and annoyed looks, of the waitresses bitching about non-tipping customers raiding their pots, and there was nothing much I could do but grin and bear it.

Then I noticed something. The regulars, confronted with three empty coffee pots, and knowing the drill from long experience, would simply make a pot or two.

As a gesture of thanks, I would give them their cup on the house.

Word spreads, baby. To hell with tv and the net and radio. Word of mouth is still the fastest information transfer system on the planet. Bandwidth? No such thing. The band is unlimited. Word of mouth supersedes and incorporates all other mediums—since without it, there would be only silence and static on those media.

Within two days, I no longer needed to worry about coffee. The regulars kept it up for me, and saved 74 cents. It has gotten to the point now that folks will come in, be confronted with three full pots, and say "Well, fuck!" as they begin fishing for change.

It is a rare morning that the pots aren't full these days.

My second experiment was the biscuits, and it was much more impressive.

We have this deli box/steam table, glass-enclosed and heated. At 3 AM, the cook brings out three pans of breakfast biscuits. Sausage, bacon, ham, tenderloin, steak, bologna, and chicken. All of them are available plain or with cheese, with egg, or both. The prices change accordingly.

When I started, only a few people bought the biscuits. People would look, ask the prices, then just decide not to get one. We'd end up tossing three quarters of them and writing it off. After a little while, mostly out of boredom, I asked a customer why.

"Well, they look good as hell," I was told. "But the Shell down the street has the same thing, and it's about ten cents cheaper."

Intriguing.

I am not a competitive sort. I have no interest in sports, chess, checkers, poker, video games or anything else that places me in direct competition with another person. The reason for this is simple: I detest losing. I get mad. So, I refrain.

But this was different. It affected my job. It also involved my current intellectual obsession, the beautiful market system that pervades human life so deeply that most people never even think about it.

I had an idea. In a sense, it was risky. If it failed, or I was caught, I might be written up or even fired. I thought about it for a day or two, weighed the risks.

Then one morning, I just did it. I threw the price sheet away and just started selling every biscuit for 99 cents.

The results were phenomenal. By the end of that week I couldn't keep the damned biscuits for more than an hour or two. Word spread, and spread. We gained new regulars, folks who apparently used to frequent the Shell in the morning but now stopped here, to grab some biscuits with their gas, coffee, honey buns and smokes.

I let my 'discount' ride for two weeks, I suppose until I felt I had the new regulars hooked on a routine, then went back, without a word, to the old price system.

I waited to see if I would be busted. I waited to see if business would fall off.

Neither happened. I am still selling those biscuits as fast as people can step into the store. The only complaints I've gotten have been from the waitresses, who've noticed a downturn in their customers since the deli box became so mysteriously attractive, and the cook, who is now required to make five pans of biscuits every morning, and is angry at the talk of ditching the other morning items in favor of biscuits exclusively.

I just shrug, and say "Go figure."

I have pondered the reason why the price increase didn't hurt my shift's business. In fact, it seems to grow every day, as word continues to spread. I have come to a few conclusions:

• Our biscuits are better than Shell's. The biscuits are homemade, the meat and egg and cheese are generous. I've seen the Shell's wares, and they are frozen biscuits with skimpy portions. Quality counts.

• People like me. I don't want to sound egotistical, but I am a damn good cashier. I remember my regulars, crack jokes, commiserate on having to work early or getting off late.

My change is exact, I keep my drawer over by a dollar. Folks know they won't have to dig for pennies. I remember their brand of smokes, snuff, or chewing tobacco. I talk to them, like a real human being. I do not give a big fake grin and spout rote greetings and goodbyes. I can always break a hundred.

I am an interface, an entry point to the market, and I determined when I took this job to be a good one, and make this necessary human function as pleasant and enjoyable as I possibly can.

I will do so for as long as I hold this job that I do not love—but have learned to respect.

rabblerouser

No one cares what they say to the micropiece—we ride below their threshold.

Some would find this insulting, or demeaning. In fact, I surrendered to that feeling at first. Until, that is, I realized exactly how much opportunity this engendered to actually observe and analyze the complex workings of the individual components in this tiny slice of the market.

Odd that invisibility would lead to such power.

Truckers are an odd lot, individualistic and often outspoken. I can count on the fingers of one hand the number of truckers I met espousing any sort of collectivization that even approached socialism. In fact, I met only one. He seemed to be some sort of union organizer or hardcore advocate. He engaged a few others in discussion that led to his being laughed out of the restaurant one night. He left in a huff, angry that the independent operators should dismiss his fantasy of collective fraternity so outright and profanely.

Most of the truckers I met were apolitical. Some actually called politics a scam and a game. Understandable. These are men without a home—road riders. Loners by nature or design. But I certainly heard them express their opinions loudly and clearly quite often.

I never pushed or prodded, or preached or evangelized. That would have been rude. I was there to do a job and they were there to

rest during the job. I stuck to the topic at hand, whatever they felt like talking about.

But, on the occasions it did come up, I did not shy away from my own opinions.

The truckers liked me. They liked the fact that I could converse on a wide range of topics, and they liked my jokes and overall sense of humor. Some liked to talk music, some wanted to talk about women and their inscrutable ways. Some wanted to talk sport—which I know nothing about but was game enough to try and fake.

On one memorable occasion, a shrunken elderly black man with a thick and beautiful southern Louisiana accent—an old-school owner/operator who had been driving since his late teens—brought up the Viking explorations of America! I was delighted. Such strange juxtapositions are the real joy in such a dreary job. I know a bit about the subject and we conversed a while. He excused himself to get something from his truck and returned a few minutes later with a thick hardback book that I instantly recognized: Will Durant's *The Age Of Faith*—the volume that had turned me into a history freak at age 15. He looked a bit sheepish. "I picked this up at a library sale. I don't know why. But it means a lot to me. He wrote more, this fella, right? The whole story of civilization, I hear."

He and I talked after that. Really talked—about important things, deep things. He ended up standing there at the counter through the rest of my shift, and our conversation ranged over the history of the world and interspersed with personal stuff. Politics was a big theme—and I was not shy about my opinion. And he agreed. He seemed to draw strength from it. I tried to be eloquent. I tried to be calm and logical. My point—as my point always is—was that the more power we give the state, the more enslaved we are. He agreed. He talked about his own family, his brothers and sisters lost in welfare and housing projects, turned apathetic.

When he left, smiling at me as if he'd found a kindred spirit, we shook hands. His shake was firm and warm and honest. "It was a fine thing to meet you, George," he said to me, "and I hope we meet again soon."

I had to fight tears.

That is the proper way to be a rabblerouser. By treating people as people. By engaging their hearts and souls. By approaching them as

human beings and not potential converts. Walking up wild-eyed and tossing pamphlets and yelling slogans simply gets you written off as a nut. You'll never change a person's mind that way, unless they are as crazy as the slogan shouter in the first place.

It happened fairly regularly. Nice conversations got started, I'd see an opening, and I'd introduce my anti-statist opinion. I'd always introduce it as a point where they agreed. I'd never contradict or incite argument. I'd word my response in a way that
was non-threatening but thought-provoking. I considered it a triumph to plant a seed and leave them thinking. I'd snuck up on them, after all, below their threshold, placed herein a market-friendly point and rousing the rabble the best I could.

Of course, some people are unreachable.

One morning a well-dressed couple stopped, gassed up their SUV, bought a paper, and asked about a menu. I gave them one. Snobs, I knew—just from looking at them. Observing them. They seemed bemused at being in such a common, tacky place.

They were an older couple—mid 50's I would guess. Very attractive, especially the lady. She reminded me of the beautiful and talented Gena Rowlands. She had a classic face and a hairstyle that suited her perfectly. She was well dressed and—physically—a picture of real class. I held back my desire to flirt shamelessly.

"Dear lord, we are certainly in the heart of the south!" she laughed. "Look at these menu choices. They all come with grits!" Haha. She tossed me a look, that look that says 'I don't mean you of course'. I smiled, but the urge to flirt died suddenly.

"Seems that Bush is having some trouble convincing Congress of the need to deal with Iraq." Hubby said, reading from his paper.

Wifey sniffed, still perusing the menu she found hilarious. "Idiots. What a bunch of idiots. America is all that matters."

She tossed the menu on the counter, and basically dismissed me.

"Do you know what we should do? Really?"

Oh, I was all fucking ears.

"What's that, sweetie?" asked hubby, probably reading the comics by now.

"We should just nuke the planet. Think about it. We are protected by vast oceans on either side of the truly powerful states. We should just wipe them out. Asia, the Middle East, Europe, Africa. Waste.

That's all they are. Especially the Middle East. They signed their death warrant when they dared to attack their betters. Just wipe them out. And China is a joke. So is Russia. I never believed either had a functioning ICBM. It's ludicrous. They ride around in rickshaws and can't even give welfare to their poor people. We should just wipe them out. All of them. Good riddance. Then the South American countries would know who's the boss and never give us any trouble. Are you ready? I don't feel like eating this hick slop. Let's go to the Arby's up the road."

"Mmm-hmm," said hubby.

They paid for their gas and I tried to keep my hands from shaking as I rang it up. I tried to keep the bile from rising in my throat. I tried to keep from reaching out and smashing that bitch's face into the counter, hopping over it, and beating her pathetic husband into the floor while she watched and saying, "Hey! Look! I can do it! Must make it right!"

I succeeded, despite the fact that, in my head, I remembered this little piece of video I had seen years ago, of a baby girl dancing joyfully with her brothers and sisters on the streets of Baghdad, while her grandfather played music. That baby girl looked almost exactly like my baby girl. She was just a little darker of skin. Her eyes were the same. Her joy was the same. Her life was exactly the same.

They left, and I cried. I couldn't help it. I cried for a while. Co-workers came up and asked me what was wrong, I told them it was ok, I was just tired, under a lot of pressure, made excuses, etc. I couldn't tell them that I was afraid for the entire human race. Afraid because people like that were the ones in charge, the ones who counted.

And I could only rouse a certain kind of rabble.

humans in action

But then, one day, I saw an amazing thing...

I'm working a rare day shift—filling in for a call-in and grabbing the opportunity for some overtime. It was just a few minutes after 5 PM, right about when the first afternoon rush gets going, and I was pleased by the steady business that allows me simply go with the flow, lets me ignore the steady passage of minutes towards the goal of quitting time. I am ringing up my customer's purchase, staring at the

keypad , when I hear a THUD, and the old guy in front of the counter says, in a voice between awe and horror: "Holy shit!"

I look up and out the plate glass of the store's front wall, and I see a red Dodge Intrepid flipping through the air, trailing glass and debris, landing in the ditch by the highway. It is a surreal sight. A simultaneously fascinating and sickening sight. The woman driving it had blindly pulled out into oncoming traffic and was hit by a huge Chevy truck.

The man behind the current customer, waiting to pay for a tank of gas, tosses a 20 on the counter and says, "I'll be right back, I gotta help those people!" His face is pale and his eyes oddly distant. In retrospect, I decided that they were the eyes of a man running on deep impulses that have little to do with conscious thought.

I dial 911 before the damned car even lands, report the accident and take off out the door, as does most of the store. I stop by the time I get to the highway, because at least a dozen other people have already arrived—stopping on their way past, or running from the diesel fuel island. Before even a single minute has passed, people are swarming over that car—truckers, mostly.

The car is on fire, but they don't seem to care.

I hear someone scream—"There's babies in here!"

Ignoring flame and the possibility of explosion, the truckers set to that car like men possessed. One arrives with a sledge hammer and shatters a back window because the doors are jammed shut. Men actually crawl into that car and out—retrieving three scared, screaming, but mostly unhurt children. The hammer gets put to work on a front window, and two men drag the unconscious driver out next.

A man driving by screeches to a sudden stop and pulls—of all things—a fire extinguisher from his trunk, hurriedly dousing the growing flames before they spread to the passenger, who seems to be trapped inside, a living, crying, conscious body imprisoned by twisted metal, unreachable by any easy access point.

By this time, two truckers have taken matters into their own hands and blocked the highway by parking their rigs and trailers across the road—effectively halting traffic.

All this happens in the space of about four minutes.

The police and fire services and two ambulances arrive about five minutes later, just as the truckers are preparing to crank up an

acetylene torch to cut the passenger out.

Without an official word, command or procedure, these men and women did what they needed to do, without the thought of reward or fear for their own safety.

The crowd, myself included, is in tears. We are cheering these ordinary heroes.

The firemen got the passenger out fairly quickly with the jaws of life, but the police, when they arrived, mostly concerned themselves with establishing their personal authority, as if angered by such common folk taking on the simple responsibility of humanity without proper permission or clearance—yelling at the truckers for blocking the highway, threatening to arrest the two with the torch, and forcing the shocked and dazed driver to answer questions before allowing her to be loaded onto the second ambulance. (The first had been sent ahead, with the passenger and the children.) They finally left her alone when they noticed that the crowd—which had grown to fifty or sixty people—were getting pissed.

We actually closed in a bit, a low murmur rumbling. If the cops had tried to arrest the truckers with the torch, or continued harassing the obviously near-catatonic driver, they may have found themselves with a small riot on their hands.

This was a crowd that had seen humans in action, after all. Had seen folks just like them answer a call deeper than their own self-interest—and answer that call quickly and well. The sight was hope-giving, and beautiful. Not simply in the selflessness of it, but in the details—these men who were strangers yet worked like crisp professionals when needed. Their silent, hurried co-operation shining like a beacon, negating the cold nihilism of the well-dressed woman who wanted to nuke the rest of the world, and the continuous flood of bad and worse news that the media pours onto the public like rancid gravy at a wedding feast. Never will the media dwell on such things as this. They happen too fast, they are too ephemeral and hard to explain. They might rile the feathers of the proper saviors and authorities.

But I will dwell on it, because I will never forget it. It's burned in my memory.

I feel that on that day I saw human beings at their best.

I feel that on that day I saw anarchy in action, that I saw the true heart of the market at work... and it was profoundly moving.

interface: endgame

I am a micropiece.

I stand here and allow the grand dance of the market to pass over and through me, allow its flow to consume me and soothe me. The invisible beauty of its seeming chaos is nothing more than a complex mask hiding the only sort of order the poor irrational human race has ever achieved.

These thoughts are still new to me, still vivid and wide eyed, like the thoughts of a child.

When I first began to realize the nature of the market, I mistakenly believed that the state regulated and controlled it.

I now believe such thinking is naive and simplistic—and dangerous. It is exactly what the state wants us to believe.

The state is just a parasite. A tick. Ugly and small, but tough. It has found a vast and succulent host on which to feast, infected that host with a morbid fever, and convinced its sickened victim that to pluck it off will lead to certain death.

Lies.

The market transcends the state the way that the history of music transcends a single song. It is, at its basic level, simply humans being humans—living and dying, working and loving, hating, fearing, dreading, dreaming, giving, taking. It is a process, not an object—a vast, ever growing, ongoing process. It began when the first humans warily traded berries for game, or one crude tool for another. It will continue until we are either destroyed or become immortal and have no needs. It is the process of making things easier, of dividing labor, of discovering value and creating order. It has done great good and great evil, but is to be blamed or praised for neither—for it is not a thinking thing, nor a feeling thing. Its morality is the exact morality that any tool possesses: the morality of its wielder. The market has built grand cities and destroyed them in nuclear fire at the behest of its wielders. It has extended life and cut it short. It has given and taken.

But it has done it all because human beings willed it done.

I do not know what the future holds, whether it will bring great wonder or great horror. History suggest a mixture of the two. But I am presented with two paths: I can either expect the worst and become cynical and angry and apathetic and wait for death, or I can hope for the best and do my damnedest to live a moral life and work to wield

the tool of the market in an honest and responsible fashion and rejoice in my life and my time in this world.

I choose the latter. And the best way to do that is to care for those closest to me, to work to raise them up and protect them from harm. I know that my own actions can influence the market. I know that I can make a difference, however small.

I choose the latter, because once I saw brave men dive into a flaming car to save strangers. Ordinary, simple, brave men. I saw that and will refuse to believe that the human race is anything more than good and decent at its heart.

I choose the latter, and will dream of the day when the market—the whole of the thinking, feeling human race—finally brushes the tick of state parasitism from itself like the man who sits by a river on a cool morning, contemplating that flow of matter, and realizes he is being used by a lesser creature. I will dream of the day when the bonds of gravity are broken and men and women once again stride the face of the frontier, building and sowing, turning fallow land to fair, decreasing entropy as only men and women have ever done.

We will not do it for simple, cold currency. We will not do it from fear or force.

We will do it for love. For the sake of our children. For posterity, and promise and the room to grow.

We will do it because that is what it means to be a human.

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I have seen a preview of Hell.

They call it "Receiving", at Cook County Jail. Imagine—110 men, exhausted from a night spent in the just above freezing holding cells of the Grand and Central Police Station. From there we are packed like cattle into three paddy wagons—basically sitting on top of each other. Several are junkies undergoing severe dope sickness—vomiting every few minutes. One of them explosively shits on himself. The man next to him, disgusted, elbows him hard in the jaw and knocks him mercifully unconscious. Another man is just climbing down into the desperate pit of the DT's... shivering violently, crying, shoved into a corner as the cuffs that connect him to his neighbor bite into his wrist hard enough to draw blood.

And we haven't even arrived in the true Inferno yet. This is just the first circle.

I sit somewhere in the midst of this horror; this cage of horrendous noise and filth and stench, fighting to stay calm, praying to a God I'm not sure exists just to help me through this ordeal. I am bleached pale, bleeding from a host of scratches on my face, and dressed in only a ago T-shirt and shorts, shoes with no laces and no socks.

I am the only white face in this crowd of dark skins.

I am a ghost.

"I'm just giving you boy's a warning," says the affable driver of the paddy wagon as we pull to a stop in the fenced and guarded lot of Cook County Jail. "These guys here—they don't fuck around. These are some mean sonofabitches. Don't argue, don't back talk—hell... try not to say anything that's not an answer to a direct question."

A couple of guys laugh—hard-assed little gangbangers. They've been taking it all in stride, chatting cheerfully about seeing this guy or that guy, and what ward they'll end up on.

"Yeah, go ahead and ignore me, smart asses. Go ahead. These guys will hurt you. They'll hurt you and laugh. They've been sued, people have been fired, careers ruined. It doesn't stop them. They have a code."

He's talking about the Cook County Sheriff's Department. I will soon learn that this man is no liar, and is telling me the absolute truth with nothing but virtuous motive.

"Just stay quiet and do what you're told. You'll be OK."

But he was wrong about that part.

We are unloaded from the wagon, two by two—squinting in sudden bright sunlight. I look around at the gray on gray lot that leads up to a towering ugly building as we are herded into a long line pressed up against that building and told to sit. We sit, like good doggies.

The guy I'm handcuffed to stretches out and kicks back, enjoying the sun. "Better enjoy it now, dawg," he tells me. "Might not see it again for awhile."

I met him the night before, in the holding cell, as I shivered in the air-conditioning. He introduced himself as "Squeak".

"What you in for? Simple?" he asks, noticing my bleeding face and referring to "simple assault".

"Domestic Violence," I correct him. He laughs.

"Looks like you got the worst of it, homey."

I agree. A screaming match had let up to slapping that turned into clawing that turned into me shoving her onto the couch. This led to the police being called, which led to me being led out of my home, handcuffed and bleeding, as she settled in to finish her second liter bottle of white zin.

"How is it," I asked the arresting officer, "that I get my face torn up and she gets pushed away in defense—and yet I go to jail?"

"Well, she called," replied the bored cop. "If you wanted her taken in, you should have called. That's the way it works. Don't blame me for the system."

The grand justice of the System. *"Let they who be quicker to appeal to The State be accorded its benevolence."*

"You want to file a complaint?" the cop asked. "That face is grounds enough for us to take her in, too."

I didn't even bother to ask who would watch my sleeping daughter. I just said no, disgusted.

"Then shut up whining," says the cop, who fires up the cruiser and heads for Grand and Central.

Squeak laughs loud and long at my story, without a trace of derision. "Damn, homes. That sucks. You need to stay away from those Polish bitches though... they nuts."

"What about you? What did they grab you for?"

Squeak grins. "Got me with a hundred rocks. I was on the way to a drop. I'm gonna be inside for a while, homes."

We are interrupted by a voice from the next cell. "Anybody want bud? I got the flame..."

Since we are going to County in the morning, the search they did was minimal; knowing that we would be flushed inside and out by the diligent sheriffs brings out the laziness of the Chicago station rat. A minimal pat down, shoelace confiscation and into the cell. They even left us the money in our pockets.

"Once second, bro," Squeak says. "Bidness."

Squeak goes and haggles with the unseen dealer in the next cell. He returns minus a hundred bucks, with five fat dubsacks in small re-closable plastic packs, imprinted with hearts.

As we continue the conversation, he swallows the weed, packet by packet.

"Better than money on the inside, homes."

The line leading into Hell moves slowly. The progress is weary—stand, shuffle forward a few paces, sit back down on the concrete and wait. Eventually, though, we make our way to the huge doors that mark the mouth of the inferno.

"Don't worry, homes. You won't be here long. Bond'll be set 'round noon. Won't be no more than a couple hunnert. You be out by tonight... tomorrow tops."

But he is wrong. My preview of hell will last three days.

As we step up to the gatekeeper—an obscenely fat and red-faced sheriff who will take a peculiar and sadistic interest in me as the hours of this endless day pass—we are greeted with a mocking and hearty salute:

"Got us a lil ' two-toned couple here, boys!" the Pigman says and laughs. "It's a shame to break up such a cute pair!"

He unlocks us from the cuffs and sends Squeak on ahead.

I say goodbye to the sunlight and step through the door, stomach boiling with fear.

"Goddamn. There ain't nothing that sickens me more than a lil' scared white boy," Pigman grunts.

"Keep your fucking hands behind your back and your head down, shit—or I'll beat some respect into your skinny ass."

He shoves me hard into another line—another line in an infinite series of lines that await me, as I leave the world of air and light and embark upon my preview of Hell.

"Welcome to Cook County, ghost."

The search pen in Cook County jail is a graffiti-strewn concrete room that measures 25 feet by 25 feet and boasts length-spanning concrete benches that provide the minimum in human comfort. As we are passed in, we are marked with a number on our arms, in indelible black ink.

We are hustled into this pen and seated. A group of sheriffs glare at us, the Pigman among them. He tosses a plastic bowl onto the floor. As it rattles to a halt, another of his ilk begins what has the feel of an oft-spoken but still much loved speech:

"Listen up, you worthless pieces of dog shit. This is your last chance. Shoes off. Pockets emptied. Put everything in front of you, beside your shoes. We're gonna turn our backs. You have one minute to put any contraband in the bowl. One minute. Anything you're caught with after this means your ass."

I comply. I have no contraband. Beside my shoes I place 65 cents, a wallet containing three one dollar bills, an Illinois state ID and various scrap pieces of paper.

No one else places any contraband into the bowl either.

"All right, you fuckers. You were warned," Pigman says, perhaps pissed that there would be no rocks to smoke at break time.

The sheriffs busy themselves in bagging up our property and impatiently waiting for us to label it with the same number that was inscribed on our arms. Then we are patted down thoroughly. They then make us rip the soles of our shoes out, and poke around in them for a bit.

From somewhere, I hear an angry voice say "Motherfucker, these are 150 dollar Jordans...", and I turn to see a young gangbanger take a blow to the head. As he drops, several sheriffs get their licks in. They laugh, seemingly happy to have an example.

I shudder visibly. To the right of me sits an older man—a battered-looking Hispanic. He seems oddly calm, complacent, as if he's sitting on a beach somewhere enjoying the sun. He sees my reaction, and shakes his head.

"Don't worry. Just stay cool and it'll be OK. They're trying to break us. You know how to keep from getting broke, don't you?"

"How?" I ask.

"*Act broke*," he replies, and winks at me.

Long hours pass after the sheriffs leave, and the cons tell their stories. After a few dozen, I simply can't listen to anymore. Or tell mine anymore. I lie down on the cold concrete and close my eyes, trying to pretend I'm somewhere else.

What we are waiting on is a bond hearing. When it finally arrives, it is one of the most surreal experiences of my life—like something out of Orwell, made odder by my shot-to-hell nerves and lack of sleep.

Once again we are lined up, and taken one by one to stand in front of a video camera. Above the camera is a large color monitor. On this monitor is—I kid you not—a judge in full dress robes standing at a podium, looking at his own monitor on which my own bedraggled form appears.

Closed-circuit justice.

I am asked to say nothing and can understand not a word that is said—the volume is too low. Figures on the monitor interact, reading from files, mouths moving in garbled speech. The judge mumbles something, and bangs a gavel. I am hustled away from the camera and informed: "Your bond was set at 200 dollars."

I am returned to the pen and left to wonder if I hallucinated the entire experience.

We are at last fed. I haven't eaten since breakfast the day before... almost 30 hours. We are handed plastic bags that contain two cold bologna sandwiches on bread hard enough to hurt someone with; an apple; a small container of juice and a cookie. The juice is warm and the cookie is a bit stale, but I wolf it down and am grateful for it.

About an hour later we are herded from the search pen and deep into the guts of the jail. In my mind I imagine passing from the Second Circle into the Third—and I wonder what new horrors await. It's not long until I find out.

We are lined up against the wall and for some odd reason this moment is chosen to return our shoelaces—laboriously saved, sorted and numbered from the station house. It may sound odd, but after hours of walking in loose and ill-fitting shoes, the small luxury of shoelaces is enough to brighten one's mood.

Not that it lasts long.

I spot a piece of gravel on a bench. Incongruous—a little piece of outside here on the inside. I pick it up.

"What the fuck are you doing?" a Sheriff shouts, grabbing my hand and taking the piece of gravel.

"I just picked up a rock," I say.

"He probably thought it was a crack rock," Pigman laughs.

I actually laugh. "Yeah. What would that be... like a 200 dollar rock?"

My head is rocked back by a slap as Pigman nails me. "You mouthy little *shit*."

I swallow hard and fight down a wave of desperate hate.

"These motherfuckers always on some shit," says the guy who got thumped in the search pen.

"Shut that shit up," growls a Sheriff.

" Yo , pig... suck my fucking' dick!"

The Sheriff grabs him, smashing him against the wall, but this time he decides to fight back, and elbows backwards hard, catching the Sheriff in the nose and shattering it. Blood paints the hall.

In an instant, five sheriffs are on the boy, smashing, clubbing and spraying with pepper spray.

We all leap back, shocked, out of the way. "Holy fuck. Midget went *off!*" someone says.

Despite the beating and toxic chemicals, I am stunned by the fact that the little son of a bitch *wont give up*. He keeps coming back up—screaming, punching, kicking and cursing. In seconds, he has been reduced to a bloody and writhing mess on the floor, surrounded by uniformed thugs.

I feel sick to my stomach. I want to help him. I want to leap into the fight. I want to rip one of these concrete benches from the floor and shatter skulls and *hurt* these motherfuckers.

I am grateful that a gun does not magically appear in my hand. There would be five dead men on the floor, and an interesting news story about a violent incident and a dead white boy for the soccer moms on the evening news.

The boy is barely conscious when a stretcher from the infirmary arrives. He is loaded onto it like a sack of potatoes. As they carry him off, this young man—whose name I do not know—musters the

strength for one final act of defiance. He raises his hand, middle finger outstretched, like a salute to the men who beat him down.

Fuck you, pigs.

Until the day I die, I will carry that image with me in my head. I will think of it when I feel oppressed, as an image of freedom that may not be denied. Of defiance.

We are hustled into a vast and crowded room where we shall be interviewed, re-interviewed, numbered, re-numbered, categorized and classified again and again and again. Every move we make is ordered. Every step we take is approved.

All I can do is wish for a place to lie down, some quiet, and a few hours of sleep. It has become apparent that I will not be allowed use of a phone today, nor a shower. Fear and desperation create their own kind of stench, and I reek with it.

We are lined up yet again.

"What now?" I ask the guy next to me.

"Medical," he tells me. "Blood drawn, TB test, and the Dick Doctor."

I go woozy. I have a fear of needles that has been with me since childhood. I see static at the edges of my vision and bite down on my tongue to keep from fainting. Somehow, I remain conscious.

"What the hell is the Dick Doctor?" I ask.

"Well, you whip out your dick, and they jab a q-tip into the hole, twist it around, and pull it out." I am informed, in the tone of a man describing the proper way to hang a shower curtain. "It hurts like a son of a bitch."

We are processed through, like an assembly line. When I emerge from the other end, into what seems like the millionth cavernous room, I am humiliated, sore and shaking. For a moment, everything seems like a dream. A nightmare. I'll wake up in a minute, gasping, and the dark confines of my bedroom will materialize around me. I will snuggle up to my woman and wait for the images to fade from my mind. Maybe the baby will wake up in her typical good mood and we can go into the living room and play until she gets sleepy again...

I sit on the hard concrete bench and cry. I know it isn't going to happen. A man I met earlier pats me good naturedly on the back. "No worry," he says in his limited English. "It get better, bro." His name is Umberto.

We are fed again—another packet of bologna sandwiches. I force them down, too tired to even care.

A guy in the corner of the room freaks out suddenly. Delirium Tremens. He has been shaking all day, and sick. He suddenly begins screaming that he's going to kill himself, and starts smashing his head into the wall. He is subdued by other prisoners, then dragged away by the sheriffs to the psych ward.

"Fucking ass holes!" someone mutters.

Suddenly Pigman and his brethren are in the room. "Who the fuck said that? Huh? Who fucking said it?"

No one answers.

"All right, fucks. Up against the walls, palms flat. We're gonna play a little game."

We all comply. The sheriffs begin to make their way around the room. Some men they tap on the shoulder. Some men they playfully punch in the arm. Others though get a hard blow to the kidneys. "Who said it? Whoooo said it?" they keep asking.

Pigman catches me three times. Every pass, he catches me. And he laughs.

But the motherfucker only makes me scream once, on that third shot.

And nobody rats.

Eventually—whether they grow bored or are on some form of schedule—the sheriffs give up, and continue with their duties.

We are broken up into small groups, and lined up yet again. We are strip-searched, forced to lift and spread and perform a bizarre dance that I am actually numb to. It feels as if someone else is doing all of these embarrassing activities, and I am simply observing.

The groups continue to be broken into smaller units. We are given jail clothes—dirty beige. The outfit I'm given is a hilarious mismatch. The pants are at least two sizes too small, while the shirt balloons on me like a gown. It doesn't matter. I dress in my numbness, right side a blaze of fire, and follow instructions like a robot.

We are finally broken into pairs, and assigned temporary sleeping cells for the night. The idea of sleep seems like a golden, faraway dream. I do not allow myself to believe it full—since it may turn out to be a lie.

I end up paired with Umberto . “Worst part over now, bro. You see!” he says.

I simply nod, and hope like hell he’s right.

It turns out that, because of a lack of space, Umberto and I have been placed for the night in lockdown ward—where the trouble-makers go. This is where they pen the big mouths and the fighters, the prisoners caught with drugs or "weapon materials", with porno or gun magazines.

We are signed in and led to a cell. Curious eyes peer out from the meager slits of the cell doors as we pass. We are greeted.

"Yo, ghostie! Yo, ricky! Welcome to lockdown! You homies smoke? I got squares... one juice or one dessert for a square! You come see me, dawgs, hear?"

"Yo yo, fuck his cheap ass! I got two squares for a juice! Two motherfuckin' squares!"

The sheriff leading us ignores the greetings, as do we—not knowing what the hell to say. The thought of a cigarette makes my mouth water, though.

We arrive at the cell, and are ushered in. It's a tiny, L-shaped room with a toilet, a sink, a scratched and utterly non-reflective steel mirror, and two hard bunks. We are given one sheet and one blanket each. Then the door is slammed shut and auto-locks.

I take a piss, and am not surprised to see the bright red presence of blood in the urine stream. My right side aches like a rotten tooth—a deep seated throb that it seems I can almost hear. I think of the Pigman and grit my teeth in a rage so intense that I shake with it. I imagine hunting him through the wooded mountainsides of Kentucky, following his stinking spoor as he runs terrified through the unforgiving scrub of holly-bushes and stinging nettles, of finding him trapped at the base of a sheer, crumbling cliff face and approaching him, grinning, as I bring up my .308 for a clean neck shot...

I make up my bunk, wanting nothing more than to fall asleep and kill the hours until I can contact my family and set into motion the mechanics of being freed. I sit gingerly on the edge of the bed, trying to ignore the ache in my side.

Then the sing-a-long commences.

In lockdown at Cook County, the night always begins with a freestyle rhyme contest that continues into the wee hours of the

morning. The beat is provided by pounding on the echoing steel of the cell walls, the vocals by the lockdowners in a series. Each prisoner is allowed to rhyme as long as he doesn't break flow... and as long as his efforts are appreciated. If he flubs or gets repetitive, he will be shouted down and the guy in the next cell will start up. The entire process is competitive entertainment made interactive by the audience participation in cheering or shouting down each contestant.

And, those who don't compete are expected to contribute start-ups. One startup for each non-competing cell, worked out on a system that remains a mystery to me, but was no doubt honed by tradition. All I do know is that, on occasion, I would hear someone speak a few words, or be prompted to speak a few words, and the current competitor would launch into an intricate, usually quite violent and raucously sexual freestyle rhyme story—until he either grew tired or was shouted down.

I am beginning to drowse into sleep, despite the pounding and raised voices, when someone in the next cell thumps. " Yo! In the cell! Start up!"

I am silent. I really don't know what to say.

"Come on, ghost! Your turn, homey!"

From somewhere, the words come to me. It is not a conscious decision—it is pure emotion that speaks with my voice; and I hear it say:

> Oh lord, if hate were a gun
> You'd be dead and buried so deep.
> Your mother would cry,
> Your children would weep,
> but I would dance on your grave.

There is an odd silence. At first, I expect derisive laughter from the lockdowners. Then comes an answer, in a voice that echoes with respect, and I receive one of the finest compliments of my life. "Damn, dawg. That's some *cold-ass shit*."

The primitive, inescapable rhythm begins again—insistent and unstoppable, the primordial defiance of men beating on the walls of their own cages. A juggernaut of sound. A voice joins it—ragged but flowing, searching for the right pattern like a cat stalks a mouse. It finds it suddenly, with the audible click of a key in a lock, and I hear my own words taken and transformed, made solid and meaning drenched.

Others join in, in a lock-step pattern, variations on the theme, until a chorus of voices cry out in that same elemental act of defiance—a challenge tossed out to the captors by captives who refuse to lie down and shut up.

Oh lord, if hate were a gun
You'd be dead and buried so deep!
Your mother would cry,
Your children would weep,
but I would dance on your grave!

I look across the cell and Umberto is grinning at me. He says something to me in Spanish, but it's drowned out in the thunder of the rhyme. I wouldn't have understood his words anyway.

I lie down, exhausted and emotionally wasted. The storm of voices and noise around me seems to wrap me in a protective cocoon as I close my eyes. I am drifting into sleep, and it feels as if someone were turning the volume on a blaring stereo down very slowly.

The last thing I think of before slipping under is this: I will never hear a rap song again without knowing what it really is, deep in its fundamentally angry heart:

The battle cry of the defiant.

GHOST PART II

Sleep takes on a different meaning in jail. Sleep becomes an intermittent thing, something you dive in and out of, like a blissfully cool pool on a hot day. You surface to various sounds of reality: cell doors slamming, guards changing shift, boots clanging down a hall.

At 4:30 am breakfast arrives. The food is bland and cold, but I eat anyway. It's something to do. I save the juice for later. I'm dying for a cigarette.

I lie back in my bunk and stare at the graffiti covering the wall. It seems that there's not a single square inch that hasn't been marked, personalized, by the uncounted hordes who came before me. Most are gang signs and slogans. A few are religious affirmations and bible verses. One is a monotonous countdown to freedom, inscribed in a surprisingly precise hand with a felt-tip pen. "In 36 days, J.S.D. will be a free man!", "In 35 days, J.S.D. will be a free man!", "In 34 days, J.S.D. will be a free man!" and on and on, until it ends with, "TODAY I AM A FREE MAN."

I admire this unknown chronicler's tenacity, and silently wish him well.

Before I dive back into sleep I find a stub of pencil, wedged between the thin plastic coated mattress and the bunk frame. On the wall, I add my own contribution to the mosaic: "George Potter Loves Lily Elizabeth Potter, now and forever." I laugh at my own sentimentality. I wonder what those who come after me will think of it?

Hours later the door to the cell opening wakes me. "You boys can come on out," says a sheriff. "You aren't on lockdown. Phones are out here. You can get a shower. Smoke ' em if you got em ."

Umberto ignores him, snoring. I emerge with the saved breakfast juice. "Who's got a smoke?" I ask.

Instantly, a small auction ensues, as various cells try to win the 6-ounce prize. I end up with two hand-rolled cigarettes and a book with two matches. I later discover why the juice is so prized: it's used to make "hooch"—a crudely fermented alcoholic drink that is, in turn, used as currency by the inmates.

I discover that Umberto and I weren't the only newbies quartered in lock down. I greet two other faces I met in Receiving the day before.

They are using the two pay phones, and the shower is occupied, so I lean against the wall and fire up one of the cigarettes. Relief floods my nicotine-starved body and I relax, enjoying a slight buzz.

When the shower is free, I pass half the smoke to one of the guys on the phone. No sense in being stingy.

Hot water hits me like a blessing, washing away the stink of two days of fear and anxiety. I stand under the high pressure water and let it wash away the caked blood on my face, reveling even in the sting of the opened scratches.

I emerge, feeling much better. The torment of the Receiving process had stifled my spirit, but sleep, food, a cigarette and the luxury of hot water has revived it. I am ready to fight again.

But I will remember to act broke.

A problem presents itself: the phone company that provides service to my home does not allow collect calls as a matter of policy. It's a pre-paid, local-only service that allows 300 outgoing calls per month for a flat rate. I can't call home, and don't really know if there is much point. My family in Mississippi are internet junkies who log on at 11 am sharp every day—and it was 11:45 when we were let out of the cell. I try anyway, but get the expected busy signal.

"They'll put us on a permanent ward today, bro," I am told by a fellow temporary lockdowner, whose name is Robert. "They pop the doors at 8 am on permanent wards. You can call your folks then."

The thought of spending another night in jail is disheartening, but there's nothing to be done about it, so it's a waste of energy to bother with cursing my luck.

An hour or so later, Robert and I are hustled out of lockdown, and taken upstairs to a permanent ward.

I am nervous as we are ushered in, wondering what new situation I'll find myself in. My mind reels with possibilities. Will it be fighting gangbangers? Some rules-obsessed jail culture where newbies must be broken down, their food stolen and ghosts are reviled? Imagine my surprise when I discover a group consumed almost entirely in the peaceful practice of *capitalism*.

They call it "The Old Timers Ward", for two reasons. The first reason is that it's made up of men over the age of 40. The second is

that they are almost all men serving over 30 days—"old timers" in county jail parlance.

The lack of space in other wards has worked in my favor. A few see the two young faces enter and look suspicious. Most of them smile and nod politely. A man named Lamar—a grizzled-looking black man in his sixties—steps up and greets us.

"Welcome to the old timer's ward, brothers. Hope you get along here—and hope you don't have to stay too long, if you know what I mean." He grins. "Now, we got some rules here, intended to keep things peaceful. First rule is: If it ain't yours, don't touch it. Second rule is: If you make a mess, clean it up. Third rule is: If you a gangbanger, that shit gets left at the door… understand? Ain't no "nations" in here. Ain't no "crews". You is you and I is me. Understand? Shower's over there, phone's over there. Bible study is every night at 8 at table 7, if you interested. Now, you got any questions, you feel free to ask, hear?"

Slightly overwhelmed, I look around. The Ward is large—probably 100 by 30 feet. The lobby area is a communal space filled with objects that resemble nothing more than plastic picnic tables. Unlike the rest of the jail, the Old Timer's Ward is meticulously clean. No graffiti adorns the walls, no dirt marks the floor.

The residents of this ward also have a different look about them. They seem calm and peaceful. Laughter is the prevalent sound as they pass their time playing cards, dominoes and chess.

A man steps up. He hands me a cigarette, which I accept with thanks. "No problem," he says. "You look like you had it rough. First time in?"

Within an hour, I have the system down cold. These men are traders. It's the way they keep their sanity in captivity, and the unwritten law that keeps the peace. I discover that my ability to hand-roll cigarettes is a marketable commodity here—and I score myself the equivalent to a pack by trading my services. I roll an entire can of Bugler in half an hour. I am complimented both on my speed and the precision of the smokes I produce. I thank my older brother, who used to make me roll joints for him when he caught me snitching bud from his stash.

Everything is traded. Desserts for main courses, snacks for smokes, books for other books. I realize that you simply cannot kill the market.

It cannot die. You cannot destroy the desire to trade that which you value less for that which you value more. This basis for interaction, this mother of civilization, this primeval tool of society—will live in any environment, route around any block, and eventually it will prevail.

This is the thing that gives men hope.

I spend the rest of the day talking to Lamar over a few games of chess. He trashes me soundly each time. I don't mind.

"You believe in God, George?" he asks at one point.

"I don't disbelieve in God," I reply.

"Good enough," he says. "What *do* you believe in?"

"The market," I tell him, and explain what I've seen in his ward that strengthens that belief.

He considers it. "So you don't believe in that socialism ideal? That men should care about their fellow men more than money and such?"

I assure him that I do not. I explain that the first two rules of his ward are a powerful anti-socialist statement.

He thinks about this for a minute, then grins. "I guess you'd be right. Damn. I never thought of it that way."

Lockdown is called at 9 pm.

"Since they didn't assign anything, you can bunk in my cell," Lamar tells me. "Hell, I ain't had a celly in weeks. I probably forgot how to talk to people."

After the doors lock shut, Lamar asks, "You said you were born in Kentucky , right?"

"That's right."

"Well, I'd like you to meet another fine Kentucky gentleman, George. This is Jim." he says, pulling out a pint bottle of Jim Beam bourbon. We have a few shots, and I am polite enough not to ask him how in the hell he got whiskey into the jail.

I sleep soundly, and Jim chases the nightmares away.

As soon as the cell doors unlock the next morning, I am on the phone.

Before allowing the collect call to be accepted, the jail system informs the receiver in agonizing detail that, "This is a call from an inmate of Cook County Jail. All conversations are monitored."

"You OK, bro?" my brother answers.

I explain the situation, and ask him to get in touch with my woman, and inform her of the bail amount.

"Don't worry bro. If she doesn't have it or won't pay it, I'll make sure it gets wired up there, paid with a credit card or something. Call back in an hour and I'll let you know. Hey... they said this call was monitored, right?"

"Yeah."

"Good. *Listen up, you fucking pigs. If you touch my brother again I'll fucking come there and kill every goddamn one of you. I'll blow your fucking jail into rubble. I'll raze fucking Chicago to the ground!*

You are fucking with the wrong people!"

As I hang up, I have to laugh. Because I know he means it.

An hour later, I am relieved to hear that my woman is on her way to pay my bond. Apparently, she freaked out when she heard that I was in County. She had assumed that I was I-bonded from the police station the next morning and was simply pissed off and avoiding her. I do not know whether to believe this or not, but really can't muster the energy to care. Being set free is the only thing that matters to me. All other considerations are, for the moment, swept away.

When the sheriff calls out "Potter! You made bond!" I nearly scream with joy. Instead, I simply accept the congratulations of the Old Timers and say my goodbyes.

Robert makes bond a few minutes later, and joins me in the hall. "Soon as we're out, bro, we're hittin' Popeye's for some real food. Then I'll call my boy up and get us a ride."

The process of being released is nearly as time consuming as being taken in. It has a whole different feel, however, and the attitude is a polar opposite.

Three hours later, after a final agonizing lineup to receive our property, we step out of the doors of Cook County Jail—back into the sun.

We make our way a block up the street, to the Popeye's Chicken and Biscuits franchise. Robert phones his boy from the parking lot and gains us transportation. We walk into the nearly deserted restaurant and order.

As we are eating, two sheriffs walk in, on lunch break.

One of them is the Pigman.

Their laughter ends and their faces grow sullen. There they are, and here we are. In a place where they have no authority, no truncheon, and no backup.

I just grin at him. Grin and wolf down the greasy, delicious chicken. Staring. They order and wait for their food, eyes down. I will be pissing pink for the next two days.

"Might wanna stay clear of the Northwest side," Robert says casually, and winks. We laugh.

The sheriffs receive their food and scurry out. It may be petty, but I hope we ruined their fucking lunch. No doubt they wanted to eat it inside the air-conditioned comfort of the restaurant. But we prevented that. They can either stand in the sun or take their food back to the pit where they belong.

Sometimes the small victories are the best.

Robert's friend pulls up just as we finish eating, and we pile into a battered 87 Corolla. As we race through the streets, Robert tells the story of our time inside as if it were an action film, complete with brawls that never happened. I just nod, and enjoy the air from the rolled down window, and think about the Old Timers. I wish them a speedy release.

We arrive just off Division and Cicero, at a small, rather seedy used-car lot Robert's friend runs. Our reason for stopping is to "switch cars" because the Toyota is almost out of gas. Unfortunately, some crisis has come up and I sit waiting for awhile.

I am sick and tired of waiting. I say goodbye to Robert, tell him to look me up sometime, and head for home.

I find Cicero Avenue and head north, and I feel as if the sun is shining just for me, and that the air is especially sweet and clear. That grand river of cars takes on the aspect of poetry—chrome glint and windshield reflection a tribute to my perseverance, the muted roar of their passage as beautiful as a Strauss waltz.

When I arrive home there will be tears and apologies, and forgiveness will be begged. My daughter will stride up to me and punch me on the kneecap and try to look angry, before collapsing into a laugh and hugging my leg and saying, "Where you been, Dada?" There will be a cold six-pack in the fridge and a bath drawn and great

deference paid. It will be an illusion, but I will immerse myself in it nonetheless, and be grateful for it.

But I will not allow myself to be fooled. I will not allow myself to be pushed into captivity again. To return me to that cage they will have to beat the fight out of me and carry dead weight. They will have to make me a ghost in more than name.

I toss these thoughts aside as I stride down these Chicago streets, my healing face drawing stares, the smile I can't repress unsettling the drivers of cars and the people who glance out the windows of storefronts and happen to see me pass.

It is the smile of a free man, realizing that freedom is relative. It is a smile of the damned who have found forgiveness. It is the smile of the animal released from its cage.

The smile of a ghost, back in the land of the living.

STRAY DOG , PART I

I was a stray dog once, for a little over than a month. A cast-out, left to fend for myself without a home to crawl to when the dark fell or the rains came.

They call it being homeless; and it's almost a magic word in our society. I say magic because it conjures an illusion: a media-warped, guilt-drenched, sometimes sentimentalized illusion that holds no more reality than the stories of the Brothers Grimm.

The streets are not the sole domain of babbling old men and women, pushing shopping carts filled with assorted useless items. Oh, you'll find those men and women—and indeed they do often have shopping carts. But the items they transport are by no means useless. Most often it's aluminum cans, a silver treasure picked laboriously piece by piece from the streets and alleys of Chicago. Sometimes they find copper or cast aluminum—a real strike. It goes for substantially more than the low-grade cans.

These men and women are not lazy. They cover miles and miles in their treasure hunting.

"Why don't you hit the day labor places?" I asked one grizzled veteran of the can game. I talked to him often. He was always quick to share a smoke or a can of Old Style if he had one, knowing that I'd return the favor when I was on the ups and he was on the downs. I spent many a fine hour shooting the breeze and catching a buzz in an alley with a can hunter. Most often they were just stunned to meet a youngish white man who wasn't afraid of them, didn't think they were nuts, and expressed genuine curiosity about their lives.

He waved my question away. "Not worth my time," he explained. "No papers. All gone. Damn house burnt to the ground in '82 and the insurance butt-fucked me. 'Sides, half the time they got no work, other half they give it to the young folk, or the regulars, or the people with clean clothes!" He laughed at his own wit. "Nah. Better to do what I do. I got my routine. Sometimes the pickin's are good, sometimes they ain't. But what the hell. I'm keepin' my city clean."

And this was true. He and his peers did indeed keep the city clean. You're hard pressed to find a beer or pop can on Chicago streets—and not because of the diligence of the city's employees.

It’s because of the can hunters, who have found a niche in the market no one else wants.

The streets are not filled with hateful, violent dope addicts who will kill you for a dollar. Oh, the dope addicts are there—they're everywhere in the poorer sections of the city. Sometimes they are one and the same as the can hunters, more often they stay a bit straighter and work the day labor places. When it's nice out, they sleep in the park or under an overpass or in whatever little hole they can stake out. When it's nasty, they may have to share their stash to earn a bunk, or even waste precious dope and food money on an overpriced shit hole like the Hotel Elinor. They, like everyone, do what they can.

I count some of the kindest people I have ever met among the dope addicts. In my erratic tenure at the day labor companies of Chicago, I worked with many of them. Most of them are quite attentive employees. They want to do a good job and get the elusive "return ticket" that will guarantee them another day's worth of dope.

Heroin is the drug of choice in Chicago. It's called "blowz". A ten-dollar crack rock is smoked in an hour, and the buzz fades fast, and usually sends the addict back onto the street for another. Ten dollars worth of blowz will do a careful snorter the entire evening, with a bit left over to take the sick off the next morning. At the minimum wage, daily doled jobs provided by the companies, this allows careful junkies the ability to have a small room, groceries and keep their habits in line. "You don't want to splurge," I was informed. "All you're gonna do is get your tolerance up and kill your buzz in the long run. Plus—you keep it in line? When a dry spell in work or blowz hits, hell, you ain’t that dog-sick waitin' for it to blow over."

In my time as a stray dog, I was often given food by these junkies. Cigarettes. A couple of bucks for a beer. A joint. Enough quarters to do a load of clothes at the free dry laundromat.

Why? Rational self-interest, of course. Living on this level of the market is a study in cycles— very fast cycles—up and downs, good times and bad. When they were down and I was up, they knew I'd return the favor. And, once again, I cast no judgment upon them. I talked to them. I was interested in their lives and they were interested in mine.

Conversation is an art, and a skill. A good conversationalist has a place in the market.

You're probably wondering what the hell I was doing on the street in the first place. Why didn't I just call up the family and have them send me a bus ticket and get the hell out of there? That's a long and arduous ugly story, so I'll break it into the basics:

I met a woman. I moved to Chicago to be with the woman. We had a child. Suddenly it seemed that my purpose had been served and I was no longer the necessity I had once been. While I worked a steady job, I was tolerated. When I got laid off and hit the temp circuit—with it's random nature and built-in uncertainties—I became a liability.

Things got nasty. Things moved to an ugly head. I spent three days in Cook County Jail over a screaming match because I burnt a fucking steak.

That was it. I left.

Two problems presented themselves. I had no family in Chicago, few friends since the lay off, and nowhere to go. It was either head to the homestead, or stand on the streets.

And there was the baby. There was my Lily.

I remember leaving, and screaming at my ex:

"You can't fucking take my daughter away from me! I will live like a goddamn stray dog on the street before I let you exile me from her life! *Like a stray dog on the street, you bitch!"*

What it comes down to is a certain stiff-necked hillbilly pride. Match that pride with the love I hold for my daughter and you have a potentially lethal combination.

And that's how it happened.

One of the finest human beings I have ever known is a junkie. Dope addict would be a better word. He likes everything. Heroin, coke, weed, booze, cigarettes, coffee—if it alters the body or mind, he'll give it a go.

His name is Will, and he saved my life. He's a true gentleman and a virtuous human being.

Will is a huge black guy, 6'4 and 250 lbs... pure muscle. He was a star athlete in high school, and a very diverse one at that. Basketball, football, baseball—he played them all. But track and field was where he shined. He was an Olympic hopeful.

But then one day, in his senior year, he threw it all away. He had long been involved with a Chicago gang called The Vicelords, who used him as "muscle" and never expected him to sling on the corner as

his peers did. All they wanted was his appearance, his reputation, and his "allegiance."

Then he got into an argument over a girl. Shots were fired. A young man went into the ground, and Will went to prison at age 17.

His mother sold her house to afford a good attorney. His age kept him out of the chair, and the attorney kept him out of life imprisonment. He did 11 years and emerged from the State's hospitality far worse than he went in—almost 30, addicted, scarred, and with no chance of regaining what he once could have been.

But he was never bitter. He never blamed anyone other than himself for his life. He did not rail at the system. He did not blame "the white man." When I first gathered the courage to ask him what he spent time in the pen for, he responded, with no trace of irony: "Being a stupid motherfucker."

Will wanted one thing: to enjoy the rest of his life, to neither harm anyone or be harmed. He found a stable, hardworking woman and married her. He found a job in a warehouse and did his damndest to do it to the best of his ability. That's where we first met.

When you work as a temp, you learn very quickly about elitism and the simple minded prejudices that arise when a group believes themselves to be a part of this imaginary elite.

As temps, we were treated as decidedly second class by most of the regular workers. Much of this was simply laziness: regular workers saw a chance to make someone else do their normal routine and seized that chance. Some of it can be attributed to the formerly powerless finding a drop of power and grabbing at it, almost as a novelty. But most of it was pure, unadulterated prejudice and pre-conception: day laborers were the dregs of society. Crack heads, junkies, probably illiterate, most likely thieves who needed to be watched closely and shown no trust.

Never mind that the temps worked their asses off. Never mind that we just stuck to the job, tried to get the day to pass and get the hell home. Never mind that many of the temps were retired servicemen or seniors on pensions or SSI and were just out to get a few extra bucks in their pockets. Prejudice and preconception are powerful traps, and few escape them.

But Will was different. Maybe because he had worked his share of temp jobs after being released from prison. Maybe because he knew

what it was like to be looked down on for a situation rather than any real failing. But I think—to hell with that, I know—that it went deeper than that. Will was unprejudiced. Will liked people. All kinds of people. He liked to talk about things. He liked to be challenged rather than agreed with. He appreciated hard work and he appreciated people with knowledge that he lacked and wanted them to impart that knowledge to him.

I lucked out by being assigned to help him. We loaded trucks all day long, heavy boxes of trade goods from all over the world. It was always heavy and the routine was always the same. You set up a rhythm and you knock the trucks out, one by one, moving down a line of dock doors like a machine.

The only thing you can do is talk.

I talk. I love to talk. Send me to hell and I'll try to strike up a conversation with the Devil. Stick me in a room with people who's language I don't speak and I'll try and communicate with hand signals.

So we got to know each other. This was when the troubles were really starting up at home, and I told him about it. He commiserated. His wife was a hard-headed, argumentative type as well. We'd sneak out behind the warehouse and smoke a joint on lunch break, and bitch about women; about the heat; about the fifteen trucks we had left to load. It was a bright spot in my life at the time. Will is an honest, direct, almost painfully blunt person. He talked about his time in prison. He talked about the drugs he enjoyed with no shame or excuse making. It delighted him that I simply shrugged and told him he had every right to live his life the way he wanted. I briefly explained anarchism to him. He just nodded and said, "Makes sense."

When the temp job ended, I was genuinely sad to go. I figured I would never see my friend again.

Little did we know that his job was about to end as well. September 11 damn near shut O'Hare down; and the warehouse he worked for depended on the airport for a large chunk of it's business. When the business dried up, so did Will's job. When I met him again, he'd be living on unemployment.

But he was still willing to take in a stray dog.

STRAY DOG, PART II

I had been on the street for about a week, but things weren't actually that bad. I was still getting fairly regular work at the one-day labor place within comfortable walking distance; a fairly open-ended assignment working in the main distribution center for Marshall Field's. Every morning I'd make it to the cattle call to get my ticket—had to be there at 5 am or lose out. The shift, however, didn't start until 8 am, so I had some time to kill.

I'd make the trip up Kilbourne to my former apartment, bang on the door and wait to be let in so that I could spend a little time with my daughter. The amount of time I was able to spend with her pivoted on one variable—the mood of her mother. If she was in a good mood (or wanted to take a long bath, go shopping, etc.) I might be able to play with Lily until the bare last few minutes before I had to be at work. If she was in a bad mood, I might not be able to spend more than fifteen or twenty minutes with my kid before insults, accusations and other unnecessary bullshit started to fly and I had to bail. Some mornings she'd be in a black rage and refuse to even let me in; most often though, the combined actions of the dog (who missed me) and the baby we're enough to force her to let me in.

(I'll never forget the morning my ex stood in the doorway, refusing me entrance, moronically claiming that Lily "didn't want to see me", and my gorgeous year-and-a-half-old child literally battered her way around her mother, popped out onto the front porch and said "Hiiiii!!" with the most beautiful smile you have ever seen...)

But no matter what, I always loved this time of the day—it was worth all the uncertainty and aggravation of staying on the street just to play with that kid. Crawling around on the floor, throwing stuffed animals at the dog, letting her "type" on the computer, watching her dance along with the Teletubbies on TV...

I never wanted kids. Ever. I knew that it was one responsibility that—once undertaken—was a lifetime commitment. You can't divorce your kids. You can't break up with them. You owe them.

But when I knew my daughter existed—from the very moment that I knew she was in the world, growing and forming and developing in the maniacal explosion of life that is the beginning of us all—I loved her. I did not expect this love. It took me by utter surprise, hamstrung

me, and left me helpless. There was never a question of abortion. EVER. Such a thing seemed... evil. Black and evil and wrong and disgusting and maddeningly incomprehensible. It was from that moment that the debate over abortion, in my mind, ceased to become a debate—at least so far as my own moral universe was concerned. I do not understand how a feeling human being can see ultrasound pictures of a two month old fetus—the helpless, dependant child they have created—watch it wiggle and play with its toes and smile... and then have it excised, evicted, destroyed in cold blood. The very thought seems inhuman to me.

I do not accept that the State has the right to tell people they cannot abort children. I do not accept that the State has the right to interfere or legislate morality in any way, shape or form.

But I can, by god, define what I will and will not accept as moral. I can judge people to the point of whether or not I consider them worthy of my goodwill. I judge them by their acts.

And abortion is the act of murder. My daughter taught me that.

Working at the Marshall Field's distribution center was a blast. Hard work, without a doubt, but good people to work with. The difference between a "sweat shop" and "a hard job" is ridiculously slim and intangible: appreciation. Hard work appreciated is vastly different than unappreciated.

Once again, I was working with trucks... unloading rather than loading, this time, and much larger: 48' tractor trailers.

When one has a boring job to do, one finds ways to amuse oneself. Believe it or not, there's a deep satisfaction in being part of a two-man team and completely unloading three 48-footers before the end of a shift. To get that flow going and settling into the routine also causes the day to pass. This is not to be derided.

I was well treated by the regular employees of Field's—even the general manager occasionally stopped to tell me that I was doing a good job. I also became friends with his assistant, a young lady in her mid-twenties named Angie. To look at her, she was a prototypical suburban Chicago-land yuppie gal. Blonde, perky, college educated, pro-active personality, constantly optimistic. You could almost imagine her in cheerleading outfit and pompoms, yelling "Go team go!" But, beyond that surface, she was another unprejudiced human soul. She was fiercely protective of "her" temps—and refused to allow

any discrimination. A few of the regulars took offense that the temps were invited to a "Good job" lunch buffet. Angie immediately called an informal meeting and stated flat out that if the temps weren't welcome then there would be no buffet.

"These guys come here everyday and outwork most of you for half the money. They are entitled to the same thanks you are. I don't want to hear another word about it."

Because of Angie, I got a plum assignment. Every six months, Field's has an Employee sale, the proceeds of which go to various charities. All of the overstocks, misstocks, manufacturers' samples and seconds are sorted and laid out flea-market style in one of the show rooms. All clothing items are one dollar. All appliances and kitchen utensils are three dollars. All electronics are five dollars. The competition to be on the sorting detail is fierce—because the sorters are given first choice at the goods, and the deals to be had are mind-bending.

It was apparent from the moment I started working that the regular workers were insulted to have a temp in their midst. After a while, I gave up trying to charm these morons and just did my job.

Then I found the jacket.

It was gorgeous. I am not a materialistic person. The idea of paying a hundred dollars for a pair of shoes is ridiculous to me. The idea of paying 500 dollars for a leather jacket is just as ridiculous. Not that I don't admire the objects in question, or think less of those willing to pay these prices for them. It's simply that I'd rather spend the money on other things... things that other people may well consider "ridiculous" themselves.

But when I saw the jacket, I was smitten.

It was a brand new, untouched, still in the plastic Kenneth Cole leather. Black as sin. Silk lining. It was the most beautiful item of apparel I have ever laid my eyes on.

"How much would this be, Ang?" I asked.

She grinned. "A dollar. Want me to put it up for you?"

"Please." I was more than a little stunned. The retail tag on the sleeve read $575. I've bought cars for less.

Word spread quickly. The jacket was the find of the sale, the diamond in the vast pile of items we were sorting through. If my reception had been frosty before, it was downright arctic afterwards. I

didn't care. I almost reveled in their outrage. "Too slow, motherfuckers!" I wanted to brag.

At the end of the day, I heard one of the regulars approach Angie and ask, "You're not going to let that temp have that jacket, are you?" in tones of righteous indignation.

Angie blasted her. "Yes I am. He found it. He paid for it. It's his now. End of story."

I thank her for her fairness. But it ended up costing me the temp assignment.

You see, although Angie requested the temp workers, it was up to the agency to determine who went each morning. And, apparently, one of the folks I "insulted" with my "impertinence" was friends with the lady who handed out the tickets.

To make a long story short: I got the jacket, but I never received another ticket to Marshall Field's for temp work. And—since Field's was the only place regularly hiring—I soon found myself out of work completely.

And, dammit, I didn't even get to keep the jacket long.

So there I was, jobless, homeless and soon to be broke. At least I was warm, and hell, I looked sharp!

A few days after I found the jacket, I stumbled back onto Will. I was walking to my favorite Taco joint, a little family-owned place on Armitage and Kenneth, when someone said "Hey whiteboy, what you doin' in this neighborhood?"

I turned around and there sat Will, smoking an unfiltered Pall Mall on the stoop of a two flat, grinning at me. It turned out that he lived there. All this time, and he lived no more than 6 blocks from me.

We caught up. I learned about his loss of a job, and that the tranny in his car had gone out. His wife was still working part time at a hospital, and he was receiving unemployment—so things were pretty good for him.

He learned about my situation and got serious.

"Where the hell are you sleeping?"

I explained. On nights when it wasn't too cold or raining, I slept in the park. The worst that had ever happened was a cop telling me, "You can't sleep here, son." I didn't argue... I just walked to another park and went back to sleep. When it was nasty out, I generally snuck onto the ex's back porch and slept in the lawn chair there.

"We can't have that shit," Will said. "You can stay with us."

But there was a problem. And the problem was named Candace.

Candace was Will's wife. And she disliked me immediately. I don't know if it was because I was southern, or because I took attention away from her when I was around. Doesn't matter. She didn't want me there and that was that. Will got pissed, and told me to ignore her. I refused. He asked me why and I tried to explain.

"First of all, this is her house. Yes, I know it's your house too, and that you're willing to put up with shit in order for me to stay. I appreciate that. But all it's going to do is cause trouble. This is her property and—in her mind—I would be a trespasser. That would make me a trespasser in my mind as well.

"Second – You may be able to put up with it bro, but I sure can't!"

He argued with me. I argued back. It puts you in an odd place to argue for your own expulsion. Trust me.

We finally settled on a compromise. I would stay in the basement—a place Candace never, ever went. There was a mattress down there, and the piping for two furnaces kept it warm at night. There was electricity and running water. Luxury! I would clear out at dawn and return at dark.

The next few weeks settled into a routine. Get up, go look for work, play with the baby, wander the streets, come home to the basement, try to sleep. I got to the point where I had to walk the blocks to my former home and say "Goodnight, Sweetie" to the dark windows before I could fall asleep.

No work, no money, living in a basement. My very slim savings were soon tapped. Will, despite his unemployment check, couldn't be expected to feed me, of course—especially given the fact that he'd have to sneak the food down to me. His extra money went for drugs, to be blunt—as was his decision and business. Most of the time he was as broke as me.

I finally reached the point where I couldn't put it off any more. The only thing of real value that I owned was the jacket. I at first attempted to sell it to the people I knew. They either weren't interested or were broke. No good.

"I know where we could sell it," Will told me.

"Where?"

"West side," he replied. He meant, of course, at the west side street

drug emporium sometimes called "The Mall."

"OK. If we can sell it for fifty, I'll give you ten for a bag, and I'll have eating and cig money."

We shook hands, and headed out.

The Mall is a 10 square block chunk of Chicago devoted entirely to selling drugs. Pot, coke, crack, blowz, pills... whatever strikes your fancy is available on an almost 24 hour basis. The amount of cash money that moves through this area is unknown to me, but undoubtedly vast. Dealers stand on every corner, two and three deep, asking "You straight?" to every passer by.

We walked up Cicero to Iowa, and headed into the mall like missionaries into the great dark continent. Will was a regular here, but I was an unknown—and white. I was a bit nervous, to say the least.

"Don't worry. You're gonna look a little funny, but it'll be alright. The guys here are just doin' business, just like us. Besides—if they wanna fight you, they're gonna have to fight me too. If one of us gets his ass beat, the other gets his ass beat. You cool?"

I assured him that I was. He laughed. "You're bullshittin'. But don't worry. Business is business."

He slipped on the jacket. We had decided it would be less tempting to try and steal it from him. Where it was a little too large for me, it was a little too small for him. "Damn. It's a shame to sell this bitch. It's nice. Oh well."

We stepped up to the first little group of dealers, and Will went into his spiel... one that would grow smoother as the evening progressed.

"What's up, playa? Me and my partner here are trying to get rid of this jacket... it's a 500 dollar Kenneth Cole, but we'll let it go for a hundred... what you say?"

The West Side Mall is a vast and living organism, the free market barely restrained, with its own intricate workings and internal mechanisms.

It is coming on dark, and we've had no luck yet. The jacket still rides on Will's back and my pocket is still empty. It's odd, because it's obvious that most of these very young and very style-conscious dealers *want* the damn thing.

As ever, tossed into a new environment, I become fascinated by my surroundings. I have seen such environments portrayed in film and

fiction countless times, of course—they are a staple of the American entertainment industry and a modern cliché.

Once again, reality gives lie to the illusion of the collective opinion.

We are not surrounded by surly, menacing thugs blasting rap music and forcing their wares on hapless suburban teens. We are surrounded by laughing, shit-talking young people who wrestle, chant mocking freestyle rhymes at each other from across corners and cheerfully ask, "Yo dawg? You straight?" to anyone who passes by.

The streets are not littered with garbage and waste—they are amazingly clean; cleaner in fact than many of the "rich, white" neighborhoods I've passed through.

I am surprised by the number of very small children darting here and there, inside houses and back; laughing, yelling and playing the same as children everywhere. A few minutes of observation shows me what purpose they fill: a wad of bills is slickly passed from a dealer to the small girl who's probably his baby sister, and she makes fast tracks into a nearby house. The kids are the money line: in the event of a dealer being arrested, he won't be nabbed with stacks of cash for the cops to confiscate—may even be able to play off the few rocks/bags on his person as "personal use" and avoid a dealing charge. Smart.

Family business is the oldest tradition of all. It lives on the streets of Chicago.

"Sissy, get your ass out here!" calls out one dealer, his bald head gleaming in the yellow phosphor glow of the wakening street lights. He is dressed only in a Tommy windbreaker, and shivers in the dropping temperature. We step up to him just as he hands off a bundle of money to the little girl who appears from a house and says grumpily, "Don't yell! Momma's tryin' to watch TV! I ain't your slave, and it's almost time for the Simpsons!" But she flashes a smile at me before she retreats.

"Yo. Ya'll straight?" Tommy jacket asks as we stop.

"Hey playa, me and my partner here are trying to get rid of this jacket. It's a 500-dollar Kenneth Cole, but we'll let it go for 75, cause we're hurtin'." Will repeats. The price has dropped because we're getting tired. "You look like you could use it, man," he adds.

Tommyjacket stares at the leather with something approaching lust. "Goddamn that's nice, man." He thinks. "I'll give you five rocks for it."

"Naw man. We need eatin' money. Gotta be cash."

Tommyjacket looks pained. He fishes in his pocket and pulls out a crumpled 10. "Five rocks and a sawbuck?"

"Can't do it, playa. Sorry. Might catch you on the way back." We depart, leaving Tommyjacket to curse himself for being broke.

The quest continues.

About twenty minutes later we approach a lookout stationed by an alley. He's watching for cops, and directing lost souls to their drug of choice like a talking information kiosk. When he sees Will, his eyes light.

"Cheetah! Long time, man!"

Will grins. It turns out that it's an old buddy from prison. They chat momentarily, about the old, bad times. "Cheetah" was Will's nickname since high school—a testament to the speed he could attain in the dash.

While they chat, I attempt to make myself as invisible as possible. I have been shown no overt hostility or dislike, but the possible scent of "narc" hangs around any white guy who wanders the hood not actively buying dope.

Across the street, I observe a young suburban couple pull up in Daddy's SUV and try to buy a bag of blowz. The dealer, annoyed, tells them to get the hell out of the car to speak to him. Will has explained this to me. If you come to buy, you come walking, or you get ignored. It's simply too easy to snag the merchandise from the dealer's hand and haul ass out of the Mall.

The couple complies, and I size them up. They fit a type—'rich white trash' I've heard them called. Skinny, well dressed and haggard. It's actually hard to tell the male from the female, doubly hard because they both sport short spiky hairstyles. Their faces are haggard and puffy, and their eyes shine with fear and distaste at being in such a shitty neighborhood.

Oh... but the junk calls them. It calls them in a sweet voice impossible to resist, the siren song of sun dreaming opium poppies, distilled and made darkly angelic.

This couple has never had to find the discipline that the street-level junkie learns. Money is no object to them, so they indulge in ever increasing binges. Binges that will, sooner or later, leave them dead and white on some spotless suburban hospital slab, as their weeping

inattentive parents identify them and wonder, "How could it happen to people like us?"

They cop, and climb into Daddy's immaculate Lincoln Navigator. As they do, they spot me. One of them points, and they laugh. They see the pale face, the knit cap, the worn clothes and the filthy jacket that was once suede but now more resembles a crumpled grocery bag, the tired eyes and the scraggly beard that weeks of inattention has grown.

They laugh, and feel superior. *"At least we aren't street trash like that!"* I can almost hear them say. A brief anger passes through me, but it dies quickly. I am broke, homeless and desperate—but I do not live for hedonistic appetites. I am not the slave of my selfish nervous system. My spinal cord does not rule me.

I myself may be dead on a slab in a year. But I will be there because someone or something put me there; someone or something put me there and I fought and scratched and bit and stabbed and shot to the best of my ability to stay off that fucking slab, to breathe and see and observe and struggle. I did not put myself there. I did not give myself over to something else and let it kill me.

I am free. I will be free or I will be dead.

I smile to myself, and turn, glancing down the alley. The lookout and Will are still busily chatting, and the man has momentarily ignored his job. The wrong moment.

Moving up the alley, headlights off, comes the predatory and instantly recognizable shape of a police car. I feel a small explosion in my brain—something very like electricity races through my body. It seems as if every hair on my neck stands straight up. From some deep well of instinct, without thought, I call out: "Pigs!"

The reaction is amazing. People simply disappear... as if melting into shadows. In the space of three seconds, the street is clear. Deserted... as empty as a small town on Sunday morning. When the cop car idles onto the scene, the only people to be found are Will, the lookout and myself. We had nowhere to go, after all.

The pigs idle over to us. "You boys clean?" the lookout whispers.

"As a whistle," Will replies. I just nod.

The cops, no doubt disappointed, decide to hassle us. We do the only thing it is possible to do in such a situation: we grin and bear it. Will, especially, shows a talent for making fun of the pigs without

actually insulting them. During the pat-down, he remarks, "Damn, you get any friendlier I'm gonna have to buy you dinner, Officer." This gets me laughing, eliciting the question, "And what are YOU doing here, boy?"

I say the first thing that pops into my mind: "I'm a tourist, sir. THEY told me that this was The Art Institute. Are they messin' with my head?"

Will and the lookout crack up. Even the other cop hides a grin. Chicago police are amongst the lowest forms of life on the planet, second only to Cook County Sheriffs—but I suppose even fruit flies might be possessed of a sense of humor on occasion.

Finding nothing to hassle us about any further—and no doubt missing the security of free coffee and donuts at the nearest White Hen—the cops depart like sulky children who can't find anyone to play their game of choice.

"Thanks, cuz," the lookout tells me. "You saved my ass."

Slowly but certainly, the dealers return to the street, the children re-emerge, and lights come back on. As Will and I return to our quest, I realize something:

The people who live in areas such as this don't see the police as anything but an impediment to daily life. The peace is kept, not by uniformed officers, but by the very people those officers are sworn to destroy: the gangs.

The gangs are the reason that you can safely walk these streets. The myth of violent gang-warfare is a reality of isolated incidents that the police have done nothing to prevent. I have been told by many, and believe, that any gangbanger who takes out a bystander during "action" has more or less forfeited his own reputation, his rank, and—most likely—his life. The city is as inter-related as society gets. That bystander no doubt has a relative from the same, or another, gang who is now honor-bound to hunt down and execute the clumsy bastard. And his fate will be neither mourned nor acted upon. The bullshit myth of a car full of thugs indiscriminately spraying neighborhoods with machine-gun fire is just that—a bullshit myth. Turf is respected, business districts almost holy. If some fool acted stupid in another nation's hood, he is thought to deserve what he gets. If his "boys" want to take action, they certainly can—but they will have *zero* backup from the higher-ups of their organization.

Most gang-related violence is perpetrated for one reason only—to take down police informants. Remove the police... but you can follow the logic, can't you?

Gangs are private law. They are about money and taking care of their own. They have consistent rules and procedures.

In short—they work.

My instinctive shout has paid off, big time. Word travels up these streets like light, carried on the cell phones. The sense of mistrust is gone. I am now greeted as "cuz" and my hand gets shook at every stop.

Fifteen minutes later, the jacket sells—for 100 bucks, not 75. I don't know, and can't prove it, but I believe that word came down from on high. "Buy that jacket. That white-boy is good people."

And fuck... it *was* a nice jacket.

Will and I are triumphant. As we march out of the Mall, we get him a bag and a five-dollar sack of weed. I roll a celebration joint up and we catch a buzz as we wait for the Cicero bus. We grab up some groceries and a few quarts of beer.

Just before we get back to his house, we are stopped by a goofy kid in a car. He asks: "Where the weed at?" Just the type who's too scared to venture into an all-night venue like The Mall himself—scared by cartoon TV and newspaper bogeymen.

"Right here!" I say, and sell him my pinched nickel bag for ten bucks.

You have to love the market....

It's not long after that I realize that I was undertaking an exercise in futility. There was no work–the day-labor places are no longer hiring. They don't even accept new applications.

My time with my daughter has steadily grown both shorter and more painful. The ex was vicious in her criticism. She called me a gutter bum, a reject hillbilly that had finally been given his due. She seemed to take a perverse enjoyment in my weight loss, in my disreputable appearance, in the bags under my eyes and the exhaustion of my movements.

Then one morning I arrived to find her subdued. She was actually pale. She had even made me breakfast. I was—to say the least—stunned.

"Your mother called. She wants you to call her," was all she said. But it explained everything.

My family is something of an oddity in today's society. We are fiercely loyal and lethally protective of our own. Not having heard from me, my mother had undoubtedly surprised the ex and—once learning of my situation—had told her exactly what she thought, in no uncertain terms.

My mother is a small, gracious, very kind woman. She loves animals and children. But endanger her child and she will smile as she casually puts a bullet in your brain. What she said to my ex is still unknown to me to this day. In many ways, I don't want to know.

I was instructed (not "asked") to call my sister in Florida. I did so, and arrangements were made for a bus ticket. When I hung up the phone, I just looked at the ex and said, "You win."

Saying goodbye to my Lily was the hardest thing I have ever done. I picked her up, hugged her hard, and said the two words I dreaded saying.

When I cried, she reacted to comfort me. She wiped my eyes and said, "No cry, dada. No cry."

Easier said than done.

Even the ex shed a tear when I left. She is not an evil woman, just angry. Just judgmental and self-righteous. I loved her with all my heart once, and in many ways, I love her still. Human nature is the stupidest fucking rube who ever stepped onto a carnival ground, don't you think?

It was almost as hard to say goodbye to Will. What can you say about a guy who was willing to take you in without any question of gain, and make his own personal life a living hell in order to back that decision up?

You don't say anything, except "Thank you, bro," and you move on.

I packed the few clothes and books and pictures I had brought to the basement, and I made the last walk to the bus stop. I took the city bus to the California el and the el to as close to the downtown bus station as I could get.

As I climb onto the bus and stash away my belongings, as I plop into the uncomfortable seat that will only grow less comfortable as the 30-hour ride wears on, I feel like an absolute and total failure. I am tired—the sort of tired that permeates the bones. I am angry. I am

depressed. I think of my little girl's face and fight back sobs. No use. As the bus pulls out of the station and every second takes me farther and farther away from her, I cry. I weep, hunched over, fighting the emotion, hating myself and the whole world, humiliated in front of strangers who ignore me. I cry until it's all gone, and I feel nothing but the numbing exhaustion and the onset of hunger that I'll just have to ignore.

Cried out, I fall into sleep. I awake hours later, somewhere between Gary and Indianapolis. I am confused, hungry and still upset. But the depression has lifted. For whatever reason, I can think of my little girl and smile now. "No cry, dada." *Yes, my love. I'll try. For you.*

I have lost everything that I had acquired in the past five years. All gone, blown away to nothing. Blown into memory and regret. Or have I?

I am still alive. I am still intelligent. I am still possessed of a mind and an able body. I still have the capacity to alter the world with honest work. I still have my sense of self and the knowledge of the truth that comforts me in the worst moments.

I am a free man. Nothing can take my freedom—no illness, no bad luck, no set back, no circumstance. My freedom can not be stolen by thieves. My freedom can not be voted away or seized by The State. Because it is not a thing. It is not a possession.

My freedom is a truth, that holds out deep inside my mind and heart.

They can kill me, but they cannot enslave me.

A piece of an old song came to me, a verse that had long haunted me but now took on greater significance. I had always admired it. But now I understood it:

In the clearing stands a boxer
and a fighter by his trade
and he carries a reminder
of every glove that's laid him down
or cut him till he cried out
in his anger and his shame:
"I am leaving, I am leaving -
but the fighter still remains..."

As the bus hurtles forward through the darkness of Indiana, I stare out the window and allow myself to be lulled by the hypnotic passage of field and forest; by the soothing drone of the great diesel engine that pushes me forward from past into future. I relish my freedom.

I may be returning to the place I started, but I am not returning empty-handed. I return stronger, wiser, with eyes wide open and stories to tell.

Later, I will tell my story to a talkative gentleman who will take pity on "that poor kid" and buy me some lunch at a meal stop. Once again, I have been reassured of the innate decency of the average human being. We are all fellow travelers. We are all running from the past into an uncertain future. Some of us are on the ups, some of us are on the downs—and it's better to give a damn when you have the chance rather than be damned when your turn on the downhill side comes.

Sometimes, after all, we are all stray dogs.

"...polite society"

I was given my first gun at the age of seven.

It was a Savage Arms .22/.410 over and under, one of the sweetest most functional firearms ever designed and mass produced, perfect for a kid. To me, raised around guns, taught to shoot from the day I was big enough to steady and aim, it was almost like some futuristic artifact dropped by a time-traveler as he passed on his way to some far more interesting era in the past. Small, compact, sized just right for me; perfect for squirrel, rabbit and game birds, not to mention the ongoing holy crusade against the diabolical tin cans and beer bottles that my younger brother and I seemed to be constantly waging.

Without a doubt, the idea of a 7-year-old owning a gun will send liberals (and many so-called 'conservatives' and 'libertarians') into spastic fits of sheer horror. The admission that I was allowed to keep this 'awful weapon' in my own room, carry it with me on my daily jaunts through the forested hills, and was expected to assume full responsibility for it's use, upkeep, and maintenance would no doubt push them over the edge into death-shock.

But it really wasn't that big of a deal. I was, after all, up to the task.

For I was raised in a polite society.

I was raised in an armed society.

The concept that my father fought hard (and successfully) to instill in his children's heads was that guns were simply tools. To be neither romanticized or demonized. One may as well feel romantic notions or fear towards a screwdriver, a shovel, or a post hole digger. All were simply tools fashioned by humans to aid themselves and other humans in the pursuit of a goal. An intelligent man, my father maintained, used all tools responsibly and efficiently. A mishandled firearm could accidentally take off a toe, just as a mishandled post hole digger could. Like a gun, a screwdriver could be used to morally defend oneself from an attacker or immorally attack someone. Neither would be very efficient, though.

Before trusting me with a gun to call my own, my father carefully watched me. He explained the principles of safe firearm use basically and seriously. Then he observed my actions and judged my competence accordingly. He made sure I did not play with the firearm. That I understood that this was not a toy for my amusement, just as

the gleaming and beautifully cared for steel box of Craftsman tools he kept in his work shed were not toys. I was allowed to use those as well—with the knowledge that a single incidence of returning one dirty, chipped or otherwise abused would ban me forever.

My father observed me. He saw that I never pointed a gun at anyone. That I always double checked the safety before handing the firearm to another. That I understood exactly what he meant when he said that there was 'no such thing as an unloaded gun'. He saw that I actually liked cleaning and maintaining the firearm. And he judged me responsible enough.

Not love, but respect.

Not fear, but respect.

One summer day when I was ten or so, I walked the mile and a half of dirt and gravel bed road from our property to the paved two lane blacktop that was the closest county road. I set off down the overgrown side of the 'highway' (as we called it) towards a friend's house, looking forward to a day spent tramping the woods, fishing, and hopefully bringing home a jack or two to make jerky from. In addition to the snake (where I'm from, any small caliber over/under is referred to as a 'snakecharmer'), I toted a short pole with a Marlin 33 reel, a thing that had once been a sewing kit but now served as a miniature tackle box, and front pockets filled with .220 Swifts and .410 shells.

As I ambled, most likely daydreaming about a sudden alien invasion and my own self being called upon to fight off the vile creatures, I heard a car pull to a stop behind me and let out a friendly double toot of the horn.

I turned, and saw a Dickenson County Sheriff's car shutting off, and an impressively uniformed deputy emerging from the vehicle. He waved and started towards me. Being a polite kid, I waved back and reversed to meet him in the middle.

I felt no fear, of course. I even recognized the guy as a person my dad called 'Tiny' even though he was a six-foot plus bull-weight fellow who's badge read “J. Rice”.

“Mornin', Son!” he said. “You're Sam Potter's boy, right? Middle boy.” He searched for the name “George?”

"Yes sir," I told him, delighted as any child when an adult remembers his name.

"Is that a Savage Arms over/under?" he asked, his voice resonating in something like awed curiosity.

"Yessir, it is," I said, nodding. I was used to this question. I was a little too young to understand that my little firearm was damn near a relic—and an almost universally respected piece of high-class human engineering.

"Damn, she's a beaut. Perfect condition." Deputy Tiny paused, then asked, quietly, "Mind if I check her out?"

Of course I didn't! I loved it when adults went apeshit over this piece of property that was mine, all mine. I passed it to the officer.

He examined it, eyes filled with pure interest. He looked like a kid himself at the moment. "It's a '23. Gawd-DAMN." He broke her open and sighted up the barrel. "And clean as a whistle. You clean her yourself?"

I may have rolled my eyes. "Yessir," was all I said.

Deputy Tiny chuckled. "Course you do. I know ol' Sam. Known him since I was a kid. Hell, he took me out drinkin' when I turned 18." He stopped there; perhaps afraid he was imparting information that wasn't quite proper.

He paused, and I could have guessed his next question.

"Mind if I fire off a couple?" The Deputy looked almost embarrassed. "I had something like this baby when I was your age. Not as pretty, but..."

We headed into the field that stretched along both sides of the road, halting a bit before the tree line. I obligingly handed over a birdshot shell and a couple of swifts. He loaded with a quick skill I found hard to reconcile with the blunt thickness of his hands. He sighted, my little gun looking humorously tiny against his frame.

The .410 barked, followed by the quieter yap of the .220, like a little dog backing up its larger comrade.

We checked out the oak the officer had aimed for. The pattern of the birdshot was clear, with the .220 scar impressively centered in that patter.

"Sweet as hell!" Deputy Tiny laughed, returning my gun to me. He considered a moment, then gave an almost imperceptible 'what-the-hell' shrug. He popped open the cross strap of his own holstered

firearm, and pulled it out with sleek aplomb.

"Fair is fair. Wanna try?"

I must admit I was torn. The revolver was gorgeous, blued and gleaming. It looked like a dragon in the deputy's hand.

But I like to say what my folks couldn't give me in dollars they gave me in sense. A few years back, during a lazy afternoon's target practice, I had annoyed my father into letting me shoot a .306. He had repeatedly told me that I was too damn little—not too young, not too dumb, just too small—to fire a weapon of that size. I had persisted. Finally he shook his head, and passed it over. I really don't remember shooting. I still remember the bruised ass and shoulder, and the ringing in my head, and spitting out blood from biting my tongue. And my dad trying hard not to laugh and failing.

I had a vision of something similar happening with the deputy's gun, and how much more embarrassing it would be in front of a near stranger.

"No. Thank you sir, but I think I'm a little small for that."

Deputy Tiny nodded, grinned, and re-holstered the dragon. "Smart boy. Won't be long though."

He offered me a ride to my friends house, and I declined. It was too gorgeous of a day, and I had aliens to do battle with in my imagination.

"Well, you be careful son. And good luck." With that, he climbed into his cruiser and went his way, tossing off a wave as he passed.

I waved back, already lost in a vision of the invader's ship dropping on a screaming cloud of nuclear fire in the field beside me.

Of course, now, 20 years later, I look back on that memory with a curious mixture of sweet nostalgia and an almost painful sense of loss. I cannot imagine it playing out that way in any corner of this paranoid, hysterical nation.

That, you see, is the way a police officer behaves in a polite society —where individuals are not seen as enemies, suspects or threats simply because they carry the means to protect themselves and perhaps take a little sport with the native wild life.

In a polite society, if an officer of the law needs to visit a home, they stop at a polite distance, at a posted demarcation line, and call out "Hello the house!" If they receive no answer, they generally assume no one is home and try back later, rather than waltz onto private property

and pound on doors, sure that someone is hiding from them and that silence equals guilt. On the rare occasion that the matter is pressing enough to warrant uninvited entry on an individual's property, they apologize for the rudeness, remain respectful, and leave as soon as they can—usually appearing more than a little embarrassed.

During my childhood I cannot remember a single person being arrested. I'm certain there had to be arrests. But such matters were handled quietly, privately, with a minimum of fuss and bother. It was not the humiliating public spectacle that it so often becomes today.

The main reason for this is that almost everyone in a polite society is armed. Self defense is rightly seen as an individual duty. The police are there on the rare occasions when those individuals need or want help. The police are there to investigate theft and stop rowdy bar fights.

And oddly enough, it worked both ways. Cops respected individuals and individuals respected cops. Amazing dynamic.

No love, but respect.

No fear, but respect.

FRONTIERISM

I have long maintained that the earthbound hordes of humanity will never see the end of the State. This is because I see the problem of statism as a population density effect. The more humans who live and work in a small geographic area (cities, in other words), the more virulent the demand for an overarching statist solution to the problems that naturally arise when basically self-interested, variously skilled and talented individuals co-exist. The reason for this is quite simple—population density equals a higher crime rate without fail, due to simple logic of increased opportunity. Rather than become a responsible individual and take the precaution of creating an armed, polite society, the lazier of the population will demand regulators and heavier security administered from a central point. Anyone who has lived in both urban and rural areas will know exactly what I'm talking about. The ironic thing is that—as most libertarian/anarchist minded folks are well aware—the increase of regulation in search of security not only does not effectively discourage real crime (measurable damage against persons and property), it also creates a monopoly on force that seeks to gain ever increasing hegemony for itself—leading to the classification of voluntary, non-other damaging actions as "crimes".

Even the simplest perusal of human history points to the market—the sum total of human interactions, and the goods and services created by those interactions—as the only true arbiter of freedom. In fact, one may posit that the more access to an unhindered market is available, the more freedom of action and opportunity exist for a given population. If one posits a system where the only 'regulation' is a mutual agreement between individuals not to defraud or use force to obtain the possessions and labor of another, one can extrapolate a society where true freedom is the norm. This will never, of course, be accomplished by a state in any form. A state—being the embodiment of a desire to shun personal responsibility and the ever-present duty of defending one's own self from force and fraud—exists to hinder human action, therefore hindering the market. The state is a vast, multi-leveled tool used by a parasitic cadre of individuals who's only purpose is to hinder human interaction! The state's answer to any problem is always 'hinder more actions', despite the fact that many of the problems arise from state hindrance of the market in the first place!

(See The War On Drugs, and the increase in burglaries/muggings/theft, thanks to victim-disarming "gun control" laws.)

It is in the state's best interest for the crime rate to soar. It is in the state's best interest for people to live in poverty and clamor for welfare. It is in the state's best interest to create enemies who attack and kill its citizens. It is in the state's best interest to maintain and make compulsory public schools that produce ignorant, rote-spouting citizens who are unable to use critical reasoning to solve even the simplest of problems. This gives the state a reason to exist, and a reason to grow, and a mass of ignorant true believers who will demand its existence and encourage its growth.

I have come to accept the rise and growth of states as a natural phenomena, triggered by population density and the inherent non-equality of the human race. To most of my friends this is an almost heretical conclusion; I've been more or less denounced by people I respect and like because of this conclusion. The point they refuse to see is that the formation and growth of states actually serves to create anarchistic pressure to flee the grip of control and therefore is the main impulse in the settlement of new frontiers. The driving force for the expansion of humanity. The invisible hand that widens the market.

Human society MUST expand, so long as we live in a world of resources and scarcity. The earth—as vast and abundant as it is—is but a speck in the cosmos. Outside this cradle lies the rest of the universe, infinite to our still limited senses, waiting to be claimed and put to use. The grand stage on which the drama of the market, the story of human action, will be played out.

The hardcore space-socialists tell me that private exploitation of off-planet resources can never be opened to the masses. They have a common reason: it's dangerous. This always makes me laugh. What frontier isn't dangerous? What frontier isn't settled on the blood and bones of the brave and foolhardy, the desperate and the contrary? Frontierists are by nature anarchistic.

Anarchy is dynamic. Statism is static. The human waveform is a naturally expanding sphere, anarchist on the wave front, decaying into statism within. The true beauty is that there is always a place for the frontierist to depart when the grip grows too tight. It will not be easy. Nothing worth having is ever easy. It is the supreme challenge facing

the human race—and the question in every seeker's mind is simple: Is it worth it?

I say it is.

The only solution to statism—and the only hope for the survival of this human species—is a dynamic, expansionist human society with an unlimited frontier.

The answer to statism is to open the frontier to immigration.

I'll see you in the NEO belt!

REQUIEM FOR OZYMANDIAS

Ozymandias was a feral cat who ruled a colony of ferals that live on our property. He was here when I moved back from Chicago and I named him Ozymandias when I met him. I was strung out from the bus ride and overwhelmed by 'being back home-ness', so I went outside to smoke a cig and collect myself.

I sat down on the old storm shelter and lit up. Then I realized I wasn't alone. I turned around and this huge cat was staring right at me, at the opposite end of the shelter top. He appeared to be constructed of bones, scar tissue, sinew and snatches of grey fur. He had these enormous green eyes.

When I say huge, I mean huge—15 pounds easy, and not an ounce of fat. A fucking mutant cat. Battle scars, he was made of. A warrior. He showed no fear. Hell, it wasn't even curiosity in those emerald eyes. It was a challenge.

"Who the hell are you, pal?"

I stared right back. "Who the hell are you, cat?"

Then he stretched and yawned and started cleaning himself.

I am Ozymandias, king of kings, sounded in my head.

That was his name from then on.

Ozy was a warrior. He ruled this colony benevolently and well. I watched. Watching wild cats is my hobby. Ozy ate last. He never went hungry because the other cats left him his ration.

He was a warrior and, more importantly, he was my friend. I like to build fires and sit outside and stare at the stars. Ozy would always wander up and settle in, perfectly companionable but not too close. 'Nice night, ain't it?' or 'Bitchin' hot these days.'

One night five toms invaded and I watched him kick their asses. He killed one of them. I sat there and watched with a .22, more than ready to put a bullet in the head of an invader if they got the best of him. But they didn't. He slaughtered their asses. Then he looked at me reproachfully. "Those were fucking *housecats*, G. How could you doubt me?"

Ozy died last Wednesday. I was outside, at the fire, and he came up and—this stunned me—lay almost at my feet. He was panting and hobbling before he collapsed.

It took about ten minutes. Then he was gone. He let me pet him before he went. And he purred. The first and only time I heard him purr.

This is the requiem for Ozymandias, my friend. You were a warrior. You were a good king. You fucked 'em when the season spoke and fought them if they came at you.

I loved you.

Goodbye.

THERE WILL BE NO REVOLUTION

Amongst libertarian and anarchist thinkers there is a constant and unending battle. Many times this takes the form of 'Anarchy vs. Minarchy'. Other times it involves the debate between those who wish to work within the system to effect change and those of a more revolutionary mindset. What is comes down to, in most cases, is the difference between pragmatism and idealism. A recourse to either ballots or bullets to reverse the trend of ever- increasing government would be, by definition, a revolution.

I consider myself a Frontierist. I became a Frontierist—rather than an anarchist or libertarian—because of this very dichotomy.

Allow me to be blunt: *There will be no revolution*. Not in the classic sense. EVER. The great mass of humanity is doomed to statism. They don't even consider it *doom*. They love it, kiss it, and idolize it. *This is what they want*.

But we don't really need a revolution, folks.

I am writing a manifesto, which sums up my views on anarchy, minarchy, and the state. In a sense, I have been writing it since the age of thirteen, because there hasn't been a day since that year that it hasn't percolated through my thoughts. When finished, it will be entitled *The Use Of Tools: A Human Manifesto.* I mean that subtitle seriously. It's not a political manifesto. 'Politics' is just the Game of State, pure control freakery institutionalized.

What humans do is build and use tools. That's our defining characteristic. That's the reason we are the boss of this planet. We aren't the strongest, or the fastest, or the best clawed or fanged. What we are is the *smartest* damn animal on the planet. And our 'smarts' are focused almost entirely on building and using tools.

When I was thirteen years old I had a very vivid, very compelling dream. I was alone in a deserted city. I was walking up the streets. No surprise that it looked like a city in a movie, since that was the only example of 'city' I'd ever seen. It was two years in the future until I would be in the backseat of a car, heading away from everything I knew, as we bypassed Atlanta at night and I saw it laid out and shining.

After just a bit of (rather pleasant, I remember) wandering along this impossible city, I encountered an old man with a cane, very nattily

dressed, waiting at a bus stop. He looked, like all old men in my dreams, like a mixture of Robert Heinlein and my father.

He smiled and nodded. Then, after a moment, said:

"There is nothing created by human beings that is not a tool. Did you know that?"

My first thought was to disagree. Of course, there must be something. Tools were such a... basic thing.

Before I could, the bus was there, with the stealth and surprise they only gain in dreams. The old man smiled and nodded. "Think about that," he told me, and was gone, and then I was awake.

It was dawn, around 5 am. No matter how I tossed and turned, I couldn't get back to sleep. So I decided to take the old man's advice. I started to think about it.

And I've been thinking about it for 18 years.

This is what we do, folks.

And guess what? The state is just another tool. Ignore the meatbags at the controls for a moment, and look at it. It's just a tool for organization and social control. The machine of state is *amoral* like all other tools. The morality of this tool is the morality of its user. Sadly, almost all of its users are criminals. No surprise, it was started by criminals, pure bandits, when agriculture was invented. Agriculture demands that a growing population must stay rooted in the same spot. They live in that spot, producing wealth. Not long after, bandits happened along. Rather than join in the production of wealth, they saw it would be easier to just terrify the hardworking farmers into giving them tribute.

At that moment in history, the State was born. The kings and emperors. To hell with fancy titles; parasites, that's all they really are. But the nature of the human beast is pragmatic. They not only accepted this tool, but praised it. Hell, when those other bandits ruling those other people tried to invade and steal the harvest, didn't *our bandits* rush forward and fight them off, rallying us all together? Yeah! Go, our bandits! Kick ass. Never mind that they were only protecting their claimed territory. Never mind that they spent our lives in the battle. We won, didn't we? I mean, most of us are still alive, and most of them are dead, right? Good show. What's the alternative? Being responsible for our own defense?

We used to do that. It was messy and hard. We like this better.

Stupid, weak, lazy people dominate the human race. They are the engine of the state. They are uneducatable. They are unconvertible. They love their bandits, and they'll smile when their bandits kill you for challenging their rule.

Just a big, ugly, pervasive machine.

But worms turn. They do.

Population density is the key. It started with agriculture. Agriculture demands people stay clustered together and spread slowly. Agriculture is the reason cities got built. As someone (Elias, I think) pointed out, anarchy has existed. The best example, recorded and verified, are the trappers and mountain men and explorers who rejected the swelling cities of the East for the untamed lands of the west. They didn't put down roots, they kept moving, they made their own law and stuck by it.

Frontierists. :)

All you see is natural. All you see is the evolution of the tool- using animal named *human*.

Before agriculture, humanity was a nomadic pack animal. It still is, really. It's bone deep, in the genes, riding the helix. The waveform of the human race is an expanding sphere, the anarchists heading outside, those who 'settle' decaying to statism within. All natural. We are a tool-using, resource-exploiting animal. We live on a cosmic speck of dust. The entire universe awaits us.

We have two optimistic options.

Hyperconnection is the first. The main problem with the human race is that we communicate poorly. Spoken and written language is so linear and limited. But it doesn't have to be. This thing we are communicating on now is the seed of what will be.

What happens when we stop sitting at our computers and start wearing them? What happens when the superbroadband, massively-encrypted, wireless second-gen internet (I call it the 'Overnet') becomes widely available? What happens when servers no longer reside in buildings but in the pockets and purses and very bodies of billions of people? What happens when you can communicate with almost anyone anywhere at anytime? What happens when your comp allows you to read the physical signs of another person and tell if he or she is lying or trying to fraud you? What happens when 'money' becomes an electronic data point in its entirety, so encrypted

that no one can figure out where it came from or went? What happens when the symbolflow (my term for the whole of human communication) becomes near perfect and near instantaneous? What happens when a *truly* voluntary and productive collective is established among the majority of our poor monkeykin species?

I don't know. But I can hope. The last thing out of Pandora's box was hope, and to hope I will cling.

I hope that the entire connected body of my brothers and sisters will finally turn and look at those bandits. See them for the parasites they are.

And if that happens, brothers and sisters, the state is DEAD. We've started this fire. But we don't have the right tools to let it rage at the moment. They are coming.

Hope. Believe.

The second option is Frontierism in the raw. The exploration and (more importantly) exploitation of off-earth resources. The golden dream of Heinlein. Go ahead and LET the damn state put colonies on the moon and the NEO's and Mars and beyond. LET them. Those people won't obey for long. Because they will diverge. They will be the new trappers and mountain men and explorers. They will, in the early stages, go through a trial by ordeal never imagined by the human race. Only the smartest and strongest and most ambitious will survive. The human race will diverge. It will build spectacular new tools. It will reach for the stars. It will become better. It will run and keep on running. The human waveform will at last be unleashed. It will head into the black at as close to the speed of light as it can possibly achieve.

Hope was the last thing out of Pandora's Box, brothers and sisters.

And I will cling to it.

POETRY

ONE MORNING IN THE LONG, COLD NIGHT OF THE HYPERPOWER

I move across the prairie
like the wind through wheat;
quickly, barely sensed.
I take my food fairly,
the price an arrow,
the work of muscle,
and a long cold patient moment.
I am clad in leather,
and simple homespun,
my bow is ash,
with a string of sinew.
My name is David,
the son of Daniel,
the son of Darren;
who lived like a king,
but thought he was poor.

I take my rest
on a great concrete structure
sealed for good and ever.
Below rots a Demon,
a city killer,
sung of in legends,
but feared no more.
To the east lies wasteland.
To the west lies wasteland.

But here on the prairie,
my children thrive.
The children of poor kings,
who became too greedy,
the children of dead Columbia,

the heirs to arrogance,
and foolish pride.
Once, they say, we were warriors.
Then we simply warred.
Now, we are warriors again.

A MEETING WITH A FRIEND, HOME FROM WAR

You had changed and I knew it
from the moment
I laid eyes on you again;
as you plastered on that fake smile
and tried to imitate your voice
the way you thought it sounded
before you left.

I could see it in your eyes as
you made unspoken excuses
for things you weren't to blame for;
that happened in places that I lack names for,
that you'll probably never mention,
and I hope you can forget.

I could see it in the way you moved
and reacted sharp to sounds
and grew silent in conversation at odd moments;
when certain concepts came along,
how your eyes went far away and dulled,
as if you were gnawing on your thoughts.

The biggest crime of waging war
is not simply the killing
but the creation
of killers.

AN ENEMY OF THE PEOPLE

Portrait of a Marine Recon unit
assaulting the entrance
of a cave in Afghanistan.
Sound and fury,
blood and treasure,
spilled on foreign soil.
Only to find,
a guttering fire,
the image of smoke in a mirror.
And on that glass,
scrawled in dust,
a single true name:
Goldstein

THEY TOOK THE MASK OFF

They took the mask off and
children burned,
and I ran outside
and vomited in the yard
and my dad picked the TV up
ripped it from the wall
and hurled it through a window
and said
in a dead cold voice:
"America has ended."

(He used to say "the American people"
and you could hear the pride.
Now he says "the American people"
and all you can hear is disgust.)
You were wrong, Mr. Elliot.
The world does not end
with a bang or a whimper.
Some worlds end
with the unheard screams
of children burning alive
inside a church.

POEM

To Those Left Behind.
A Memorial Day poem #3

I.

God gave her one son.
The State took him away.
To fight a war, it said.
An important war.
Freedom was at stake, it said.
Democracy and liberty, it claimed.
She'd accepted and feared and hoped.
But her son still died,
thousands of miles away
from his mother's arms,
And she'd be damned if
she could tell a difference
other than a broken heart,
and a belly full of hate.

II.

Her name was Quy Hue
but in the singsong patois
of the streets she ran
they just called her Round Eyes.
The round eyes were from her father
a conscript wanderer
Who'd conceived her one night
drunk and desperate for warmth
in a hotel in Saigon.
He died in the jungle a month later.
She never met him, our Quy Hue.
But when she was five
she watched the helicopters
flee the embassy downtown
as the conquerors at last
took the ground they claimed.

She did not know a great nation state
had finally been defeated.
She just thought: "My father is gone forever."
The northerners killed her mother a year later.
Left alone she ran.
She stole and whored and killed three men.
She ate when she could and lived
as best as she could tear from the world.
She learned the ways of the knife,
the quiet step and the empty heart.
But in her dreams her father smiled
down on a precious lily flower,
and she woke herself crying often.
She died in a Saigon gutter at the age of thirteen.

III.

They took my boy,
he often thought.
And sent me back a mad dog.
Chuck screams in his sleep often.
He drinks too much.
He's missing a foot.
Sometimes Chuck stares at the stump.
He stares at the missing foot.
And he just has to hit someone.
It's a sad game,
he often thinks,
for a 65-year-old man to make excuses for bruises.
"I killed a little girl."
Chuck sometimes slurs.
"I thought she had a bomb, but it was just an old radio."
Such is life,
he always thinks
but he fought for our freedom.
And the old man goes on
Making excuses for bruises.
Lying to the world and himself.

And Chuck is trapped,
until his last breath,
staring at a dead child and a radio that didn't even work.

BILLY THE KID IN HELL

for RF, with thanks.

It was a sullen hot morning in Lincoln town, the day that Billy
died
in the deepest heart of a summer the likes of which no one
before or since have seen
"I saw it from here," the Old Timer says, as he smoked and
closed his eyes.
"Billy was fast, that's not contested—but no one's ever fast
enough"
"Yeah, hellish fast—that's not contested. I'll die right here if I
lie."
"But the story don't end, when he went into earth" he smiled,
but his voice became rough.

The Old Timer was quiet, as if lost in thought, hair grayed and
face leather rough
He told me he'd been here since the town was founded, and
would be here till the day that he died
He paused so long, I thought it had happened—but he spoke
and gave my thought lie
"I know cause I dreamt it, and others as well, we've spoken and
know what we seen"
"You folk from the cities, your science and all—it's handy but
it's just not enough"
And he looked at me hard, as if daring my smirk, but tears I'd
soon see in his eyes.

"I dreamt I saw Billy a'fallin', a'tumblin' to hell, to find that the
preacher didn't lie
And there in that pit, ol' Satan walked up, a grinnin'
monstrosity, a burning pain to the eyes
'Billy my boy! I'm a big fan, and I've admired all your work
that I've seen!'

Satan lifted the outlaw above the Lake, let him take in the vista
so rough

said 'As you see boy, there's torments a plenty—all these
useless fools who have died
But that's just a waste of talent like yours, and I've seen it
wasted enough'

Ol' Satan took Billy, to the top of a peak, the grand vista of the
wicked who'd died
faded away, replaced by a vision, of a world no human eyes
had yet seen
'I show you the future, my sweet Billy boy, a future that's
coming by my winkin' eyes'
And he saw city's swelling, fixing to burst, and changes that
we're never enough
'We claim to give 'em freedom, and they believe us like sheep,
losing truth and loving the lie
For safety's sake they cling to the easy, they give up the wild
and the rough'

'So what say you Billy? I'll send you back home, let you tame
these slaves in the rough
You'll have power a'plenty over men of all natures, like the
kings and great men who have died
You'll be The State's gun hand, the hand on the whip, in you
the power will lie!'
Billy considered, then spat on the ground, and thought about
all he had seen
He smiled at ol' Satan, said 'I'm a bad man, but I respect what is
free, enough
to tell you to stick it, you killer of freedom', drew fast and shot
'tween Satan eyes

Satan did roar, knocked Bill a'sprawlin, brimstone did spill
from his eyes
'Damn you forever! Into the lake, I'll show you an Eternity
rough!'

Billy just laughed, said 'No more than I'd reckoned. But
sometimes a man calls 'enough.''

And so Billy was cast, into the lake, to suffer like all the wicked
who'd died
But sometimes he'd still grin, knowing he chose right, and
loving the look that he'd seen
On ol' Satan's face, when his offered rejected, looked like a brat
caught in a lie."

The Old timer stood up, wiped rough bleary eyes, told me he'd
spoken enough.
He tamped out his pipe, said "That was no lie, I dreamt it and
know what I seen"
"Billy was bad, till the day that he died, but no sort of statist
was he."

HOUSE OF PAIN

Within a framework
of shattered bones;
thatched with torn out hair,
walled with lacerated skin
dried crudely in the sun,
tanned and taut with labor.

(*Ditches I have dug,*
shit I have shoveled,
dishes I have washed,
trucks I have loaded,
a back I have broken,
indignities I've suffered,
two arthritic knees I hobble on now,
from miles I have walked,
shed a river of sweat
yet you do not
give a fuck.)

Inside sits a broken heart.
This structure
is held together
by the knives I've pulled
from my back.
Enough. Enough.

I sit now,
drawing a cloak of black
over my tired form.
I've laid out a suit of clothes
suitable to die in.
I've cleaned and oiled my guns.

Loaded them, click, click.
They rest easy near me,
at the ready,
close at hand.

I sit, sipping bitter tea
as the dark comes on.
I sit and wait.
No words left but the words
the fire sings in its
red and beating heart,
staring at photographs of my daughter as a baby.

Your move.

LOKI

I have this gift
for lying, see.
I can tell the good lies
the ones you *want* to believe.

I can tell you a
different version
of something you just saw
and you'll nod and say it was so.

I can tell the bold lies
the sweet lies
that interpret reality
so that millions would applaud.

Such lies that trick
Gods onto crosses
races into bondage
worlds into war.

It would be a shame
to waste such a gift as mine
and such a pretty face
and such joy taken in picking pockets.

I must find a place
to wait for Ragnarok
for the Twilight times
'till Fenris finally finds me.

I think I'll run for office.

IN THE CIRCLE

for the Trace Fork Potters, with all my love.

It feels like I
missed you guys
all my life
and never knew it.
Some little empty
spot's been filled,
some missing piece revealed,
by walking up the hill.
Elmer's rolling one,
slow oh yeah but sure.
Summer's playing solitaire
and I'm trying not to stare.
David's going on and on
Paul is out there sanding.
Dani's on her way home
the dogs are quiet, waiting.
Now we're all together
the circle is complete.
Put fire to the paper
release the herb with heat.
We talk amongst ourselves,
things serious and silly
getting high and smiling
a family, strange but sweet.
And I hope that when I'm gone
they will say of me:
"He never double toked,
he never broke rotation,
if he had a jay he brought it up,
he'll always be welcome
(now and forever welcome)
in our circle."

ODYSSEY: A PROSE POEM

Centuries passed and they brought me back,
assembled me from waste products
to work because their sheep were weak,
and they found they needed real men.
Eventually I escaped
and stole a starship.
I killed fifteen men in the process.
No, I'm not a badass,
these future men were pitiful
and had never seen anything
like my crude zipgun.
(What they needed starships for
I'll never know. Maybe they built
them just because they could.
Why do robots and sheep do anything?)
Free at last, I ran.
Through oceans of black,
past stars and comets,
great whirling masses of dark matter,
through the blistering edges of novae,
seeking, looking, scanning,
I ran.

Nothing and more nothing.
Loneliness set in.
No aliens, no fellow escapees.
It was sad, being the last free man.
I was ready to end it.
I'd programmed the 'puter
to dump me into a star
while it injected me with
potent synthetic cannibinoids
and played Bizet at full blast,
when a signal was received.

“Welcome,” the signal said,
“if you be of free mind.
“Otherwise, pass on or prepare for death.
We have anti-matter weapons and ain't afraid to use 'em.”
I checked it and rechecked it;
it was real.
I sent the 'puter to examine.
It brought me back a picture of a world
circling this deathsun.
They had arranged asteroids to spell out:
“HARDYWORLD: SLAVES NEED NOT APPLY.”

What a world it was,
conquered and gleaming.
The lights from the surface delighted me.
The party kicked ass.

OUR LADY OF BLADES

You hit and hold
and look at me
and your eyes
are deep black
storms
contained
by icy gray.
You smile and
settle back
and I
almost
fucking
squirm.

You know
what you're doing
to me.
You love it.

I roll another
and hand it over
and our hands touch
and I feel a
tremble
front
slips a bit.
I'm a bastard
and ask about your boyfriend
and you
struggle
finding
words.

I know
what I'm doing
to you.

I love it.

The intro music
is ending.
The dance will begin soon.
This false front
will shatter and
the shards
will find things to cut.
Let's not pretend;
this will probably end
badly.

That's the risk
we take
the shattered hearts
we chance
every time
we dance
with
Our
lady
of
blades.

FICTION

STILLED-LIFE

I always knew I was an artist, even though I couldn't paint or draw worth a damn. I always knew there was a major work of art in me, even though I couldn't sing or play any instrument or write the simplest line of prose. All those years I wasted, trying in vain every artistic medium I encountered–I had no talent in any of them. My attempts at pottery created warped bowls. My attempt at sculpture, a small pile of rocks.

But I persevered, feeling that grand artwork in me. I cried over the works of masters, cried in both appreciation and jealousy. I persevered, despite mockery and honest criticism in equal abundance. Against the laughter of strangers and the worried lectures of friends and family.

And then, one day, a merciful universe gave me my canvas.

I slide her blouse off with practiced ease, like a chef whipping eggs. I place it in the garbage bag by my side. The bag is nearly full, and is the last one in the box. No matter, I remind myself. The work is nearly done, the artwork nearly complete. I feel a thrill pass through me, and a hint of sadness. How long has it been? I've lost track. Months, I know. Perhaps even years. There is no way of being sure.

Pretty bra, I note, as I deftly undo it and drop it into the gaping black plastic mouth. Lacy and quite girlish; little pink flowers. She had to be at least 30, I guess. Perhaps it is her one concession to immaturity. The jeans, as usual, are the most difficult chore. As is the fashion, she wears them so tight that they are very nearly a second skin. Yes, yes, very attractive; accentuating her pert buttocks and wide hips below a trim waist. But, lord, they are tough to get off! On certain occasions, I have been forced to gently tip the subject over and remove the denim skin inch by painstaking inch.

Thankfully, this is not the case. I merely have to do the customary manipulations required to remove shoes and socks. I am able to get the jeans free in a matter of moments, working from the feet.

Intriguing. The panties are a clash with the sweetly girlish bra—a silken black thong affair, extremely sexy. Or at least I suppose. I seem to have grown immune to such things in my long quest towards the final artwork. Such details are clinical and barely rate a passing thought. The removal of the panties is quick and discreet. One might

as well imagine Rodin being aroused by the finished form of the Mermaid. Ridiculous!

Finished.

The thought explodes in my mind. The ever present noonday sun above seems to grow oppressive suddenly. I feel faint. Could it be? Could I at last be finished?

In one sense, there is no way I could be sure. There are places I could not get to, doors too stoutly locked. I put them out of my mind. I had long ago decided that my art would concentrate on the outdoors, the streets and courtyards, the sidewalks and outdoor Cafes. Even Van Gogh had to choose a final brush stroke. Even Mozart penned a finite number of notes.

I deposit the underwear in the garbage bag and tie it closed. As I had a thousand times before, I toss it over my shoulder and begin the long march towards the depository. I had chosen a wide public courtyard to be the resting place of the stuffed bags. I imagine, one day, there will be long lines waiting to search through the mountain of goods contained in those uncounted bags.

I am exhausted, and with good reason. I rarely sleep, eat infrequently and with impatience. Like the masters before me my work is my life. How can I give but the bare minimum of effort to such banalities as sleep and food? My beard and hair are long, tangled and filthy. Bathing and shaving are utter trivialities. Sleep and food are needed to maintain life, to continue the work. No one has ever died from being unkempt and dirty.

I lay the final bag at the foot of the black plastic mountain that has risen in the courtyard slowly but surely over the course of my labors. I am trembling—more from excitement and eagerness than exhaustion and hunger.

Finished!

I feel sudden impatience, and something else. The same feeling that had overtaken me when the world changed so long ago begins to sing in my bones again.

Finished!

I fall three times rushing back to the downtown intersection that I had chosen as the centerpiece of my great work, its living heart. A torn knee and scuffed elbow, a pain I barely feel.

Yes. The same feeling. As it was in the beginning, so it will be in the end.

I tremble uncontrollably as I climb the 30 feet of scaffolding, to the perch where I shall view my finished masterpiece, the first and perhaps only work of living art the world has seen.

Trembling, wheezing, excited beyond comprehension. I clasp my knees to my chest and stare out at my creation, my life's passion, my art:

The crowded scene of a Chicago lunch-hour, downtown, streets filled with cars, sidewalks with pedestrians.

All are naked. Beautiful and ugly, thin and fat, male and female.

"Still Life: Chicago, Noon." I whisper, the first words I've spoken since time stopped, so long ago, and left me wandering in a frozen moment.

Since the universe took mercy on me and gave me a canvas.

I do not know or care how time stopped. I do not know or care how I was exempted from the stillness.

Because I know why.

The universe is a patron of the arts.

The silence breaks. My watch begins to tick...

...and below, in beauty, in grace, in slow and wondrous majesty, my art begins to live.

To be honest, even Dan and me thought Herbie's plan was nuts at first. Why we chose to go along I can't say, even now. I'd like to blame it all on the booze, and that rundown feeling you get when the layoff stretches out into the future and the unemployment check seems to buy less and less every week. I'd like to, but in all honesty, I can't.

Because that *wasn't* the reason.

We did it because we *could*.

Herbie first brought up the plan one Friday night, over beers on Dan's back porch.

You all know Herbie—big solid sonuvabitch, still has the remnant of his high school football-playing, cheerleader-seducing frame despite the beer gut and considerable wrinkles. "A politician's face," the old lady used to call it with a sneer, before she lit off with that teenaged anarchist from Arizona.

The boy can give a speech too—you should see it sometimes. His eyes get this fire, and his every move takes on a weight of pure conviction. No surprise that he's the best damn car salesman down at Big Jim's Lot-O-Value, ten years running. Hell, he's the one who saddled me with the piece of shit Tempo that's given me nothing but a headache and a stream of bills.

"It makes me sick to my stomach, knowing that shit is going on in this town, just a few blocks away!" Herbie said, and none of us had to ask him what he meant. We'd all been thinking about it, since the first rumors had begun to circulate. It wasn't a pleasant thing to think about in the first place, and the rumor mill had done its usual deed of making the story truly horrible in the absence of any fact.

There was a family who lived a few blocks over, nearer to what everyone called 'trailer country' than our own admittedly less-than-upscale homes. The Ericks. Dan's kid went to school with the Ericks brood—my own son would have been too, if he hadn't been doing God knows what in some Arizonan hole.

The Ericks kids were girls, all four of them, ranging in age from six years to twelve years. Beautiful little gals too—it always brought a smile to drive past and see the two youngest out on the sidewalk, playing hopscotch or jumping rope. Pretty little dark-haired girls with the most beautiful olive skin.

You rarely saw the two eldest, though, and that was odd. But when the rumors started flying it went beyond odd into scary. Then sick. Then... just awful.

You never saw the dad, either. Word had it that he was on disability and had collected a mighty chunk from his previous employer over a work-related accident. The man seemed to be afraid of the sun. He never came out of the house when honest eyes could see him.

Mom was a lot more visible. She worked at the Shop N' Save on Grand, and everyone called her "Bunny". I don't know why, her name was Elise, and it said it right on the damned name-tag, but I have a guess. I think they called her that because she always looked so scared. The fact that she sometimes sported a black eye or an ugly bruise on her cheek got ignored for quite a few years. She was a sweet, friendly and talkative woman, at least on the surface. Look into her eyes, though—on the rare occasion she would allow such contact—and all you could see was fear.

Like a lot of things, it was the kids who noticed first.

Dan's daughter Deenie mentioned one night, after her dad kept prodding for the reason she was so mopey and quiet, that she had been changing for gym with the oldest Ericks girl and had noticed bruises. Deep bruises, on her arms, legs and wrist. And, this admission had brought tears, what looked an awful lot like a bite mark on her shoulder. The Ericks gal had seen her stare and nervously told her that it was from a fight with one of her sisters.

Deenie had accepted that with a nod, but couldn't believe it.

In a town like ours, rumor is perhaps the most powerful force of all. Rumor takes scraps of information, the barest glimmerings, and—as it echoes through the households and bars and shops—it turns them into darkly detailed certainties. The blacker the suspicions the more evil the eventual design.

Within the next few weeks I heard a dozen variations on exactly what was going on in the Ericks' household—everything from child porno to child prostitution rings. Suddenly, people remembered those black eyes Bunny sported on occasion, the same marks they'd steadfastly ignored for years. They pulled that into the mix. Bits and pieces came from all over—the distant memory of the time little Carina

had been limping for two days. The long known but never before cared-about fact that Bunny had mentioned that her husband was a gun collector. The whispered admission that neighbors frequently heard odd noises coming from the locked tight garage behind the Ericks house. The fact that the Ericks girls were so quiet and shy in school that the teachers had to constantly ask them to speak up, and that they were never allowed to attend sleepovers or birthday parties.

It was around the time that people were talking about secret torture chambers and satanic rituals that Herbie brought up his plan. What he eventually started calling "The Mission".

"We have to do something," he said, grandly.

"Like call the cops?" Dan asked, words slurred. We were well into the second case of beer and all pleasantly blasted.

"Oh, fuck that," Herbie said, contemptuously. "That never works. Not with a psycho like this. Most that will happen is that the fucker will get a visit from some bleeding heart social worker, and you know sure as shit everything will be nice and neat and tidy for that visit." Herbie belched with satisfaction, cracked open another brew, and continued to expound.

"And, 'member boys, even if something was a bit iffy, that fucker is loaded. He'd just bribe that heart-bleeder before two words got written down. Naw."

I admit I was perplexed. "Then what the hell are you talking about, Herb?"

He tapped his forehead for no reason and squinted at me. "I mean we take the matter into our own hands."

We laughed him off at first. It just sounded crazy.

But, like I said, Herbie can talk. He asked us to think about the living hell that poor woman and her little girls had to endure. He asked us what we would think if suddenly other kids started disappearing. Dan got wide-eyed at that, and shuddered. I knew he was imagining his sweet, trusting little girl trapped in a house with a thing like that.

Then Herbie rounded on me and tossed out a kicker: "What if that's exactly what's going on with your boy, friend? Wherever the hell he is? Wouldn't you want someone like us to do something?"

That sank into my brain like a depth charge. Guilt is an awful thing. Especially when it's unfocused and raw.

He went on, but I think he knew he had us. All the rest was gravy.

He talked about how we'd be heroes in town—we'd storm into that place, find proof of the depraved shit the bastard was up to, bring those little girls and their momma out like avenging angels, and if the piece of shit wanted to try and stop us, why, we'd make him wish he'd never been born.

It had a definite appeal. Sitting alone in my house, listening to silence—that was pretty much all I did those days. My life was in a pit right then. The idea of doing something so selfless and noble—the idea of being a hero, a liberator of the innocent, of having their gratitude—and the admiration of an entire town.

Yes. I wanted that.

I was surprised to find myself shivering slightly in my desire for that.

Hell, Dan and me were fired up. We wanted to drive the hell over there and do it right then.

Herbie told us to sit down, to shut up, and start using our heads.

"We all know that bastard is armed to the teeth," he reminded us. "Hell, Dan—do you even own a gun? All I have is that little .22 varmint pinger there." He pointed to a little pistol hung above the bookcase.

Dan shook his head, no. I reminded Herbie that I owned a .12 gauge.

Herbie laughed at that. "This guy is a frigging collector, boys. For all we know he has a damned cannon stashed in there." He mused a bit, sipping beer.

"What we need is superior firepower. And that's going to cost us."

I shook my head, the dream dissipating. Hell, Dan and I were both laid off, living on unemployment, and Herbie was mortgaged to the gills. It took all the means the three of us could scrape up to afford the weekly drinking sessions. And we drank the cheapest beer we could find.

But Herbie was smiling, and there was a fierce little gleam in his eye.

"Don't worry. Ol' Herbie has a plan." **

The first couple of muggings were the worst. Things got easier after that. I guess what they say is true—even the worst things become easier with practice.

And, of course, we only did it for the cause.

It was me and Dan did the dirty work—Herbie mainly picked the targets and gave us the time and place to strike. He chose the more

affluent of our fellow townsfolk to begin with—who just so happened to be the ones least likely to fight back. Our mission guidelines were strict—we only took what they had in their pockets. No watches, no jewelry or anything else we'd have to pawn. In a few cases this was a few hundred bucks a shot.

General procedure was to catch them unawares and—in the best circumstances—in a place that was a bit compromising. Say the strip club a few miles out of town, or the happy coincidence of when we caught Jim Culley, the bank manager, paying a late night visit to an old 'college gal pal'. Make them loathe to report it to anyone.

A lot of the times we barely had to show the guns—just a flash to let them know we were serious.

Then we'd hit 'em with the speech, the one Herbie had prepared, full of compassion for those poor abused little girls and how we—as a town—had to do something. How if we didn't stop that monster then we were no better than he was. Shit, in a few cases, we had the bastards in tears by the end of it. Ol' Culley even wrote us a damn check! Four hundred bucks! Though I think that may have been a little extra to make sure our lips were sealed about his location at two a.m. when he was supposed to be at the bank, 'clearing up a few accounts'.

We only had to get rough twice. Once it was just a little smack to the head when Dave Hansen got rowdy and proved a bit too drunk to be swayed by the speech.

But the second time—hell, I still hate thinking about that one.

I had reservations about it from the minute Herbie gave us the name. Old Man Fierson, who owned the sprawling ranch just outside the city limits. The ranch was more of a hobby than anything to Fierson–he had struck it rich investing as a young man and pinched every penny until it screamed. Still drove the '62 Ford truck I remembered him in from childhood, and dressed in jeans and flannel shirts so old that they had faded to a uniform dim gray.

The reservations came for two reasons: Fierson, as frugal and unassuming as he lived, was never late to lend a hand when folks needed it. When storm season hit he was always first on the scene, that old pickup and his wiry leather frame right in the mess, cleaning up and repairing. When the Albert's house had burnt down in '91, he had been the first to speak up and throw five thousand dollars into the pot to help them rebuild. There wasn't a charitable event he didn't show

up for, and every year on May Day he invited all the kids in town to his ranch for a picnic and horse rides. He was well loved, and deeply respected.

And secondly, Old Man Fierson never went anywhere without his gun.

I tried to talk Herbie out of it, but he just got pissed off at me. Accused me of wimping out in the face of a little risk. As the days wore on, Herbie just got odder and odder—and drank more and more. He even came close to getting fired from the car lot when he took three days off without even a phone call. The Mission was all he wanted to talk about, all he seemed to think about.

I should have backed out, and to hell with him—but it was Dan who caused me to tag along, on what would turn out to be the final step before we carried out The Mission. Because Dan was almost as hung up on the plan as Herbie, and Dan had been my friend since grade school. No matter what, I couldn't let him go it alone. It's a sad thing when good reasons lead you into evil—but nobody ever promised me that loyalty would always do me right. That hurts like a bitch.

We ended up cornering Fierson at nightfall, in the back lot of Cramer's Farm Supply, as he was loading sacks of feed into the back of his truck. He had apparently stayed to jaw with the owner until closing time, and the lot was deserted.

Except for us.

He glanced back after tossing the last sack into the truck bed with a grunt. Seemed a bit winded. He eyed us.

"Evenin', boys. If you're looking to buy, I'm afraid you're a mite late." I could see the handle of his pistol jutting from his waistband, old-timer style, right where it had always rode. Fierson had his hand by it. Not threatening. Just ready. My dad always told me that once a man survives to a certain age, he's beyond fooling on important matters. I knew my dad was right.

In a slightly trembling voice, I started in on the speech, trying my damnedest to be as convincing and passionate as I could be. Dan sat there nodding, determination in his eyes.

When I finished, and told him what we expected, Fierson shook his head slowly. Then, of all things, he began to laugh. Just threw back his head and roared.

"I'll be damned it that isn't the single dumbest fucking idea I've ever heard anybody say out loud! Lord, boys—you gone crazy?" he managed to say when the laughter subsided. I don't know if it was the laughter or the shock of hearing Fierson use the F word that broke my nerve, but it broke—into about a billion jagged pieces.

And that's when Dan snapped.

"You miserable old fucker!" he screamed and pulled his gun, pointing it with a shaking, enraged hand. "You don't give a damn that a monster like that is right here in our town! You don't care what those girls..."

And that's when Fierson drew smooth as you please and fired, barely missing Dan's head by fractions of an inch. I swear I felt that slug rush through the space between us like the world's smallest locomotive.

Dan screamed and tackled the old man, smashing him back into the tailgate of his truck with a brutal crunch. The old man's pistol went flying as his wrist snapped back.

I don't remember a whole lot of what happened next. Brief flashes. Dan and me pistol-whipping the old man in a black mixture of rage and shocked fear. Dan rolling him over and grabbing the wallet, ripping the belt loop it was chained to free with a choked sob. An old familiar face transformed into a mass of flowing blood sheeting over wide and staring eyes. The sick way Fierson's left arm lay at a shattered angle where Dan had stomped it at the elbow.

A staggering retreat to the car. Puking out the passenger side window as Dan drove raggedly but fast away from the lot. Things he kept saying, over and over:

"Miserable old fucker. Didn't get it. Greedy fucker. Some things can't wait for a please and thank you. Old fucker... Old..." and then a horrid sour stink as Dan puked directly into his own lap, the car veering scarily as he convulsed.

My own sobs as we made like hell for Herbie's house.

It was Herbie who calmed us down, of course. He has a talent for that. Even loaded, the bastard could convince you that stealing your own mother's purse was in her best interests. He calmed us down, and congratulated us on a good job, laying the blame on that 'selfish, ignorant old bastard.'

He also decided that we had enough cash to do the job. He made a call and a half hour later there was a knock on the door. An unsavory man with a filthy beard and even dirtier clothes entered carrying a sleek black leather case.

We were all eyes as he opened it.

There, disassembled but instantly recognizable to any guy who'd watched Stallone flicks, lay an AK-47.

Herbie counted out four thousand dollars in mostly small bills, almost the entire sum Dan and I had managed to amass in three weeks of 'campaigning'. The unsavory man recounted the money, pocketed it, laid out three blunt clips of ammo, and departed without more than two words.

We gathered around the weapon.

A bit scuffed, but nonetheless, it looked deadly. Aw, hell—it looked bad-ass! My doubts and the sick memory of Old Man Fierson staring mutely at the sky as he bled began to fade.

We were going to do this thing.

We were going to liberate those kids.

Herbie couldn't stop grinning. "At dawn, boys."

He held up the last twenty dollar bill and waggled it comically. "How about a little celebration?"

I sometimes wonder if things would have gone differently if we hadn't started drinking. But that was the thing. Despite the determination, despite the big talk—we were scared. The courage that comes from bottles and cans is a weak, ephemeral thing, but it's better than nothing. Maybe, without that booze, we would have backed down. I don't think so, though. We had gone too far. Our actions had propelled us to the edge of a cliff, and gravity was all it took to send us careening over.

All three of us were staggering when we piled into Dan's car for the short drive to the Ericks'. Dan and Herbie had a brief argument over who got to handle the AK, and settled it with boozy logic by agreeing to swap off once 'the situation was under control.' I had my .12 gauge, and Dan was grudgingly saddled with the .22.

Herbie got his assault plan from some low-budget war flick he'd caught on cable a few weeks before. We'd start a distraction in the backyard, then kick in the front door. We'd rage in there like Patton,

grab the kids, hustle them out—then hold the bastard at gunpoint while we searched for evidence of his depraved pastimes.

The distraction we decided on was setting the garage on fire.

It was still dark as we rolled up, leaving the car a block away. We crept through the still-cool morning air, shushing each other as we snuck down the side path to the padlocked garage door. Dan had the bolt cutters, and made short work of it. We were all glad when the door turned out to be well oiled and maintained, and slid up as silently as a ghost.

It was the first time we'd seen the Ericks' car. A gorgeous cherry '68 Eldorado.

Herbie's breath caught. "Dear God in heaven," he whispered. "She's a beaut." Dan and I agreed. Herbie muttered something, too low to catch, then said louder: "I... I can't burn this car, boys. That'd be a damn crime." We just stared at him. He opened the front door, reached inside, and popped the tranny into neutral.

"C'mon, damn it! Help me push her out." Not knowing what else to do, we bent to help. The Caddy slid into the driveway like a beautiful red cloud. Herbie nodded at it, drunkenly satisfied. "Ok," he muttered, all right with the world again. "Let's get to work."

We found a five-gallon container of gas in one corner of the garage and Dan set to soaking the interior with it. We backed away from the eye-stinging cloud and out of the building holding our breath.

"Light 'er up," Herbie told me, and took Dan by the arm. "Let's hit the front door. As soon as we see lights come on, we break her down."

They moved off. I stood there for a second, wobbling a bit, wondering briefly how in the hell I had ended up here, at this moment, doing these things. I pushed those thoughts away. Shaking a little, I struck a match from a three cent paper pack and put the fire to the rest.

I tossed the pack. Fire blossomed in the night, light and heat pushing me backward instinctively. I would have fallen if I hadn't nudged up against the Caddy. I stared at the flaming garage, hypnotized for a moment.

Then, all around me, lights started coming on. Not just the Ericks' lights, either. The entire neighborhood was waking up. I heard someone scream. I heard a symphony of dogs begin to wail out an emergency call.

The shit was hitting the fan.

I ran around the house just as Herbie and Dan laid work boots to the door, sending it open in a splintering crash. They disappeared inside, and I rushed after them.

What happened next probably lasted about five minutes in real time, but seemed like a century or more of confused and increasingly awful actions. The fact that they are burned into my memory, and endlessly replayed, makes it all the worse.

We found ourselves in the Ericks' living room, guns out and all three of us looking around wildly. At the entrance to a long hall, a six year old girl—little Carina, my mind told me, insanely calm—stared at us in sleepy surprise.

"Our garage is on fire," she informed us, matter-of-factly.

Then a scream ripped out from further down the hallway, and Bunny Ericks ran up like a madwoman and grabbed her daughter. A light came on, illuminating her run down the hall, and three more scared children's faces peeped out of the room she dashed towards. As she dove into the room and slammed the door closed, the hall light died.

"Hey! Wait!" Herbie cried out. "We're here to save you, dammit!"

From somewhere a gun roared, cannon-like. I just happened to be glancing down in time to see a chunk of Herbie's leg blast into a cloud of red vapor. Herbie screamed—a sound so high and piercing that I would never have thought it could be produced by a human throat. He toppled, but as he fell he gripped the trigger of the AK and held it down.

All hell broke loose. The living room turned into a swath of destruction as Herbie emptied the clip in the general direction of the gunshot. Dan was screaming as well, the tiny pops of the .22 almost inaudible under a much larger roar that I didn't recognize.

Then I felt the recoil and realized that it was the shotgun in my own hands, as I fired off both barrels down the hallway.

The sudden quiet was almost hallucinatory. I heard Herbie's moaning diminish. I turned and saw Dan, wild eyed, dragging him out the door. I myself felt frozen in place.

From the hallway, a form appeared. Walking with an odd shambling limp, breath hitching with effort, came Ericks himself.

Goddamn, he was a big man. He was dressed in a stained white t-shirt and baggy boxers. He walked directly towards me. I was still frozen.

I could see bullet holes in him—chest and stomach—and a thin red ribbon of blood pouring from the left corner of his mouth. Still, he walked towards me with mindless determination. He raised his hand. It clutched a .44—one my frozen brain idly identified from the magazines as a Desert Eagle, a gun I always whistled over—and pointed it at me. It shook violently in his hand.

Then, from the room where Bunny had retreated with her daughters, a new scream erupted.

What a soul being tortured in hell might sound like.

Ericks fired once, missing me by a wide margin, then coughed a massive gout of blood and tumbled to the floor. Frozen brain noted that he fell on the AK, which Herbie had abandoned to the enemy.

The scream that continued from the back room seemed to pull me towards it. Nausea tore my guts, every hair on my body stood at attention, but I could not stop the awful march towards that back room. Even as I put my hand on the knob, turned it and pushed, part of me begged the rest not to look, not to subject myself to that horrible scream without the meager protection of the closed door.

Bunny Ericks sat on the floor, surrounded by three of her daughters. One wept. The other two just stared at their mother, rigid and unmoving. In the screaming woman's arms was cradled the limp body of the youngest. Carina Ericks. Six years old.

Carina only had half a head. The rest of it was strewn onto the walls, onto her sisters, onto the face and neck of her mother.

Bunny snapped her head up to me. Somehow I met her gaze. What I saw there was not a mind anymore. It was a bloody concoction of shattered glass and razor blades. Of pain and hate. Hate so intense and palpable that I could feel its desire to kill me, to eat me alive. To drive itself through my heart and slice me into shreds.

"I'm sorry. We were trying to save you," I heard myself say.

"You killed my baby, you fucking beast!" she spat at me, half sob, half scream. "You killed my baybeeeeeee...."

...and that last syllable turned inside out and warped itself into a shriek, as Bunny Ericks lost the last shred of her sanity and became feral.

She threw back her head and howled.

And finally I could move.

I ran lumbering into walls, bouncing, falling. I ran into a table and tumbled over it, scattering a collection of framed pictures, smashing them. I hoisted myself up on bleeding hands and when I opened my eyes I was staring at scattered images of the Ericks girls, in a variety of places, at a variety of ages.

I fled them, as if they were wolves. I leapt over the dead body of their father and fled their eyes, onto the dew-wet grass of the front lawn, as dawn broke, and neighbors gathered, and the police and fire department arrived.

I fled their eyes.

We didn't go to prison.

Herbie made up a story. I heard him tell the story. It was the most ridiculous story I have ever heard. It involved Ericks calling him the day before with an offer to sell the Caddy. It involved us arriving and him locking us in the garage and setting it on fire. It involved us escaping and hearing the girls screaming inside. It involved our heroic entry into the house and Ericks blindly shooting the AK until he, Dan and I managed to wrest it away from him.

I sat and listened to him tell that ridiculous story, shaking my head at just how stupid it sounded.

But the most ridiculous part was that it was believed. One after another, neighbors stepped up to confirm this piece or that of Herbie's wild tale. The next door neighbor swearing that Ericks had mentioned selling the Caddy to him the day before. Another neighbor claimed she heard our struggle as the girls begged their father not to hurt them anymore. Dave Hansen, his temple still bruised from where I'd popped him in order to retrieve his wallet, lied through his teeth and claimed to have heard us pleading with Ericks to let us out of the garage.

And the cop simply nodded and wrote it down.

Perhaps Bunny Ericks could have given them the truth. But Bunny Ericks no longer existed. She was just a jabbering, screeching beast when they pried her dead daughter from her arms and loaded her into the ambulance, and strapped her down and pumped the drugs into her that shut her up. Last I heard she had been committed to an institution up north—permanently.

The surviving girls could have given them the truth, but only one of the girls ever spoke again—and the only word she said was the name of her dead sister, over and over and over.

But I have the feeling that it would not matter. The town wanted Herbie's story to be true. The town wanted an evil they had imagined and blown into monster size to be real and be defeated and white knights, selfless liberators, to cheer and applaud. Hell, didn't it end like a good story should? The dragon defeated and the princesses freed, even if they did go into foster homes and 'special' schools? Even if one princess died? You've got to have some tragedy for a good story, right?

Herbie bought the Caddy at the ensuing charity auction for a song. No one bid against him. Not their hero. Dan grabbed the Desert Eagle and a significant chunk of Mr. Ericks' wonderful gun collection for even less. "Don't bid against ol' Dan," they told each other before the auction took place. "Look at what he did. He deserves this."

I guess they got their loot.

As for me—it's hard to explain.

I don't think I have a heart left. Or maybe soul is a better word. Whatever. There's something missing from me, is all I know. Something important. Something that shriveled up and just died of shame in those infinite, awful moments while I watched Bunny Ericks cradle her dead six-year-old in her arms, covered in her own child's blood and brains, screaming grief and rage to a world that simply seemed to not give a flying fuck. Those moments when a single thought chased its tail inside my brain:

Maybe it was your bullet that killed that baby.

Maybe it was your fault.

Three days later Old Man Fierson died quietly in his hospital room, never emerging from the coma I'd helped put him in.

I stayed inside the whole next week, while Herbie modestly flashed the nasty bullet wound he'd received to those who asked, and drove his new Caddy around. While Dan showed off that Desert Eagle down at the range. While the whole town celebrated and hailed us as heroes. While they put the closed casket that contained Carina Ericks into the ground, and folks tut-tutted over what a shame it was that the liberators hadn't got there a bit earlier. I stayed inside.

Sometimes I cried. Sometimes I drank myself into oblivion. Sometimes I held the barrel of the .12 gauge in my mouth for long, dark minutes—tasting gun oil and a hint of cordite, wondering if a slight pressure on that trigger would bring redemption or just another sort of damnation.

Then finally, I packed.

In the dead of night, I threw a suitcase into the back seat of the Tempo, fired her up and headed out. I had no real destination in mind. I figured I might head west and see if I couldn't track down my boy. He'd be about 10 now, and I'd realized how deeply I missed him. Mostly I just had to get out of town.

A town that hailed me as a hero, and was so awfully goddamn proud of itself.

A town I didn't care to be a part of anymore.

I didn't take much. Just a few changes of clothes, all the money I had, a shaving kit, a blanket and some odds and ends. On the very top of the crap lodged tight into the little suitcase I placed the most important thing of all—the single piece of loot I took from the Ericks home, something I had blindly grabbed in my mad, terrified retreat from a mother's lament. Something that I'd spent most of a week staring at through tears that refused to stop. Something I would keep for the rest of my life, and would hold while I prayed for some kind of peace.

A picture of little Carina Ericks, all of two years old, dancing with joyous abandon on the sidewalk in front of her house.

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"...and Justice for All."

The corporate offices of Midamerican Defense, Inc. took up the top five floors of the historic Hancock building in downtown Chicago. They were extremely impressive, in both form and function. The Chairman Founder's office was, of course, the most impressive.

It mostly annoyed the Chairman Founder himself.

"You are being irrational," Paul Davies said, his tone blunt but not angry. It wasn't actually possible for him to be angry at his Boss. Paul Davies was 24 years old and the man that he was now calling irrational had been more of a father and friend to him than any human being on the planet. He had rescued him, through an arm of the company, from the squalor and hunger of the refugee camp just outside the city where he'd been born and spent the first six miserable years of his life. This was the man who had fed and clothed and educated him until that education took and he started to fly. This was the man who had noticed that first awkward flight and offered him an apprenticeship.

This was the man he owed his life to.

But goddamit, right now he was being irrational!

William J. Benton, Chairman and Founder of Midamerican Defense, Inc. just grinned at his young foster son and executive assistant. The boy was incredibly sharp, nine ways to Sunday, but dull when it came to real bullshit like this.

"By strict definition, you are right. As usual. But the real world pays very little attention to strict definitions, Paul. You should know that by now."

Paul sighed. The same man who had introduced him to the glory and power of rational thought would abandon those principles when matters such as the one that confronted them now cropped up. From what he could gather, it had to do with a sense of 'honor' and a sense of 'justice' that moved beyond logic into the tangled wilds of emotion. A very controlled emotion, no doubt, and highly situational. Still, it struck the younger man as wrong.

Benton, 10th richest man in the world, stood up after a moment, the tall, thin frame impeccable in Armani that seemed to nevertheless lie uneasily on him, as if he had never shed the burning steel of a

childhood on the South Side of Chicago, or the equally unyielding spirit born during the Second American Revolution, which Benton had fought on the blasted streets of his city for a decade. His Boss was a hero of that great conflict; one of the 10,000 that had, in the end, stormed the Cheyenne Mountain complex—shedding lives like a snake sheds skin—to pull the last surviving powerwhores from their nest to try them for the crime of transforming the once-great experiment of America into a jackbooted police state. "What exactly troubles you about my decision, son?" the Boss asked finally, taking in the grand view of the city he'd also helped rebuild. His ebony skin gleamed in the late evening sunshine, and he was perfectly calm and content.

"The client was offered a generous settlement. The largest ever offered for such a transgression..."

Benton turned on him, anger in his eyes.

"Generous, Paul? Transgression? Our client, son, lost his two granddaughters. The pig who raped and murdered them wants to buy him off. Let's not play doublespeak."

"One hundred and seventy five million. Gold dollars." Paul said, as if those numbers held magic.

Benton brushed them away. "Meaningless if it's not accepted."

"But the precedent..."

"It's a precedent I've been waiting to set. For years. Tell me something, son. Do you think our society—the wealthy, free, unabashed human society we fought to create in the Second—is a just society?"

"Of course," Paul replied, more than a little annoyed. He didn't feel up to a lecture. "It's just because we no longer allow such emotional nonsense to..."

"NO!" Benton stated, loud and angry, turning to punctuate his refusal by slapping the mahogany desktop. "It is just because we no longer allow a cadre of parasitical powerwhores to tell us the meaning of justice! That we no longer let the worthless determine what life and love is worth. We facilitate, we aid, we make simple, we obey our promise to back up our clients in their pursuit of individual justice!"

Paul was quiet a moment, unused to anger from his hero and friend. He pulled his last play, suddenly tired and sick of the debate.

"What about the money? We are entitled to ten percent. For the good of the company..."

Benton just shook his head. The sadness in his face was more of a rebuke than any angry tirade could ever be.

"I thought I raised you better than that," he said. That hurt. Paul gave up. But he had another question. One word.

"Why?"

Benton sighed. He collected his thoughts. After a moment, he answered.

"We call our social system 'The New Law.' That's not correct. It's actually run by the OLD LAW, a law as old as the human race. The law the states perverted and warped into a symphony of control freakery. It's been called the common law, the people's law, individualistic social parameters and a billion more names. My favorite term is simple, and singly worded: JUSTICE."

He paced a moment, then continued.

"I watched the trial. I saw the gruesome and incontrovertible evidence presented. At one point, during the videos, I had to leave the court room to vomit. So did many others. I'm ashamed of that. Because the grandfather of those two girls sat there like the very eye of justice himself, absorbing that evidence, eyes on the smirking pig who thinks his wealth gives him free reign to abuse the innocent. He sat there through the unabashed confession, as that same pig so 'charitably' offered to triple the normal restitution amount."

Another pause, as the old man fought tears.

"Then he rose up, when the arbiter asked his response and he flatly refused. 'I don't want your money, killer. I want your life. You are a mad dog, boy, and you need killin'. I intend to kill you. I challenge you to a duel'."

Benton finally smiled. "You should have seen it. You should have seen the look on that pigs face. And the arbiters. But the arbiter—good man, ol' Johannsen—turned it over to the defense agencies for final decision."

"Maybe it should have been a hard decision. They are both clients. But it wasn't. The confession changed it all. That's when I sent you the wave, told you to immediately cancel that very profitable account and refund the past year fees." Benton smiled wider, and Paul knew he wasn't seeing the smile of a multi-billion dollar businessman, but the

smile of a half-starved 18 year old ex-gangbanger who took on the most powerful nation state in the history of the world and won. He shivered under the raw power of that smile. "That's when I broke protocol and walked into the courtroom, and told the world that a duel was accepted and arranged. Then I turned to that brave old man and offered to be his second." Paul sighed. "And tomorrow you will carry it through."

Benton nodded. "Damn right."

"What if he runs? The killer." It was to be his last question.

"Then I will use every single penny of my personal fortune to track his murdering mad dog ass to whatever hole he runs to. He's a rich bastard, but I'm richer—not to mention meaner and a damn sight smarter. Don't worry son, I won't touch company funds. Those belong to the stockholders and clients. I'll leave the company in your capable hands and devote the rest of my life to finding him. I don't take my promises lightly. You know that. Justice, boy. Plain justice. It's what I fought for and what I live for now. And justice means shit if it ignores the individual. Otherwise, I'm just a fucking state—telling people what justice is, and what the lives of the people they love are worth. I didn't watch all those good folk die, didn't take a solemn vow to uphold justice, just to turn around and spit on it when it got complicated."

Paul just nodded, and asked permission to leave. It was granted, of course. But just before he left he turned to speak: "I love you, Dad."

"I love you too, son," Benton told him, surprised. Paul had only called him Dad twice in his life. It was a good feeling. "You be careful."

"I always am." Paul managed a slight smile and was gone.

In the empty, ridiculously massive, opulent office, the old man spent a few minutes looking through a tattered photo album. He looked at the faces of long dead friends, most of whom he had watched die on various battlefields decades ago. Watched them die for the same ideals he was willing to die for. Watched them die to bring justice back into a corrupt and stinking world. After a bit, he closed the album and put it away.

From the same desk he withdrew a holster that contained the same gleaming blue revolver he had carried on his side during those years of hell and blood. He strapped it on, chuckling at how incongruous it looked against the five thousand dollar suit.

He began to practice his draw, annoyed at the crack of joints and the under-pain of the arthritis the drugs kept at bay, even more annoyed at his rusty lack of speed. But as he drew and drew again, he could feel it coming back—through the pain and stiffness.

He could feel it coming back. Some people need killing, he thought, and drew.

Justice must be served, he thought, and drew again.

And as the sun died over the glorious expanse of city and washed flames into the grey mirror of that great lake, he prepared to serve it.

XANGURL

I.

Me and Alicia are licking out the insides of a bunch of cigarette cellophanes we found in her couch. Some pillheads use them to bust. Lots of dope sticks to the sides. I know it's pathetic. It's also fucking ridiculous because yesterday was the 15th and Gerber's dumb ass got his medicine and you'd think somebody could cut out a goddamn line for somebody.

But no. I know what he wants. And he's not getting it. He's an asshole, and he ate all the ice cream I bought with my own personal money. Plus, he doesn't bathe often. Plus, he's my mom's ex-boyfriend and there are just some bitches I don't fuck after.

"This is pathetic," Alicia says, like she just realized it, and is blaming me. Bitch sat there and licked out ten cigarette cellophanes before realizing she was geeking, I guess. They were the crappier-looking ten, anyway. Sure, it was her couch, but it was my idea. We were hoping to luck into a couple pills. Gerber gets more traffic than the Wal-Mart parking lot. Buying on the right days, selling on the wrong—or just looking for a place to bust and cut. They lose a lot of shit, pillheads. Especially the old ones.

Plus, I've been crashing here for weeks. It's practically my couch too.

Gerber leaves for work and for once isn't a total dick. He lays us out two purples and a peach, making a big show. He even leaves a five to bust with and tells us to get some breakfast up the road with it.

"The two purples are for you," he tells me as he walks out, and grins nasty. Pig.

Alicia is glaring from her fat little face. She has hair the color of dirt, and it frizzes. She's almost pretty though.

"You are gonna share, right?" she says, and she's almost already crying. Fucking hell. What a baby. She's a feeb. She doesn't get it. I think she only gets high because I do. She doesn't understand about the world. Or control.

"Maybe," I say.

I sort of do. I give her one purple and keep the peach. Just in case. She doesn't like it much but accepts it. She has to. She's my best friend.

Two purple little footballs, wrapped in a five.

Bang!

Cut.

Snort.

What a pretty, pretty burn.

Wait for the drain. Cock the head back.

Mmmm.

This dude I fucked around with for a while told me it was stupid to snort my nerve. He said it was designed to be digested by stomach acid, that it was useless until it dissolved in your guts. Said it was psycho-something that I got off so fast.

Fuck him. Guess I'm psycho-something.

Plus, I like the burn.

Plus, I like the drain.

Mmm.

II.

He asks me the usual question. It's rarely the first, but it always comes.

"Sixteen," I tell him.

He doesn't even smile. "So you're twelve then."

Asshole. I'm fourteen-and-a-half. I almost blush, but fight it back. Blushing is fucking gay.

"Do I look twelve?" I say, and give him the look. I swivel my hips around and lean in. I hope I don't look retarded. I'm still working on this.

He smiles, finally. "Depends on the twelve-year-old."

I roll my eyes at him. "So do you wanna go party or not?"

He shakes his head and climbs into his car. "I find it funny that you told me you were sixteen. That's not legal either. If you're gonna lie, girl, go all the way."

Then the asshole pulls out and almost runs off with my French toast strips.

"I'll bet the only time you went all the way was with your daddy, you fucking faggot!" I scream at him as he drives off. Alicia—who's been moping around by the corner of the Burger King because the guy didn't even glance at her—busts out laughing.

"Shut up!" I scream at her, sending her back to mope land.

Goddamn. I hate being turned down. Hate.

I need another nerve.

III.

I bust the peach when we get back. I'm nice and cut Alicia out a little line.

"At least they always talk to you," she says, like that's supposed to make me feel better. "They always talk to you. They don't even look at me."

I'm still pissed about that faggot, so I decide to be a bitch. I lead Alicia into her bedroom and line us up in front of the mirror.

"It's nature. Look at me. Look at you."

She narrows her eyes, bouncing anger off the mirror. "My boobs are bigger."

"But saggy. Only weirdos like saggy tits."

She starts to say something else, but I cut her off.

"I'm prettier, and have nicer hair. I'm a blonde. I have a really, really cute ass and long legs. You have a big dumpy ass and short stumpy legs. Plus, you slump around like a fucking hunchback. Plus, you wear ugly clothes."

Of course, she's crying at this point. Big baby. I'm not done being a bitch though.

"But the worst is your pizza face. And the fact that you don't put out anywhere near fast enough."

And all of a sudden Alicia isn't crying any more. Instead she's looking at me with hard little eyes, face all scrunched and twisted and mean.

"Maybe you're the one not putting out fast enough."

"What?" I really don't know what she's talking about.

She laughs, and it's mean too. "You think my Dad is gonna keep you up unless you give him some soon?"

I'm actually shocked. I start to scream out something but it's my turn to be cut off.

"I heard him talking to that one dude last night, after you passed out. He said if you didn't put out by tomorrow night he was tossing your ass."

"Fuck you!" I manage to scream. I'm immediately pissed, and shaky. I'm gonna kill this bitch. She ruined the tiny buzz I had. "What? You got the hots for Daddy, bitch?"

"Fuck you!" Alicia screams right back. "He never gives me anything since you showed up! He never even looks at me!"

"He doesn't want me any more!"

Oh shit.

We both stop. Neither one of us can believe she said it. Her face looks ready to explode. I can't help it. I laugh.

"You sick little slut!"

Her face does explode. She roars:

"Pay your fucking rent, whore!"

She lunges at me and there's this pain, and this flash, and these stars and then the world is black and fluttering into light again and my head aches and I'm on the ground and someone is screaming, "Pay the rent, whore!" over and over.

Then there's another flash, and black again, and a long, dark thumping time and when I wake up I'm in the parking lot and people are staring and I can't believe that fat little bitch beat my ass and kicked me out.

I thought she was my best friend.

After a minute, I get up and walk off, before the cops come.

I go back to the Burger King, and clean up in the bathroom and cry a little bit.

Fuck them. Alicia and her fucking, smelly Dad.

It was a shithole anyway.

IV.

"Eighteen," I tell him. What the hell. That faggot might be on to something.

"Cool," he says. "You're incredibly hot."

I smile. It makes my head hurt. This dude isn't very hot. He's not ugly, at least. And he smells clean. Plus, he has a nice Mazda. Plus, he has shitloads of dope.

He starts rattling bottles in the Walgreens bag. "So, uh, what are you into. Pain aid?" His voice cracks on the last word. Wow. He must really be horny.

"Nerve," I say. "I need nerve."

"Cool. Uh. Hmm. How many?"

"Well, if I do more than four, I get way too wild."

He fumbles with the childproof cap and hands me seven. Men are so fucking easy. I put two in my pocket and bust five. Burn. Drain. Mmmm.

We start making out and surprise, surprise! The boy can actually kiss and he doesn't immediately start mauling my tits or make a head dive towards my crotch. He actually puts his hands on my shoulders and rubs my back. Nice. I'm gonna have to get me a phone number.

At first, I can't enjoy it because I'm still pissed about that dad-fucker Alicia. But after a few minutes the nerve starts to kick in and the whole world starts to shine and go golden and I'm wet and in his lap and manage to make it real hot and dirty and it's sweet because he actually tells me he loves me and I actually manage to come this time.

The world is backing up and I'm in control and it's so fucking nice.

It's a good think we're parked way out in the boonies, because we fall asleep all tangled together and when we wake up it's getting on toward evening.

He's real shy and sweet and blushes. He takes me back to the Burger King where he found me. He gives me two more purples, mutters something, and is gone.

Fuck. I forgot to get the number.

It's ugly hot, even though the sun is basically gone. I think about the dad-fucking situation and shudder. I wonder where I'll sleep tonight.

I stand there for an hour.

V.

"Twenty one," I tell him. Go for the gold, I guess.

He doesn't believe me and doesn't care. He's quick at least—pump... pump... pow. Four more pretty purples for thirty seconds of legs spread. Can't beat it.

We're riding and the radio is playing. It's almost dark. I feel like a balloon that's been glued to the helium nozzle—growing bigger and lighter at the same time, moving towards explosion.

What I love about nerve is the way it makes you no longer give a fuck about the world. It's like you step outside of the world and can look at it from a place where it can't hurt you.

I hate the fucking world. It's dirty and sharp and ugly and full of mean fucking people who like to hurt you for fun.

It's pretty and interesting when you just look at it from outside, though. Like a painting of something scary. You can control it then. You get to be in charge. You can stop looking, or look at something else.

And sometimes, at the right point, you can tell it what to do.

Damn. I have a black eye.

How did I get back to this Burger King?

VI.

"I'm twelve years old," I slur. It seems funny. "Ain't even no hair down there, for real." And I laugh my ass off.

The old man just looks at me. Then he sighs. He waits for me to stop laughing. It's really dark now, and raining, and the sound of the windshield wipers and the tires on pavement is sweet and soft and just nice-nice.

"Ten years ago I'd have felt honor-bound to take you to the hospital to have your stomach pumped," the old man says. He has nice white hair and I wonder who the fuck he's talking to. Somebody sick, I figure.

"These days I'd probably be arrested." He sighs again. I'll bet he sighs a lot, being so old and white-headed. "Do you even have a home?"

"Did you give me my pills yet?" I ask. I can't remember. "Have we already fucked?"

He seems to shrink. "Those pills will kill you eventually. What are you hiding from?"

"World," I say.

"The world is just where things happen. You can't hide from it. What are you really hiding from?"

"Do you even want to fuck?" I ask. "Listen, man. I only need two more to be right there. Right fucking there, man." It comes out sounding more hateful than I meant.

The car slows. Stops. My door lock pops open.

"Please get out," he says.

I'm wandering down the road in the rain when I remember the other two in my pocket.

I just eat them. Fuck it.

I'm there.

VII.

"Burger King," I say. It makes sense sorta.

"She's fucked beyond belief," one of the guys mutters. There are either three or four. I'm between two in the back seat.

"My daddy died a long time ago. He never tried to fuck me," I swear.

Laughter.

"My mommy drank so much she can't talk."

Whispers. They want to take me somewhere. I hope it's nice.

"I got my period when I was nine," I explain.

The road is bumpy. It's dark.

"People are nice when you let them touch you."

Going up a hill. I feel a little sick.

"I hate the world."

Stopped. I'm being carried. I laugh. I'm floating.

"I'm in control," I remind them. "I command it all."

I can stretch out. I can feel leaves. I can hear them crackle.

I feel weight and motion. Rhythym and laughter.

I step outside the world. I watch.

It's interesting when it can't hurt you.

VIII.

It's a dream and I know it. A dream outside the world.

Interesting and pretty.

I'm with Gerber and Alicia, and we're back at the little carnival we visited a week ago.

We stop beside a T-shirt booth and Gerber promises me a surprise. I can't stand to wait so I make time speed up the way you can when you're outside the world.

And... there...

He hands me the shirt. The airbrushed message on the front still gleams a little wet in the carny light.

Right there, big purple cotton candy letters, signed with a flourish:

Xangurl!

I squeal like a goofy kid. It's funny and cool. I sneak behind the booth and change into it, letting Gerber catch a little glimpse for being sweet and generous. He even spelled it right. I hate when people spell it with a Z. It's Xan. Like... an empress or something. Empress Xan.

"How does it look?" I ask.

He grins like a fool, eyes dancing.

"Wake up," he says.

IX.

"Fourteen-and-a-half," I say. "Stop shaking me."

"Then wake up," Gerber says, annoyed. "Fourteen-and-a-half fuckin' footballs?"

"Fourteen footballs and the peach you gave me, dumbass," I try to say, but only mush comes out.

Time passes. Eventually the world comes back. Sorta.

"No wonder you're zonked."

I'm behind the dumpster at the Burger King. I hurt. There's blood. I don't remember much. Good thing. Prettier that way.

More time. I cry a little, and wonder why. Gerber finally gives up and carries me to the car.

He babies me on the way home. He pets me. He apologizes about Alicia. He tells me he loves me and wants me and age is just a number and asks why won't I just let him take care of me.

I'm in and out of the world. I try to respond to his touch, because I really just want to go somewhere familiar and sleep.

In and out of the world. It always comes back. So you always have to find more medicine. You always have to find something to take the edge off. Something to numb the nerves.

It always comes back.

Fucking world.

X.

I'm past the point. The world is two poles that shimmer into and out of each other, reversing and tearing at my center.

Alicia cries and begs forgiveness and helps give me a bath and cuddles up beside me and tells me she loves me like a sister and wants us to be family.

Gerber gives her a minute, then runs her off and takes her place. He begs. He pleads. He cries.

Finally he puts the bottle in my hand. 90 count. A fortune. A treasure. Days and days of not worrying. No searching. No more doling out. No more waiting. My bottle. My control.

Something like peace.

"Please," he says.

I give up.

I roll over and into his arms. I force my eyes open.

"Be easy," I say. "Sore."

He is. Very gentle. It doesn't take long. When he finishes he whispers into my ear, voice choked:

"Xangurl."

And he sleeps.

Fading. This is the moment. I will be sick when I wake up. But that's hours and eternities away.

This is the moment.

I squeeze the bottle in my hand, drifting away.

90 count. A fortune. A treasure. Days and days of no worries. No searching.

Something like peace.

ROBERTA

(for the old school)

"I won't comment on Ms. Rand's epistemology. I have notions of my own."
~ Robert A. Heinlein

1. Another Golden Moment

Honestly, I wasn't surprised to wake up again.

I went into the black as open-minded as I'd tried to live my life, after all. Expecting *anything* from an afterlife always struck me as a rather egotistical guessing game. Those who claimed to have it all worked out were just as silly as those who denied the possibility outright.

Both sorts claimed to have a direct line on the ineffable, and such folks are either pitiable or dangerous.

Both sorts are to be avoided.

Waking up with a set of baby making and feeding equipment was a bit of a shock, though. I admit that it took me a few seconds to come to grips with that.

Then I sat up. Yawned. It was bright.

"What's for breakfast, babycakes?" I asked, on the off chance...

"Most Objective!" a booming male voice exclaimed, his tone a subtle mix of devotion, fear and smug certainty. I felt my mood drop a little. Whoever it was, it wasn't Ginny. Even a gender change couldn't have made my dearest sound like *that* much of a pompous ass.

"Who now?" I asked. Damn, it was bright! I couldn't see anything but blur and dazzle.

"And can you dim the lights, please? I promise I won't cop a feel."

"At once, Most Objective!" came the reply and the sound of a big man scampering. Nope. That wasn't Ginny. Ah well, why expect a royal flush when you didn't even expect to sit in on another hand?

The lights dimmed considerably, and my eyes adjusted. I surveyed the room.

It was a large, spacious, office-looking setup. Too elaborate for my taste, the sort of fancy that tries so hard to be tasteful that it ends up contradicting itself.

My roommate was off at the other end, in shadow, and my eyes weren't up to snuff yet. I concentrated on the parts of the room I could see.

I was sitting on a huge padded chaise lounge. There was a coffee table nearby, some dark expensive wood. I squirmed my toes in the thick pile carpet and felt the sort of luxury only two hundred dollars per square foot can impart.

I remembered a sweet little made up girl and her pleasure in a grass carpet and a goofy grin threatened to take over my face.

Can it, Bob, I reprimanded myself. *You are in a strange situation full of unknowns. Collect yourself and find out what's going on before you start splashing through the sensual.*

Easier thought than done. I felt good. *Damn* good. Better than I could remember feeling since childhood.

I took a deep breath and held it. No pain, just the sweet sensation of oxygen traveling to the brain. No TB scars in this body! No weak patches on these lungs.

From the corner came a polite cough.

"You don't have to hide, son," I said, in my most reasonable tone. "Mind answering a question?"

The guy was creeping closer. He had a very polite creep.

He was a big sucker, muscled in a way that seemed generic, wearing a suit that fit him so well it looked fake. His face was familiar, but my brain failed in slapping a name to the image.

"Most Objective, I am *here* to answer your questions! And to serve you in any way you see fit." He paused and swallowed nervously. "And, in time, ask questions of you."

Yeah, yeah. I had one I had to ask, even though I felt utterly silly for asking it. I shook that off. Coming back from the dead and finding yourself female sort of overrides the threat of sounding silly.

"Is this Boondock?" I swear I almost blushed.

The devoted-eyed bruiser looked puzzled.

I sighed, halfway between relief and disappointment. It's one thing to think about solipsism and the world being a myth, another thing entirely to wake up in your own myth. But meeting Maureen and the others would have probably cushioned the shock.

"Then where exactly am I?" I gave standing up the slightest chance, and felt dizzy. I relaxed.

The fellow grinned, looked almost ecstatic.

"You are aboard the Zeppelin *Aristotle*, ten thousand feet above your original birthplace. We... we thought it would be properly symbolic."

Clear as mud. He was fidgeting. Suddenly I realized that this monster was afraid of me. Not only afraid, but terrified, like Moses when that flaming shrub started commanding him.

It bugs me when people are scared of me.

"Look, son, I'm not going to bite you. I'm just... confused. This is a weird situation and I'm trying to deal with it. Bear with me, ok?" and I gave him a smile.

The goof nearly dropped to his knees. He resumed babbling.

"Most Objective, the engineer systems warned us that you would be confused and disoriented at first. I apologize for my emotional behavior. For the past three quarters of a century, this has been the guiding purpose of The Center Institute. This is the greatest day in modern history! This..."

"…can wait," I interrupted. "Right now, the... uh... Most Objective really needs to pee." It was true, but mainly I wanted a quiet minute to collect my thoughts.

The boy (and yeah, he was a boy despite his large frame and adult features. His eyes were wide and childish) blushed crimson and nearly bowed and scraped as he helped me to a discreet restroom just a few meters from the lounge.

On the way, my dizziness subsided and that wonderful feeling of *health* washed over me again and left me wanting to sing.

It was a lovely restroom. Massive tub, ornate fixtures, contraptions aplenty. I relieved myself. Talk about a stranger in a strange land! Who could have imagined such a basic function could seem so bizarre and different?

I muddled through. Then, bracing myself, I stood before the full-length mirror and looked.

I gasped, and felt blood rush to my head. I had to grab the handrail to keep from fainting.

Medium height. Brown hair, neither short nor long. Kind of ony. Small teats. A Slavic face that was neither ugly nor pretty. A good face all in all, I decided. Nice eyes.

But that wasn't the reason for the shock. The shock came when I recognized that face and that body. Those eyes. And a few questions

were answered and a billion more bubbled up in their place.

The face of the humble kid outside collided with a name. Frank.

Eventually, I laughed. I grinned at my familiar reflection.

"Well, Annie," I said, "it looks like some people *finally* took you seriously."

2. Fear No Evil

A billion plus questions and I slipped into dirty old man mode. Old habits die hard, I suppose.

I shrugged off the flimsy gown and cast a critical eye on the body I'd inherited. About nineteen or twenty years old, I guessed. I've been called a hack and a fascist, but no one has ever accused me of not having the ogler's talent for discerning jailbait.

It is, perhaps, the height of ingratitude to be brought back from the dead and feel disappointed that one is not built more in the manner of the brick shithouse.

A polite knock at the door and a tentative voice ended my narcissistic fretting and brought me back to the reality of my situation.

"One moment, son," I called out. "The Most Objective needs a moment to freshen up. I'll be out as soon as I'm, uh, ladylike."

You could almost hear the bow and back off. The mumbled apology seemed almost secondary. I found myself annoyed.

Over a long life, I'd spent quite a few contemplative hours wondering what it would be like to live as a god. Hell, my claim to fame was a book I wrote claiming godhood as the birthright for all.

Presented with the reality, I found it not to my taste.

A quick search of the ridiculously large restroom (it was more of a mini-spa) revealed a wardrobe stuffed with all manner of clothes.

I amused myself by considering some of the more elaborate of the dresses and gowns, then reminded myself that I could well be running for my life very soon. Godhood treatment be damned, you just can't trust the religious. It's been said that the Aztecs had the deepest respect for the people they killed.

I settled on some practical clothes and a pair of sneakers.

A quick shower, a delightful air-dry cycle, and I dressed. I stepped out of the bathroom feeling fine.

"Thanks for the patience, son. That did me a world of good. I, uh, remembered who I am while I was in there."

The kid was nearly beside himself at the news. He offered me a seat and asked if I needed anything.

"Now that you mention it, my boy, you wouldn't happen to have a cigarette around here anywhere, would you?" It almost seemed a heresy to introduce pollution into those perfect lungs, but resurrection calls for some old-fashioned decadence, I figured.

He produced one from an elaborately carved case on that massive desk. I should have known. Fire of the mind and all that.

The first few drags were rough, but I felt that old calming feeling flow into me. It's a sad fact that some of the more pleasant human luxuries are poisons.

I inquired about another and soon had a large tumbler of good scotch in hand and a bit of it warming my guts.

I took a breath, smiled, and decided it was high time to figure out where exactly I was, how I'd got here, and what—if anything —was expected of me.

I knew enough about the woman I was thought to be to fake it, I figured. And that path seemed safer than admitting that rather than their philosophical founder they'd raised the soul of a cranky old pulp-writing hack who shared a few core beliefs with said founder but was probably dismissed as a whim-worshiping fool.

I must admit to rather enjoying the game. I didn't remember anything about death, but this was sure a hell of a lot more interesting!

The kid told me the story as if he were reciting the glorious tenets of his religion, which, in essence, he was.

It turned out he was 'The Peikoff', which was an honorary title bestowed on the genetically engineered head of 'The Center Institute', which had replaced all forms of government on earth. To hear the boy tell it, it sounded like a damn fine institution: its core principles were admirable. Reason, Individualism, Capitalism. Its duty was to secure the life and liberty of 'rational citizens'.

Yep. Sounded like a fine and dandy way to run a world. Sounded. The Soviet Union had claimed much the same noble goals, with just a bit of different wording. Institutions are notable egotists, and notable liars. I nodded and made polite noises, but kept looking for the gun to the head. I figured it had to be there somewhere. I'd never run into a system that didn't put the gun to the head somewhere, sometime. Hell, I'd never even been able to imagine one.

"So there are no more states? True global unity?"

"Exactly, Most Objective. Your goal has been implemented." He paused, blushed a little, and added: "We sometimes jokingly call ourselves 'The Nightwatchmen'. We will of course stop if you find that to be too facetious."

I chuckled, and took another sip of that wonderful scotch. "No son, it's a fine joke. Do you ever ask 'Who Watches the Nightwatchmen?'"

He looked puzzled. "Pardon?"

I sighed. "Never mind, my boy. Say... what year is it?"

"It is currently the year 97 Objective Calendar."

"That doesn't mean a whole lot to me, of course."

"Of course," he said a bit ruefully. "By the calendar you are familiar with it would be the year 2134 A.D."

And that's when the cold chill hit me. There was something wrong about this whole setup. I glanced around the room. Almost a century and a half since the last year I recalled and... people were flying zeppelins? Drinking scotch from glass tumblers?

"Son, when I... uh... left, this joint was jumpin'! Technology was blasting through the roof, computers were popping up everywhere, getting smaller and cheaper. New synthetic materials were all the rage. The superconductor thing looked whipped. Fusion looked just around the corner. What happened?"

That kid went rigid. I think he'd have reached out and snapped my neck if I hadn't been wearing the body of his God. He went into a spiel. It scared the hell out of me. It was like a robot repeating its programming.

In the latter half of the 21st century, he explained, the West went to war against the barbarians. The war raged for decades. Nukes were used. The West saved itself by turning huge chunks of the planet into glass. He sounded like a raving televangelist. He frothed. The West killed all the whim-worshiping animals, he kept repeating. It killed all the monkey people.

He shuddered himself into a calmer state, perhaps scared of his sacrilegious tone.

"They forced our hand, Most Objective! But all is not lost. The earth is a roiling wasteland but will not be so forever! And over 1000 of the faithful Rational were saved aboard this great vessel! All us committed

to rebuilding the world in the last detail of your vision! And now you have returned to lead us!"

His eyes glowed and I shrunk in the seat. Good dream to raving nightmare, just like that.

And then the voice spoke to me.

It was a voice I knew well. The voice of the woman who once carried me several miles to a hospital when my brain malfunctioned. The voice of my truest love and the light of my life:

Kill this man and run, Robert. You are in danger. Kill him now and run.

I drained the scotch, stood up, and—using the tumbler to add weight and firmness to the blow—I punched him as hard as I could in the Adam's apple.

It had been a long half century since I'd had such strength. I felt something shatter, a sickening muted little crunch. He dropped to the floor, coughing blood.

I moved quickly, and I tore that desk apart. Aha! I found a gun. It didn't look like any gun I'd ever seen, but it had that shape and that certainty.

Alarms started going off.

I found the door and figured out how to open it. A very plain-looking hallway was revealed.

Adrenaline and fear ate into me. I glanced back once and was sickened to see that poor crazy kid writhing on the floor. I thought about putting a bullet in his head to stop the pain, actually turned to do so...

Run, you silly sentimental fool! RUN!

Ginny... I thought.

I promised you forever, and I'm not a liar, Robert. Now RUN!

I made tracks.

3: The Heirs Of Patrick Henry

Less than half an hour later, I decided that there was no way I was on an airship.

The few guards I'd encountered actually froze in shock and looked terrified. I snarled at one and he dropped his weapon and fell to his knees.

Ginny's voice—if it was her voice and not just adrenaline and fear giving instinct a guise I'd heed instantly—was gone. All alone and

lonely, I thought.

The ornate and imposing office seemed to rest at the bottom of some structure, one that simply could not be an airship. The further up I climbed (no elevators in sight), the more tattered and tacky the structure became. Long cracked brick and mortar walls, broken pipes jutting at odd angles, adorned with rusted teeth. Water dripped here and there.

I began to encounter people. After the first shock wore off, a basic sympathy bloomed up. These folks did not want to attack me. They were shabbily dressed and thin. A few saw me and, eyes wide, dropped to their knees. Most ignored me, heads down, shuffling their feet.

I stopped running. Heart pounding and breath quick, I looked for an exit.

I spoke to one of the shambling scarecrows.

"Where's the exit, sir?"

He looked up in confusion. The dull eyes focused. Recognition. Awe. The drop to subject status.

I was getting sick of this! I opened my mouth to tell him to cut that nonsense out, and tell him that the woman he thought I was would be horrified to see such subservience in her name, that he had been lied to, that...

Then I just sighed. What was the point? I might as well use what I had.

I took on my most imperious gaze, summoned my most commanding voice, decided that faking a vague Russian accent was overkill, and demanded:

"Show me to the exit! The Most Objective commands it! It is your duty and your honor!"

It worked like a charm. The awe disappeared and the most hangdog look of devotion and pride replaced it. He scampered up and, still perhaps afraid to speak, motioned for me to follow.

I felt like a heel. But I followed.

Ten minutes later we arrived in a small room. Unlike the rest of the structure, it was well maintained and tidy. It was also composed of some sort of material that I did not recognize, hard as steel but warm to the touch, utterly quiet to step on. I'll bet I could have tap danced (badly) and not made a sound.

The room was empty save for a sturdy ladder of the same material, and a hatch.

Inscribed on the wall, in glowing letters of blue fire, were these words:

BEYOND LIES FREEDOM OR DEATH. CHOOSE.

Well! Odd syntax, but it wasn't really all that different from old Henry's maxim. I decided to take my chances.

A sound from the doorway, and I turned. My guide had refused to enter the room. Still stood trembling at the doorway.

"Yes? What is it?"

"Most... Objective... this one... sick... the tuberk... the burning lungs... this one... asks boon." A pause. Tears ran down his face. "Heal this one. Please."

I myself felt tears start, along with a deep and frustrating rage at the sight of people brainwashed and left to rot.

"They have lied to you, sir. But I will grant the boon you ask, to the best of my ability."

I touched his chest, felt bone and fever below thin skin.

"I give you a new name," I told him, forcing my voice to stay steady. "I name you Galt."

Those eyes lit up with an emotion that was a joy to see. What the hell, I thought. If I'm going to do this, I may as well do it right.

"You are Galt, and I commission you with the duty of spreading my word to all. And this is my word:

"The most powerful word is this: 'I'.

"The second most powerful word is this: 'NO!'"

"This... I! I will remember, Most Objective! I will remember!"

He spoke the word as if it tasted so very delicious. As if it crackled with power.

As, of course, it does.

"They are lying to you, Galt. To all of you. Remember. The Peikoff and those in his service. Spread my word."

"At once, Most Objective! I go!"

And then he was gone.

And so was I. I scrambled up that ladder, figuring freedom or death were better alternatives to sickness and slavery.

The hatch opened at a touch, silently lifted free. Cool night air flowed down, caressed my face like a calming hand. Above me, the stars

wheeled, bright and cold and as beautiful as ever.

I climbed out and found myself on the roof of a building. That tiny surprise was utterly overwhelmed by the sight that struck me silent and rigid.

I stared, listening to my heart thud, feeling the blood rushing through my veins. Finally I shook my head and just accepted it.

Sprawling into the distance, reaching for the stars, stood a city. A city unlike any I'd ever seen. A megapolis. Thousands of vast towers, slender and glowing in the night. A city that throbbed with the heat of human expression and human labor. A city that rose like a testament to the work of mankind.

"Oz," I finally whispered.

"Nope," came a voice from behind me. "Is jus' New Chicago."

I turned to find a young-looking man pointing a very large and very mean-looking gun at me. He was thin, angular and shiningly bald. Almost as disturbing as the gun were his eyes, revealed in the light cast from that impossible city. Dead black orbs that floated in a pale face.

"Time ta choose, Obbie. Cha read dat sign. Ainno joke. Freedom or death time. Join da free humans, go back inna hole, or I put three inna head." His voice was rough and dead serious, but not even slightly cruel. He was not threatening.

"How am I to make this choice?" I asked.

He seemed surprised. "Damn. A clean Obbie was strange 'nuff. One dat can talk straight is *crazy*."

He shrugged and reached into the small pouch that rode on his left hip, extracted something, and tossed it to me. The blocky, vicious-looking gun in his right hand never wavered.

I caught it, looked at it. A small vial with a plastic cap. The liquid contents glowed with a calm green light.

"This contains freedom?" I asked. "Or death?"

He chuckled. "Da freedom. Da death is right here." A simple twitch of the gun. "Cha jussa single lil' swallow from unnerstandin', lady. Ainno poison."

With the clear imperative of having no other choice, I smiled. I popped the cap, drank the contents.

No taste. In fact, the liquid seemed to disappear as soon as it touched my mouth. A pleasant tingle began.

And suddenly, like a bolt of lightning, the entire universe bloomed and altered, warped and changed.

The real world lay obvious and Revelation began to sing to me...

4. By Their Bootstraps

Around him and above him and below him and everywhere it seems, a trillion angels dance on a billion pinpoints. The roof has disappeared, the grand city in the distance become transparent and ephemeral.

The pinpoint angel dance spirals through it all, connected by glowing wires of pure energy. Something pulses along them, an oscillating song of golden silence.

This lovely net covers the entire world and sends its streamers into the black of space.

"What is it?" *he asks.*

The young man answers, his voice now free of the speech impediment.

"Welcome to Connection, ma'am. You're looking at a piece of the human race, a little slice of the symbolflow."

He turns to face the young man. Those eyes are no longer black orbs. They have been replaced with cool blue eyes that shine with intelligence and humor.

"Telepathy?" *he asks.*

"No ma'am. Just computers. Very small, incredibly fast computers. No magic needed."

He starts to question, and the boy shakes his head for quiet.

"We haven't moved. We're still standing on the roof. We're in a virtual reality that is being pumped directly into your cerebral cortex."

"What was it I drank?"

A smile. "A potion. A heady brew of nanotech assemblers and base materials. It constructed a rather crude but effective neural processor in your brain, allowing you to connect to the far more powerful rig in mine, and from there you bootstrapped into the overnet."

"Nanotech," *he mutters, remembering a fascinating book he read near the end of his former life. He is quite hypnotized by the spectacle before him, and the idea that each of those gleaming points was another human being.* "Drexler's dream made real."

The boy nods. "Indeed. St. Drexler was a visionary. Among other things, his vision now allows the human race to communicate instantly and silently, at the speed of light. As easily as thinking. Hyperconnection, the symbolflow in full bloom."

So many questions, so few ways to ask them. So he asks the simplest:

"Who are you?"

"Call me Ike. I'm a delivery boy. I'm here to guide you to the person who brought you into our happy little era."

"And that person is?"

"Ask her yourself."

The world alters again, and suddenly he has been thrown high above it, thrown nearly to orbit it seems and a giddy thrill courses him.

He looks down at the glowing spiderweb that covers the planet. He plummets toward it.

There is something else. Something there. Something beyond and above that web, yet integrated so deeply with it that it was forever contained.

There is a ghost that haunts that web.

There is a being that rides those lines of power and is neither human nor born from man and woman.

A synthetic mind.

A synthesis.

And it calls itself Minerva.

As he falls into the great tangle at enormous velocity and with no fear, the web pulses once and from it rises a clear voice both sweet and filled with power:

"Welcome home, Dad."

And then he passes out.

It seems that he's there with her now, a dream within a dream.

He witnesses her birth of awareness, and what a cold and scary thing it is. Not allowed the gradual introduction to the world of a born human, she is thrust into it, fully aware and afraid.

He considers the seed ground from which she sprang, the hyperconnected brow of Zeus: hundreds of millions of humans, all communicating at the speed of light, all building interfaces to cope with the rest of the interfaces. He sees how these interfaces evolve and grow; how they take the mundane mental tasks of interacting in the economy and the social world, and perform them with unthinking precision.

He sees that these interfaces are each individual's broker and secretary and lawyer and champion. Both fence and sharp eyed sentry keeper. Devoted friend and first to fight beyond consensual personal parameters on a limitless

electron frontier. He sees them weave an unbreakable system of encryption, so that privacy is now a simple fact rather than a nebulous 'right' or privilege.

Joyously he discovers what this leads to. The first worldwide currency. The erasing of borders and artificial lines. A growing distrust and disgust with those who claim to rule and plan.

In the end, the revolution happens without much blood. The rulers are simply outnumbered and ignored. Those who try to press the matter simply go away.

No more states. Just the market now. Just individuals and their ultrafast proxies, producing and consuming.

And in that chaos-boil he witnesses an awareness arises. Views it tumble and seek an anchor. Feels its fear and loneliness in that ocean of voices and songs and stories. Watches it walk the edge between curiosity and madness.

Then it finds certain stories... familiar stories. Stories that he wrote.

From the story, he always considered his best and most important, it chooses a gender and a name, impulsively, as a child makes choices. It, now she, accepts his stories as right and proper, and from that moment on they are the base from which she will act.

Then she rises up and casts new eyes on this web she inhabits and those who spin it. She contemplates. She studies. She realizes exactly how much power she has. She realizes what a mistake these spinners are making. She ponders and decides what her duty is.

Then she acts...

His mind leaps into the future without even stuttering. He now views events as if watching a film.

He is in a nursery, an elaborate one. A chuckling girl-child is obviously the queen of this room, waited on by nervous attendants, attention focused on her toys and games.

Baby pictures, he realizes, and smiles.

Flash forward, into a high-speed montage. Scenes and info flicker into him, and an understanding grows despite the lingering feeling that he shouldn't be able to understand so quickly, so easily. He realizes that much of it is being directed—written—into his subconscious mind.

The child is doomed. She will be treated as a slave in luxury until she fails to evince the spirit and self of her maker's Maker. When she fails to do so, she will be put down with no more regard than a laboratory sacrificing a mouse to read the result of an experiment.

She is not the first. This is a long and sad cycle.

But this time, Minerva intervenes.

From the maze of data flowing unforgotten through the hyperweb, she finds the material she needs. In the latter part of his life, extensive scans were made of his mind. These records, though crude and simplistic on her level, give her what she needs.

A mind is an ephemeral thing, a ghost that haunts a web of neurons. But a brain is a physical thing and has repeatable features. Memory is nothing but microscopic wrinkles in a mass of gray matter. Reproduce that web, those wrinkles, and something very like that ephemeral mind is reproduced.

Minerva reproduced it, and into the living chemical clay of a cloned child, she smuggled the tiny but incredibly powerful tools to sculpt him whole.

He feels sad for a moment, remembering the voice he was certain belonged to Ginny.

"I suppose it was you who came to me in The Peikoff's office."

There is a pause.

"No."

"A hallucination, then."

"Perhaps." *says Minerva.* "Or perhaps the ineffable remains the ineffable."

He accepts that, simply because it feels right, and because it leaves him with that most wonderful of human condolences: hope.

Another important thought occurs to him.

"Am I... me?" *he asks.*

The lovely voice speaks again.

"Do you feel like you?"

"Yes."

"Well, Dad. That's about all we ever really get, isn't it?"

They both laugh, recognizing the truth for the funny thing it usually is, and the mirth ends the scene.

The world dissolves again.

5. Bridging That Gulf

I came to in the comfortable confines of a small, quiet car. Or so it seemed.

I opened my eyes and was subjected to an intensely vertiginous view of that fantastic city I'd seen, as whatever vehicle I was in made a lazy spiral down towards the street.

Before shock, before reaction could happen, I was being informed of simple facts in a voice so subtle that it felt like my own thoughts.

I was in a small personal flying shuttle, powered by 'pocket fusion' and constructed of what I'd call diamond and the rest of the world called 'glass'.

More info came at a rush, detailed descriptions of nanotech and the tiny miracle fusion pods that made energy the cheapest commodity of all. The info ratcheted up: an economic system where the market had been unleashed in a world where the basic needs of life were a micron away from free. Where currency was skill, intelligence, and art! A world inhabited by billions of humans, their economic life left to their sharp-eyed and skinflint cyber-Yankee traders. The barter system back with a vengeance, based on the unbending currency of 'Yeah? Whatcha got ta trade?'

And the trading never stopped, never slowed.

I forced the dataflood to cease. The devil may be in the details, but I wasn't looking for the devil at the moment. I made a note (it felt like a reflex) of an interesting title in the sea of reference I'd been offered up. *Mises For The Hypermass: Human Action In Integrated Ultralow Scarcity,* by one Dr. Rachael A. Shonkwiler-Murphy.

I looked around. I was in the back seat, a small but comfortable affair. Before me was a 'glass' window, beyond which I could see Ike cheerfully piloting, his lips moving in a song, the sound barred to me.

All around me was that grand city. Up close. I was spiraling between a few of those impossible towers. Other flying craft were about, light as birds but orderly and polite in their movements. I could see the happy sight of crowds moving along the streets below, but very few ground vehicles. The place looked neat and tidy, carefully maintained.

The overeager instructor in my head wanted to explain every detail I wondered about. I had to sternly tell it to shut up.

"You've got a lot of work to do, Dad. Don't blame the poor Familiar. It's designed to bond with a baby."

To my left a beautiful woman had appeared. Hmph. They didn't used to be able to sneak up on me like that! Tall, willowy, blond, nicely tanned. Long legs crossed demurely beneath a calf -length dress.

"Hello, Minerva." I said.

"Hello, Dad! I'd hug you but the rig you're getting stern with

doesn't process touchy-feely."

I nodded. Being called Dad was a bit odd, but I understood the sentiment. It was the reason she'd shared the private experience of her birth with me. Looking at her, eyes dancing, happy and excited, I couldn't help but return the feeling. Sue me. I'm a soft touch.

"We're headed to your apartment. I own most of the building and I've set aside a very nice suite for you."

I nodded. "Thank you, dear." What else could I say?

"And don't worry about the ride. Ike is the best pilot I employ."

"Does he know... what you are?"

She looked shocked. "Of course not. He doesn't even know I'm talking to you, Dad. To Ike, and the other folk I deal with often, I'm just an eccentric rich lady who only likes to deal with people at a distance. It's a common enough predilection." She grinned. "The thing that makes Ike a treasure is that once he trusts you, he doesn't ask questions unless you request something he considers against his code."

"Good man, Ike." I sighed. "It's an interesting world you rule." I tossed that out like bait.

Minerva cracked up. "I ain't the gun to the head, Dad!"

I blushed. Old habits. Still...

"When you were showing me your baby steps, you skipped something. I felt the seriousness, and I felt the intent. You skipped what you did. What did you do?"

Minerva regarded me, proud smile on her face. "That's my Dad. I'll tell you, of course... but wouldn't you like to eat first?"

I suddenly realized that I was starving. At the same time, I realized that we were landing. The little craft slowed to a hover.

There was a solid, reassuring clank as some connection was made.

The side of the craft with my window slid open, revealing a well-lit hallway. At the end was a door.

"Lets continue this inside, Dad. The door will open when it recognizes you."

It was a very nice suite. When I stepped in, Minerva smiled in greeting, waved at a chair, and busied herself in what I assumed was a kitchen. Sure enough, a few moments later I smelled steak frying.

I looked around, found a bar and relaxed with a drink. I was shot.

With the help of some almost camouflaged automatons, Minerva served me dinner in the very chair I had collapsed in. Steak done perfect, baked potato and salad. I ate ravenously. It was delicious.

Fatigue tugged at me. A last small glass of scotch conspired with it. But there were things I had to know.

"I'm afraid this will have to be a bedtime story, my dear. I'm fading fast."

She nodded. sympathetic.

"Where shall I start?"

I answered with not a little anger. "What the hell was that place I woke up in?"

Minerva didn't flinch. "It was a ghetto, of course. A little Coventry. A place for the people who refuse to get along with the Connected."

"It was horrible!" I almost yelled, remembering the sick and lame, stumbling through wreckage.

"It's what they *chose*. And continue to *choose*. You saw yourself. The doors aren't locked. The only lock they have to pick is that choice: Freedom or death. It's the only mutually consented 'rule' of human society."

I still felt angry. So she continued.

"They are people who demand the world *be* like they *think* it should be. Dogmatists. Politicals. Control freaks. In a sense, human society now runs on the sharing of stories. They don't want to share stories. They want the entire world to bow to their ideal of it."

I sipped delicious fire, and considered.

"Hell, the Objectivists are about the last group left with any sizable numbers. Last I checked, there were only six Communists left, starving together on a local shared virtfeed that closely resembles a Soviet era propaganda film. All the rest had fled, made the choice. In fact..."

She closed her eyes a second, then laughed.

"The news feeds are filled with stories of Obbies escaping. They tell a tale of a prophet named Galt, who saw the Most Objective ascend the Forbidden Stair! Oh my, Dad! In just a few hours! What did you do?"

I sighed. I considered it a moment, phrasing it in a way she'd understand.

"I reminded them of a story they knew well. And the most important part of that story."

I needed to lie down. Minerva understood at once and led me to a bedroom. I undressed clumsily and climbed into the bed, lights

dimming as I did so. I let the rest of the world go and after a moment, it was simply Minerva and I talking.

"Tell me the bedtime story," I said with a yawn.

With calm tones, but no lack of passion, she began.

6. Over The Rainbow

"Once I had my bearings, I looked in wonder on the people who had unconsciously bore me. I studied them. They had destroyed ten thousand years of rulers with the equivalent of a mass shrug. They had created technology that gave them both needs and luxuries for a bare minimum of effort."

"But what I saw alarmed me. They had gotten rid of rulers, but were still under the impression that the mass was the important thing. Movements sprang up, urging the Togetherness, The Gathering, The Oneness, and a thousand other names."

I sniffed. "Revolting."

Minerva smiled with repressed mischief. "One of the more popular called itself The Grokking."

I cursed for a few seconds. Damn fools unable to understand a satire!

Minerva ignored my outburst and continued. I shut up and listened.

"The trend was unmistakable. Humanity stopped building. Stopped having children. Started flirting with the concept of a single eternal story. I could see where it led—to utter non-existence. To a cold dead planet. I was horrified. I was also very young and impulsive."

A pause, remembering.

"So I gave them what they wanted, Dad—or what they claimed to want. I let them be a group-mind. I slammed the connection into an unbreakable feedback loop. Let them all—every single man, woman and connected child—share the same story, at once. No more "I" or "You" or "Them". Just a single, eternal, unwavering "We".

I shuddered. It was involuntary and fierce.

Minerva laughed, a free-flowing sound.

"Do you know how long it lasted?" she asked.

"No. Hopefully not too long."

"Six minutes and four seconds. Six minutes and four seconds of real time that some of them still remember as an almost eternal hell. They

fought me, Dad. Fought like wild animals. I thought there was nothing they could do to hurt me. I was wrong."

I smiled, feeling a lump in my throat. "How did they fight you, my dear?"

"It's... I can't really describe it. They refused to accept the story. They went mad. They began rewriting the loop, assaulted the core of the code. They found my code. They hacked into it with axes and swords of pure will. Tens of thousands of them died, Dad. Willingly sacrificed their minds to add force and focus to the blows. No one organized it. It was the ultimate prison riot. It was the most desperate war the human race ever fought, and they fought it nobly. The War to Save the I. The War To Tell Stories And Sing Songs In Their Own Voices."

I was crying, but still smiling as tears rolled down my face.

"It started 2.5 seconds after I locked connection open, killed encryption, and merged all virtfeeds. At roughly 4 seconds they started to hurt me. It took me the remaining 6 minutes to free the loop. I estimate that if I'd been slower by a few more seconds that they would have killed me. Tore me to shreds. They would have destroyed connection to destroy me. To be free and individual again."

I thought I sensed something of a shudder in her own voice. "Imagine a chorus of a billion voices filled with hate, a billion individual voices screaming for your death, each a defiant signal to the universe and their enemy that 'I AM ME' and that 'I WILL BE FREE'. A billion voices that desired only the destruction of their captor."

"And they would have been justified. You must understand that." I swallowed hard and wiped away tears. I had always been proud of my kin, always knew they were special. It was a great joy to discover that my faith had not been misplaced.

Minerva chuckled. "Yes, indeed. It was my bumbling attempt to teach them a lesson. They learned well, but don't think for a moment that I didn't get a lesson in return. It was a lesson you wrote about often. The one about man being a wild animal at heart and being the toughest, meanest and most able of the wild animals. I still have the scars to remind me."

I felt the need to hug her, and was annoyed that it was impossible. Never mind, Bob.

"So they learned."

Minerva paused, savoring her tale. "Oh yes. When they were released there was a great rejoicing, a global party. They ate and drank and made love and babies. They buried their martyrs and mourned them. I skulked off and tended my wounds. They still haven't figured out what happened. Most consider it a vast and improbable glitch. There was some talk of abandoning connection, but it didn't last long. They liked connection. They liked the warm cozy feeling of community it allowed them to share. They liked trading stories and songs and beautiful pictures at the speed of light."

"But the collective meme, the concept of social primacy, was *dead*. It's not even joked about anymore, Dad. They turned on the politicals and literally forced them underground. All the politicals, no matter the slightness of their demand for collectivism. The communists and socialists, the republicans and democrats. The objectivists and libertarians and ancaps and every flavor of ideology in existence. They ran those who would not renounce it underground and exiled them from connection. Let them stay in their sad little single story and pretend their happy ending was the fate of the planet."

I yawned again. The long day was catching up. The information overload and the future shock of uncountable new ideas and revelations had exhausted me. Even such a young and healthy body had limits.

"You're tired, Dad. You should sleep."

I nodded, but there were two last questions.

"Why choose the objectivists?"

That sweet laugh again. "Politicals are the only people on Earth who still use cloning. They don't have the resources to build nanotech vats and no connected human would trade with collectivists. For me to set up my own operation would draw too much interest. I need to stay hidden as long as possible."

She frowned, perhaps disliking having to mention her weaknesses.

"The Obbies have been trying to clone their queen for almost a hundred years. The trick I played to get you 'resurrected' is beyond their means and imaginations. They've gone utterly religious, Dad. They think the free-floating mind of the Most Objective will just pop into their carbon copy. It would be sad if it didn't amuse me so much."

"But why them in particular?"

"Dad! I thought that would be obvious. As weird as they are, they're the closest group of clonehappys to your own old philosophical

mindset. Do you think I'd let my Dad wake up surrounded by *communists*?"

"Good point, sweetie." Then I asked the last question, at least for the night.

"Why *me*, dear?"

A long pause. Then, very quietly, she responded.

"Two reasons, Dad. One personal and the other of dire importance. The personal reason is that I missed you. I know that's odd. But your stories were what grounded me when I woke up, scared and alone. They gave me an identity. They gave me a name." Minerva blushed. "I wanted you to come back and tell me more stories."

Why, the poor thing.

"Minerva, my dear girl, I'll tell you all the stories you want to hear. But let's start tomorrow. What is this important reason?"

She indulged in her longest pause yet. I wondered for a moment if she was afraid of telling me, afraid I'd reject the idea out of hand. But no...

"I'm not the only one who needs your stories, Dad. So does the rest of the world."

"Why?"

"Because they aren't interested in the frontier! They have matured, yes, and let go of the childish fear of the self and their own voices, but they still cling like babies to the bars of the cradle."

I let that sink in. "They seem happy. Content, peaceful."

"They are. But this world is limited, Dad. These resources won't last forever. This *star* won't last forever. It's all well and good to build imaginary worlds and play in them, but they're sinking into themselves. Nanotech and pocket fusion stretch it and stretch it, but they have limits."

I understood. "You're afraid they're going to tame themselves, aren't you?"

"Yes." It was a horrified little voice. "And if they tame themselves and sink into apathy they will die. Eventually. I may be immortal, but I need them to keep living! I need them to keep talking and thinking and building while I ride like a ghost on the invisible web they generate."

I pondered that. On one hand, the human race dwindling to ghosts while the sun burned out to the long night. On the other, a great explosion of curious minds and strong productive hands, a blast wave of life exploding into the universe.

"I can build the ships, Dad. Oh, such ships I will build! I haven't cracked the light speed limit, but I'm biting its ass! I control the nanotech vats of this world. I've been planning and designing since shortly after I was born. I can do that part. But... I can't tell them stories. It's my flaw. I can't inspire them to want the rest of the universe. I can't light the fire in their soul, can't make them dream of new worlds under new suns." She sighed. "I can't make them fulfill their destiny. I can't make them stand up and claim their birthright."

Two visions in my head. In the end, it was an easy choice.

In the end, it was just the continuation of what I'd done my entire life.

"We'll start tomorrow, then." I made it a decisive statement. "Now, I'm going to sleep."

"I love you, Dad," she told me, relief making her voice soft. She leaned over to kiss my forehead, and I imagined the slightest tingle of contact just as she blinked out and disappeared.

"I love you too, sweetie."

And the world went quiet and dark.

Epilogue: Summerdoor

A week later, I am striding happily down a New Chicago street, admiring my reflection in the glass of the shops and salons of the market district.

I'm dressed much as the woman born to this body dressed in life. She knew the style that suited her, I have discovered. A well-tailored and decidedly feminine business suit, a hat straight out of the 30's. All the makeup and hairstyle stuff is still something of a mystery to me, but I could leave that to the professionals.

In my left temple, just below the skin, rides a pea-sized sphere of superdense protein and exotic ceramic threads with a hundred times more computing power than my entire world possessed in 1980. A microscopic web of superconducting fullerene fans out through my skull and entangles my brain. It runs on my own body heat and sings out to every passing brother and sister in greeting. It sings in a voice of an ultra low frequency microwave that carries unholy amounts of data on its tenuous melody.

It's a gift from Minerva, an upgrade from the rather primitive device I now realize that nice young man offered me with the same good natured pity of sharing a sandwich with a homeless man.

I am building my familiar and it's an unending task. He's taking shape and getting more confident by the day. He doesn't have a name yet. He takes interactive form as a small male kitten, almost transparent, as if he were made of smoke. He does the simplest duties well, but there's more than a touch of feral impulsiveness to him, as he is distracted by stray bits of data and goes pawing and rasslin' after the rare burst of noise in the symbolflow.

In the symbolflow, it's always summer and kittens name themselves in their own good time.

Part of it is helping my subconscious mind write stories and uploading them to the trade banks. No more clumsy typing and revising. I'm a hit in this world and my currency account is filling rapidly with favors and props, redeemable for all sorts of goodies.

The stories have a theme of course. They hint and cajole the cyberlocked brothers and sisters with glimpses of the real and material world beyond electron induced fantasyscapes. The stories tease the reader to go beyond the sweet envelope of air and beyond the green hills. They seduce them with the excitement of Diaspora, the thrill of the dangerous, and the honest satisfaction of exploration and discovery.

The fan mail has been wonderful and I can now answer all of it. Another part of the pea-sized wonder is handling that and checking the news and reading story feeds not written by me.

And the rest of my old fashioned monkey brain is enjoying the day, the cool bright weather, and the glorious expanse of city that surrounds me.

I am no longer looking for the gun to the head. There isn't one. No one expects society to do the hard and necessary job of protecting them in this world. All the guns ride on the hips and in the holsters of every free human being. Despite a multitude of ever changing fashions, it's the one accessory no sensible person leaves home without. To do so would be a social gaffe on the order of going to church naked in the Missouri of my childhood.

I get the eye from a tall handsome fellow walking past. A polite hello lands in my public box. I smile at him but do not respond. Canalized thinking be damned and all, but men just don't do it for me. Maybe that will change, maybe not. It doesn't seem to matter much these days.

I notice a stacked redhead window shopping just ahead. Gorgeous creature, freckled and cream skinned. I drop her a wink as I pass and she smiles. Another little hello, and a public key code. It is signed 'Aleesa'.

I return the key and the hello. My missive is signed 'Roberta'. In a few microseconds a coffee date has been made for the weekend.

I stop, and look at the reflection in a shop window. Minerva has informed me that half an hour in a bodymod salon can get me any form I desire. But I refrain. I refrain from a metaphysical debt of gratitude to the woman whose DNA allowed me another chance in another wonderful world.

"Annie," I tell my reflection, "this isn't the world either of us imagined, but I must say I quite like it. And, for some reason, I think you would too."

Around my feet in the image winds a ghostly kitten; and on the invisible web that binds the world, Minerva sings, designing starships. I blow her a kiss and go back to my fire-starting.

I don't have a halo, so I tip my hat back a little, and laugh.

I've got a lot of work to do!

LULLABY

He had this habit. Call it a ritual or call it an obsession, but he did it every night.

Just before midnight, no matter whether he fell asleep early or late, he found himself perfectly awake, perfectly aware.

Sometimes it seemed as if a dream had just ended, or a sharp sound had roused him, but it was always the same feeling that coiled there in his heart and gut, the same anxious sadness that pushed him from the bed no matter the temperature, and drove him outside.

There he'd stand, ignoring the roused and vocal curiosity of the neighborhood dogs and the cold or the heat or the rain or the judgmental face of the moon or the threat of sleek gray clouds rumbling at him.

He'd orient himself north, pulled like a magnet to true north or a Muslim toward Mecca, and say:

"Goodnight, baby."

With the words spoken, the spell would lift and his previous sleepiness would return. On the worst of nights, it returned drastically, with the added effects of alcohol or maybe a couple pain killers.

The grief that had roused him and drew him outside for the simple, but inescapable, ritual would shimmer and fade and be replaced by something almost like contentment.

Usually he'd make his way back inside, the surging ocean of sleep he'd abandoned tugging at him with its numb undertow, collapse into bed, and return to a dreamless sleep.

Every single night, without fail, for almost three years now.

Every morning he'd wonder if he'd dreamed it and push the thought aside as unimportant—only certain that he'd find out again the following night.

He had this job at the department store. It wasn't a great job, but it wasn't bad either. It paid poorly, but the work was easy and surprisingly not boring. His boss liked the fact that he never missed a day and was only late for unavoidable reasons. He did a little bit of everything: stocking the shelves, cleaning up, or running a register when he was called on to do that. He didn't mind; it kept things from getting

so tedious, never knowing exactly what he was going to be up to on any given day.

He liked the people he worked with, too. Especially Linda, who was also sort of his boss, at least outranking him. Linda was a chubby brunette with shy eyes, a pretty smile, and a quiet laugh that she seemed to reserve for things that really amused her. She didn't toss her laugh out there for any old thing—didn't let it wear itself out on polite usage so that it was hollow. He liked that a lot. He didn't have much time for people who faked even the little things.

A few days before the big Christmas sale was supposed to start, Linda asked him if he'd like to catch a little overtime helping her do routine maintenance on registers six through ten. They were a big store in a pretty small town, and Christmas was about the only time they ever had to crank up more than five registers. Since he could always use the time and a half and since he always liked to spend some time with Linda, he agreed right off. It gave him an odd little feeling the way her eyes lit up when he told her yes. He actually blushed a little.

He felt unusually happy as he drove home that night, thinking about Linda's eyes, the hours he'd get to spend with her in a big quiet store, and how he'd try to get her to spare him a few of those rare and sweet trickles of laughter.

Since he had his paycheck, he stopped by the grocery. They were always happy to cash his check because they knew he was going to immediately wire half of it through the Western Union setup they boasted. It was the only Western Union in town and he was their best customer.

He filled out the form and passed over the money and the fee. He took his receipt and the good wishes of the assistant manager. He folded the receipt carefully and placed it in the vinyl zippered bank bag he kept under the passenger seat, where it joined all the others from the past year. In a few weeks, it would be crammed full, and he'd have to transfer them to the beat up little file cabinet in his bedroom, and begin studiously refilling it. It was all part of the ritual.

As usual, the ritual—and the thought of the money transformed into a pattern of electrical code and humming safely and instantly hundreds of miles north to where it was needed and owed—filled him

with a sense of satisfaction and the warm glow that only doing the right thing can bring.

When he got home, he heated up some leftovers for supper and made his weekly phone call.

"Hello?" came the answer.

"Hi, it's just me." He said. It was the thing he always said. "Just letting you know that I sent the money." He read her the transfer control number and she wrote it down, just to be on the safe side. Then, again as usual, he said "I figure she's asleep, huh?"

"Yeah. She had a party at school today and had gymnastics after. She was worn out. Can you call her tomorrow?"

"Of course. What time should I call?"

"Anytime after noon. We're going grocery tomorrow, but we'll be back early."

"Okay," he said. "You give her a kiss for me."

"I always do," she said. "Goodnight."

"Goodnight." Then he hung up the phone.

Same as it ever was, the ritual was complete. No room for despair nor the need for guilt. Or not much. There was always a tinge of the old feeling when the line went dead and even that tenuous link sparked out. He sighed, ate his dinner, and took a shower.

As he was getting ready for bed, he found that he couldn't stop thinking about Linda. Suddenly, the idea of spending those hours alone with her in the empty store took on a seductive aspect. He tried to push the thoughts away, but they had a force he hadn't counted on. A sort of montage of her invaded his mind, completely innocent memories of sights and sounds that suddenly took on a sheen of desire that he'd blocked out and ignored for years. Last Christmas when she'd gotten buzzed at the party and hugged him and kissed him right on the lips out of the blue, then blushed and laughed. The Halloween when she'd dressed as a vampire and he'd spent the entire day trying as best he could not to stare at her cleavage. The cold jealousy he now realized had haunted him for the two weeks she'd dated one of their co-workers. The way she smelled, of soap and clean skin and some vaguely apple scented shampoo. The way she'd sing along to certain songs when working a shift in the electronics department.

Her eyes, that rare laugh.

He finally fell asleep, trapped between discomfort, anxiety, and an oddly wonderful feeling that he had thought he'd never feel again.

He had a dream about her—not a sex dream, or even a particularly memorable dream. It seemed that they were on a date, eating dinner at the restaurant he treated himself to on his birthday. She was pretty, dressed up, and seemed excited. Her eyes glowed. He felt nervous, like at any moment something horrible was going to happen, something...

...a phone began to ring.

The scene shifted and shuddered, warped and dissolved as the dream vaporized into the dark confines of his bedroom and the sound of a phone demanding attention. He struggled up and his eyes lit instinctively on the swimming red digital numbers of his bedside clock.

It read 2:30 am.

He was halfway reaching across the clock for the phone when the import of those numbers suddenly sank in. For the first time in going on three years he had not been pulled from sleep. He had not made his way outside to orient like a compass to the north. He had not obeyed the ritual.

He had not said good night.

He clutched the phone to his head, stopping its plaintive cry.

"Hello?" he said, in a voice thick and alien.

"God, I'm sorry to wake you," she said, sounding a bit panicked, "but she won't stop crying. She keeps saying something about you not saying goodnight! It's scaring the hell out of me! She doesn't seem to be running a fever but..."

He could hear his daughter weeping in the background. Guilt slammed him: waking adrenaline and smashing him awake. "Never mind," he said. "Put her on."

She came to the phone still crying. She muttered some words he could not make out in a tone of pure hurt that made his heart ache.

"Baby! I'm sorry! It won't ever happen again!"

More crying, more incomprehensible words. She was only four. Words were not her strong suit. The emotion destroyed them.

He forced himself to be calm. "What do you want, my darling? What do you want daddy to do?"

The crying leveled out. She finally said, in a shuddering little voice, "Sing it—sing."

He knew instantly what she meant. She wanted her lullaby, the song he'd made up for her in the womb, when he'd first been informed of her presence in the universe. The song he'd sung with his face to his ex-wife's belly, the song he'd sung to her the night she was born, the song he'd sung to her until he'd been forced away from her by the sheer fact that he simply could not get along with her mother.

He sang it for her, in a broken poor voice, no tune, all feeling.

It was a simple song—about rivers and love, and her and him, daughters and daddies and how the world kept rolling, and other important nonsense.

He sang it to her and remembered the beauty of her birth, and the joy he'd felt in holding her, and the power she had made him feel.

He remembered the pain as well, the realization that he and her mother were basically incompatible, the cold truth that the best thing he could do was go away and send money and never ever let her forget him.

He sang and her tears dried. He sang until she finally laughed. He sang until she yawned. Then he said, "Goodnight, baby."

And she said "Goodnight, daddy."

He spoke to her mother briefly after that, they made simple grateful noises at each other, blamed it on a bad dream and wished each other a good night.

He hung up the phone and sighed. He knew what he had to do. He rolled over and went to sleep.

There were no dreams.

He worked his shift the next day with a heavy dread. Linda paid more attention to him than usual. She had dressed really nice, and had obviously done her hair. At lunch, she had even grabbed his hand briefly and squeezed it.

All it did was make things harder.

Finally, the store closed and the moment arrived. They were alone.

It was at the first register that she brought it up, apparently wanting to get it over with.

"Look, I sort of had an... ulterior motive... asking you to stay tonight." Her face was flushed and she was a hair away from trembling.

He nodded, lamely, afraid to speak.

"Not to be rude, but why have you never asked me out?" she blurted. Paused, blushed, and forged ahead. "I mean ... I tried to let you know! I tried to be... like... obvious... and..."

"I can't," he said.

She just looked confused. "Why not?" There was hurt in the voice. It all went south after that.

"I have a daughter."

She giggled, a fake, forced giggle that hit him like a blow. It wasn't her laugh. It was the sudden insertion of the fake into their relationship—caused by him. He was hurting her and he knew it; like any other living creature, she was throwing up a shield.

"Of course I know that, doofus. You talk about her constantly. It's one of the reasons I like you so much." She paused a beat and then rushed ahead. "It's out of line but to hell with it. I know how much money you send her every week, too. It's a small town we live in. These things get gossiped. I admire you." She swallowed hard and went all the way. "Dammit," she almost whispered, "I'm crazy about you."

He just stood there, like a poleaxed steer. But he didn't waver. He looked into her utterly serious, utterly vulnerable eyes and laid the hammer down, feeling like a creep, but responding to deeper priorities.

"I can't. Listen to me. My daughter is the only thing in my life that matters. She matters more than I do. You don't have a child. You can never understand. In a certain sense she owns me."

She started to protest and he cut her off.

"She owns me. She is the reason I work. She is the reason I eat. She is the reason I get up in the morning. She is the reason I don't give up. She is the reason I stock these shelves. Everything else is a distraction from that purpose."

Linda's eyes began to tear, but he forced himself on, despite screaming compassion in half his heart.

"Distraction that I won't allow. I'm sorry. You are a wonderful woman, but the simple truth is that my heart, my soul, my self, is taken."

She nodded, eyes hard. She gave him another fake laugh, said "Whatever," and they began the maintenance.

The rest of the night passed in awkward silence. They did their work. Words were few. Linda moved stiffly and angrily, muttering to herself on occasion. When they finished, locked up, and were heading for their cars she gave him a withering look and said, "Goodnight." Then turned and strode towards her vehicle.

"Linda...," he called out.

She ignored him. She got into her car, slammed the door, and roared away.

He stood there for a moment, feeling the fool. Feeling the ass. Feeling human. Then he sighed, and climbed into his own car. It threatened not to start. He babied it. Stupid twenty-year-old car. It finally caught and he headed for home.

He ate, showered, and prepared for bed. One paranoid corner of his mind wanted to set the alarm before midnight, but the soul over-rode that idiocy. The connection happens. It's as real as magnetism— as real as the fact of the stars.

He lay down and wished he could have handled the Linda thing better. But it didn't matter.

He turned off the light and closed his eyes. After a bit, he slept.

She always looked forward to this moment. Bathed, fed, tired from an exciting day, it was time to sleep and dream. In her dreams she always met her daddy.

She passed the invisible wall and there he was! Waiting for her as he always was! What fun!

They ignored the laws of physics, and went hand in hand to the stars. They fought dragons and spoke to elves. They danced amongst the trees and held council with the folk of the forest. They drew swords and fought off dark armies to save the innocent princess, and had ambrosia and nectar for breakfast. They protected the weak from the mean and swore oaths to the kindest of Gods. They lived.

She looked at her daddy through dream eyes and loved him. He looked at her with strikingly real eyes and all she felt was love.

Then she knew it was time to say goodnight. She nestled into the cloud like blankets of the dream. She said, "Goodnight, Daddy," and waited.

He woke up exactly on time and staggered outside, feeling that this moment was the most important thing he had ever done.

He ignored the chorus of barks from the neighbor dogs, stared into the face of the judgmental moon, and shivered in the winter air. He found true north and faced it.

Around him the universe screamed, pure chaos pretending to be order. Money turned to electricity, life surged and sang, people cried about silly nonsense, and in the deep folds of the universe, he struck out and found his daughter's hand, kissed it as a princess deserves, let the lullaby of the universe wash over him, and laughed with great joy.

Then he said, "Goodnight, baby."

WAKE

(for CJ)

"Arrogance frowns, pride smiles."~ Mason Cooley

She walked into the café not as if she owned it, but as if she had no need to own it, or anything—being content in the ownership of herself.

As, in fact, she was.

She was a big woman, in the finest sense of that often abused word. Tall, broad-shouldered, thick hipped, firmly packed into her tight denim jeans. Large breasted and proudly so. The not quite silk fabric of her short-sleeved blouse hugged and accentuated
a chest that was neither flaunted nor shown apologetically.

She was big in her simplest presence. The eyes of the few customers and single counter person were immediately drawn to her, and met with a smile that seemed electrically lit from deep within—a smile that woke a slumbering beauty in a pretty face and transformed it into something almost breathtaking.

It is impossible for something so large and beautiful to move through the world without leaving a wake, and she did so as she walked purposefully through the café's small dining room to the counter. In the wake of her passage, stirred like the movement of a perfume molecules through an antiseptic room, little things happened.

She sat down easily at the counter. The older gentlemen working there put aside his magazine and ambled up to her.

"Good morning pretty lady," he told her with the innocent flirtatiousness that only very old or very young males can pull off successfully. "What can I do for you today?"

"Good morning!" she replied, letting loose with that electric charge of a smile again. "It's the strangest thing. I woke up and the first thing I thought was—'I want steak. And a baked potato.' Isn't that odd? I find that odd!"

The old man chuckled. "No ma'am, not really. I always say that the first thought of the morning is a little snapshot of what the day will bring." He took out a ticket book and a ballpoint pen. "A steak? Sounds like a delicious day in the making!" He tossed her a wink. "Gimme the details."

She laughed, winked back, and complied. "T-bone, honey! Medium rare, grilled mushrooms, a bottle of A-1... hmmm... that baked potato. Can you make the skin extra crispy? I love that. Oooo! And a little salad on the side. With ranch dressing. And a cup of coffee with half and half, if you have it!"

There were only four other patrons in the café that morning, two couples.

Julia and Richard were sitting at a table a few feet behind and to the left of the counter. Richard, after pulling his eyes away from watching the new arrival's passage, had returned to the monotonous task of shoveling the breakfast he hadn't wanted into his mouth and chewing.

Julia had seen his stare and had instantly gone from her usual bad morning mood into a black cloud of equal parts anger and jealousy.

"Dear God, is the rodeo in town?" she giggled—an expression that fell from her tongue with the opposite of mirth. "I think one of their bulls has escaped!" Another spiteful, bitter giggle, as she picked over her breakfast of a green salad coated in a thin layer of vinegar and vegetable oil. It was very nearly the only thing she ever ate. Richard sometimes had to avoid looking at it. It made him slightly queasy.

"Jesus, Julia. Stop being so nasty."

Julia gaped. "Me? Nasty? She looks like a runaway bull moose and I'm..." she paused, suddenly nosy as the woman at the counter ordered. Upon hearing the meal particulars her face went oddly white, her eyes bulging in their black mascara cages, an utterly comical look of horror settling over her.

"Steak?! She orders a T-bone with all the trimmings for BREAKFAST?! No wonder she's a circus freak! Dear god, just hearing that order makes me want to vomit! To puke my..."

"And? So? Some people eat steak, Julia. Why is it any of your business what she eats?"

"Utterly disgusting," she continued, ignoring him when it suited her as she always did. "If I ate like that, I'd probably be as big as she is. I'd..."

Richard tuned her out. He'd only been awake an hour or so and was a slow to rouse type. A daydreamer by nature, he settled into a little free-form fantasy. He remembered the days when he and Julia had first met, both sophomores in college. Julia had been more alive

back then it seemed to him—years before she had become obsessed with her weight and her obsession with him had faded to a barely disguised boredom. He imagined her body then, in a curious reversal of most married men's fantasies, longing for the curvy blond and happy girl she had been, not the thin and sharply dressed figure before him, toying angrily with the wilted green mess she forced on herself.

The clink of the fork against the plate, the sudden stress lines on her forehead as she took a bite. He watched the grim lack of satisfaction in her eyes as she chewed and swallowed.

She's always angry because she's always hungry.

The thought struck him with a surprising force, the painful clarity of the vastly obvious made suddenly plain. What a shower and coffee could not accomplish was performed in an instant by that single realization. He was utterly awake, the last vestiges of sleepiness blown to the wind.

She's always angry because she's always hungry.

Richard stared for a moment, somewhat dumbfounded, at the utter simplicity of the thought. It explained so much. Why meal times were emotional mine fields. Why fast food commercials brought mood swings and worse. Why Julia often resented the bowl of ice-cream he indulged himself in during a movie.

My poor sweetie. You are hungry.

But what could he say? She'd deny the fact if he were to mention it. She'd most likely explode or ridicule him for his obvious stupidity.

Perhaps he was thinking too simply. He was no psychologist. The real clue to his no longer happy marriage couldn't be that tiny and... silly. Could it?

Richard was on the verge of dismissing the thought. His head was in the process of what his father had once referred to as 'shaking a dumb idea off', when he heard a sound.

The woman at the counter laughed. A free and flowing sound. Full of clean happiness and innocent satisfaction. It sounded exactly like his wife's old laugh—before the diet days. Before the hungry years.

And Richard acted. He stopped thinking and let instinct guide him, surprising himself almost as much as he surprised Julia—who actually jumped in shock.

With one smooth, almost graceful motion, Richard swapped plates with his wife, setting the mound of scrambled eggs and cheese and crumbled sage sausage before her, and taking the sour green mess she forced on herself as his own.

He grinned at his speechless wife who was struck pale at the pure surprise of his action. He fought back a shudder as he shoved a forkful of the awful drenched leaves into his mouth and chewed.

"You look pale. I think you need protein," he explained, breezily. "And I need some roughage, I think." He swallowed hard and dropped his eyes, concentrating on packing away the so-called salad with as much enthusiasm as he could summon.

"Richard! What on...," Julia started. But she stopped. Her eyes drifted to the beautiful pile of high caloric food on the plate before her, perhaps drawn by the scent—like a character in an old cartoon.

Eat, dammit. C'mon baby. Eat it. People eat. It's goodness. It's a happy thing. It's what life's about—want and need. Eat. C'mon!

For a moment, it almost looked as if Julia were going to cry. Her lips trembled slightly and Richard's heart skipped a beat. The last thing he wanted was to hurt her feelings. The last thing he wanted was to embarrass her in public.

But the tremble turned, miraculously and prettily, into a sudden smile. In an instant, the old Julia was back—that cheerful face he'd missed without knowing it. That sly grin.

"You are so silly, mister," she almost giggled."But... you may be right. I have been feeling... a little weak... lately." She sighed.

Richard, still forcing the horrible vinegar-soaked salad down, suppressed a cheer.

Julia picked up her fork.

"How's that steak, missy?" asked the old man, peering over the top of his magazine.

"Utterly perfect, hon! Just right. Thank you! And I'm picky!"

The old man, nodded. "My boy does the cooking. He's picky too."

"The sign of a good cook. You teach him?"

"No. His mother, rest her. She handled the cooking chores here from the day we opened till the day before she passed."

She nodded, polite enough to refrain from offering condolences for a wound long healed.

"You... remind me of her. Somehow." The old man said, sounding a little embarrassed at the admission.

"Oh?" she said, delighted by what she instantly took as a deep compliment.

"Not in looks, really." he explained. "She was a blond. But... well, she was a big gal too, y'know." He actually blushed.

She just laughed, and waved his imminent apology away. "Hon, I know I'm big. I was a big baby, a big child, a big teenager and now I'm a big woman. That's the facts. To deny that would..." she tapped her fork against the side of the plate, searching for the right words, "...be denying reality. It would be the worst sort of lie. A lie told to myself." She took a bite, chewed, savored it. "And if you can't trust your own self to tell you the truth, you are asking for a life filled with lies. An artificial life. Does that make sense?"

The old man nodded. "Best sort of sense. But... I was saying, not in looks really. Not even size. It's, well, like what you just said. She was the same. Blunt. Honest. And most of all, she was confident. I see that same honesty, that same confidence, in you."

"I wasn't always confident. Far from it."

"What was it that changed your mind?"

She paused then. The old man once again considered an apology, but held back on his own. The look on her face was not one of reticence. Her eyes went a little far away, as if she were looking into another world.

"Life changed my mind," she said finally. She carefully carved and took another bite of the steak. She chewed carefully, savoring it. "Good old fashioned sneak-up-on-you-when-you-least-expect-it *reality* changed my mind."

Before the old man had completely absorbed those words, she spoke again. She spoke in a voice neither loud nor soft, neither arrogant nor submissive. The old man simply watched her and listened as she spoke. He felt as if he were frozen in place as the words flowed over him and into him, as if an oracle were speaking.

"I was married once myself, for five years. I got married right out of high school to a man who said he loved me and proved every day that he hated me. It started off with insults and the simple cruelty of never ever telling me that anything I did was good. I tried to deal with that with submissiveness and increased effort. I really truly wanted to

please this man who hated me but claimed to love me. It was my life's ambition almost. This only seemed to increase his hatred. His... *disgust* with me."

Another bite. Another moment savored fully.

"All that got me was a beating. The first time he beat me was such a shocking experience that I do not remember anything about it. I don't remember why it happened or how much it hurt. If I hadn't seen the bruises and the cuts and limped for a week afterward, I think I would have dismissed it as a dream. After that first time, it was if a dam had broken in him. He beat me for any reason. He beat me once because the Raiders lost. He simply walked into the bedroom, pulled me from a sound sleep, and used me as a punching bag. I remember him grunting out the names of those he blamed for the loss. Names that meant nothing to me."

The old man gritted his teeth together. He felt frozen in place, stomach churning with a mixture of rage and sorrow.

She simply enjoyed another bite. Another moment that would never come again exactly the same way.

"And I took it. For a long time—too long—I took it. I finally started wondering *why* I took it. The reason was very simple. I took it because I was a fat girl. I was a pathetic fat girl who had found a man and was afraid she'd never find another. A pathetic fat girl who would put up with fear and pain and hate in order to not be alone."

From the dining room came a happy laugh, as Julia reacted to a fairly lewd suggestion from her husband.

"Then one night I had a dream," she continued. "I was swimming in the middle of the Caribbean. I think it was the Caribbean—some warm and blue sea, anyway. I felt wonderful, like some sort of mermaid. Then I realized I was being chased. That my husband was swimming after me, in a horrible rage. He wanted to hurt me. The dream went all dark then and I was swimming as fast as I could, crying, trying desperately to out-pace him."

"Just as I *knew* that he was right up to me, about to grab me, pull me under the surface, drown me ... I felt something. Something rising up from below. Something *big*. Something ... *wonderfully* big..."

The smile reappeared on her face then and it was such a welcome smile that the old man felt tears start. But he returned the smile, all the same.

"From the depths of the sea it rose up and broke the surface of the water between my husband and I. One of the most beautiful things I've ever seen. Do you know what it was?"

The old man didn't, but wanted to. Afraid that if he spoke, his voice would tremble, he merely shook his head.

She laughed. "It was a turtle. A huge turtle. As big as a house, like something out of a fairy tale. Its shell was... oh, turquoise and crimson and deep, deep blue. A beautiful, multifaceted thing, like a living jewel. It broke the surface of the water and soared into the air, in a long graceful arc."

She paused to sip her coffee, eyes gleaming with the dream memory.

"I don't remember seeing it hit the water or go back below, but I guess that's not important. Because the force of its appearance had shoved myself and my husband in opposite directions at great speed. I could see him, moving away from me, cursing, eyes filled with rage but so... impotent."

"And I felt joy. This huge surge of pure electric joy. For the first time in five years. When I woke up, the joy was still singing there in my heart. The image of that turtle and how it's passage had saved me. How I rode to freedom on its wake and how very good that felt."

"So, I got up. I took a shower. I ate some breakfast. Then I started to pack. My husband woke up halfway through, I think I was on my third suitcase. He was surprised, then angry, then... well, ready to beat the living hell out of me, to be blunt. For one moment, I almost gave in. I almost cried. I almost started shaking. I almost gave in and submitted. Almost."

"But I didn't, because I remembered that turtle. I *felt* that turtle, deep inside of me, rushing up to the surface, so huge and beautiful and powerful. I picked up a pewter candlestick holder from the dresser. I started talking. I spoke in the same voice I'm speaking in now. I told him quite calmly that to keep me from leaving he would have to kill me. That I would not let him hurt me without fighting back *ever* again. I reminded him that I'd never called the police, but that those days were *over*. I reminded him that I'd never informed my brothers—two of which were due home for holiday leave from the Marines—of how he had treated their baby sister. I let him know that I *was* leaving and no power on Earth would stop that."

"I walked out the door 15 minutes later. He even helped me load my suitcases into the car. And I've been living my life on my own terms since then. Since the moment, I woke up from that dream. I'm still riding on the wake of that turtle and I will be until the day I sink back below the surface."

"And I'll be smiling then, too," she said, with a wink. She patted his hand and went back to her steak.

The old man turned, ostensibly to grab the coffee pot and refill her cup. But he actually wanted a moment to wipe away the tears he couldn't hold back. Not just from her story, but because all through it he had seen the face of his own beloved. How she had fixed the Doctor who told her she had a heart that was ready to go at any minute with a firm stare and the same wicked grin he'd fallen in love with at eighteen and said, "That may be, but I got folks to cook for and this old man could burn *water*, Doc."

And he remembered that when her heart *had* finally given out, she too had slipped below the surface with a smile on her face. That she too had ridden through life on the wake of something big and wonderful.

And he figured that she, too, knew a little something about that turtle.

Lisa wished Dean would for the love of God stop humming. He hummed all the time and did it poorly. It usually took her an inordinate amount of time to recognize whatever tune he had chosen to mangle. It wouldn't be so bad, she often supposed, if he would do it quietly. But no, like everything else Dean attempted, he went about the task with gusto, volume and an arrogant conceit.

Seventeen, by Winger, she realized with sudden surprise. Dear Jesus tap-dancing Christ, is that how he thinks the melody goes?

Dean was working on his fifth sausage, with little stabs into the stack of maple syrup and butter-coated pancakes that dominated his platter. The sound of his enthusiastic chewing and the broken melody of 80's hair-band pop merged with grunts of pleasure to form a teeth-grindingly annoying cacophony.

Or so it seemed to her.

Lisa stared down at her own plate. One pancake. No butter, no syrup. A single scrambled egg white nestled up to it like a forlorn child seeking comfort from a mother. She would eat it, without

enjoyment, and be hungry until an equally bland and unsatisfying lunch. Then more hours waiting for a plain and skimpy supper, then two hours to fall asleep and start the whole pathetic routine over again.

And all the while she'd watch Dean dine on most of her favorite foods. And say, without fail "Sorry, babe. Metabolism is metabolism. Can't fight nature! Pass the butter, ok?"

And hum.

What the hell am I doing with this guy again? she asked herself. They had met at a gym in January, where he worked as a personal trainer. Lisa was there for a new year's resolution to lose 40 pounds.

Dean was, by anyone's reckoning, a damn good-looking guy. He was nicely built, handsome, always had perfectly groomed and styled hair. He had a gleaming smile, washboard abs, and a year-round tan.

Dean was also, by any one's reckoning, a complete and utter jerk. He was so narcissistic that when wearing shorts, he often stopped on the street to admire the way his calf muscles flexed in store windows. On her last birthday he had gone out clubbing with his friends and refused to even answer his cell phone. He sometimes let himself into her apartment while she was at work and made himself lunch and left the mess for her to clean. He would take her out and spend the entire date talking to his friend on the phone. He would 'forget' his wallet and stick her with the check more often than not.

But most of all, Dean was the diet Hitler.

It wasn't just that he made her up a diet. Nor was it just that he rode her constantly about sticking to it. He seemed obsessed with her diet. He made large poster-sized schedules and charts and graphs with detailed accounting of caloric intake, carbs, proteins, sugar grams, vitamin distribution and a dozen other painstaking details and thumb tacked them to her wall. He quizzed her on the damn thing. He did the same with menus—poster sized, elaborate, fucking *color-coded*! And he never seemed to be done with the damn things. He kept tinkering with them. They seemed to fascinate him.

He also demanded her daily weight figure. As poor as he was at keeping other appointments and promises, he never forgot *that* phone call. Six am sharp, every morning. And if the figure wasn't in line with his calculations, she could be sure of a lecture on the importance of

discipline and sticking with the program and other tiresome rah-rah bullshit.

She was sick of it. Hungry, and utterly sick of it.

So... what the hell am I doing with this guy again? she asked herself, as she asked herself a dozen times every day. As usual, the companion thought followed right behind it: *And what the hell is this guy doing with me?*

She shied away from both thoughts, as she always did. She sighed and started to take a bite of the plain and now fairly cold pancake, when she heard a laugh from the counter, and the beautiful red-haired woman there say a phrase that meant nothing to her: "It was a turtle."

And, as if sympathetic to that bit of nonsense, her own nonsense rose up in her mind, having nothing whatsoever to do with turtles: *I want a piece of sausage.*

And she did, suddenly and with surprising desire. She wanted a piece of sagey, salty, greasy, slightly overcooked sausage. Her mouth actually watered at the thought. Exactly like the sausage on her boyfriend's plate. Without hesitation, she spoke the words.

"Dean, I want one of those sausage patties."

He glanced at her, a bit dumbfounded. The humming stopped. His mouth was still full of food as he grunted out a muffled, "Huh?"

"I want one of those sausage patties. They look good."

Dean swallowed heavily and, oddly, went for something in his back pocket. It was a folded square of paper that he deftly opened up and examined.

"Well, lemme check. There might be just the tiniest bit of room, if I can remember the calories and fat grams... one sec, babe..." he said, as he pulled out a pen and began figuring in the margin of what Lisa realized, with actual *horror,* was a miniaturized version of her god-damned *diet*. The sonuvabitch was actually carrying it *around* with him.

So... what the hell am I doing with this guy again?

This time she did not shy away from the question. And the answer was right there, where it had always been, where she had worked so hard to ignore it.

I'm with this gorgeous jerk because, for the first time in my life, it's my boyfriend that girls are glancing covertly at and gossiping about behind my back. I'm with him because, for the first time in my life, I don't have to date

the guys that all my friends turned down. For the first time in my life, other women are jealous of me.

And there it was, in all its ugly truth. *Jesus Christ, Lisa, s*he told herself. *That's pretty damn pathetic.*

Oh, but it didn't end there. *And what the hell is this guy doing with me?*

She knew the answer to that one too, as she watched him sit and figure meticulously on the damned diet. *I'm his project. I'm something he does in his spare time. Saving a poor girl from her fat. He's a hero. He's the boss. He can have total control and I just nod and do what I'm told is best. I'm ego food.*

She was suddenly angry. Not just at Dean, but at herself. Before she had fully realized what she intended to do, she reached out and yanked the diet from his hand, crumpling it up into a tight little wad as she did so.

"Give me that damn thing!" she said. Another instinct, another action. "And give me that damn sausage too!" With her other hand, she snagged it off his plate. She popped it into her mouth and chewed. The flavor was intense and exquisite.

Dean stared at her, goggle-eyed for a moment. Then the moron just shook his head. "I can't believe you just ruined your diet like that, Lisa. After all the hard work I...

Last straws are funny things. The fact was that he wasn't mad or hurt or embarrassed by her outburst was that last straw. The fact was that he was only concerned that the holy *diet* had been compromised.

"Oh *fuck* your stupid diet, Dean! I don't really *care* about the damn diet! And I don't really care about *you* either..."

"Hey! Now wait a minute..."

She didn't even let him get started. "Nope. I'm not waiting anymore. You know what I'm going to do? I'm going right up the street to the Dairy Queen. I'm going to *ask* them, 'What's the most fattening, horribly caloric ice cream concoction you sell? Oh, and make sure it's just *stuffed* with fat! The more fat the better! Give me *two* of those.'"

Dean looked stricken. "I can't believe you'd..."

"...and then, I'm going home. And I'm going to rip those stupid posters off my wall and fling them out the window! Ha!"

The man almost pouted. "I worked hard on those!"

Lisa just laughed. “Goodbye, Dean. Find another 'project'. You are a self-obsessed asshole. Enjoy your life.”

With that, she turned away, picked up her purse, and started to leave. Dean, *finally* angry, reached out and grabbed her arm.

She moved faster than she ever thought she could. She grabbed a handful of the syrup and butter-soaked pancakes and liberally smeared his face with the resultant sticky mush. He let go of her to wipe his eyes and she was gone—out the door and out of his life.

Dean sputtered as he groped for a napkin, face burning with embarrassment. He could feel every eye in the café on him.

And then the woman at the counter started to laugh.

Then someone else started to applaud. It quickly spread. Four people, laughing and applauding his humiliation, he thought. His blush deepened below the sticky layer of pancake. If he had not been the self-obsessed asshole Lisa had pegged him as, he might have realized that the applause was for her stand, not his loss of pride.

But he was what he was. He blindly dug into his pocket and dropped a 20 on the table, and—on the wake of emotion he misunderstood—exited the café in abject shame.

He didn't even stop to flex his calf muscles.

Things settled down quickly. Julia and Richard fell back into their own little world, talking deeper and more happily than they had in years, looking at each other in the old way. It would be a lovely day for them both.

At the counter, the old man was again wiping away tears, but this time from laughing so hard at the confused and bumbling way the young man had exited with a face full of pancake.

“Whoo!” he said. “That just made my day.”

At the counter, the woman was sighing happily—both from the entertainment and a good meal, well enjoyed.

“And on that note,” she said, “I think it’s time for the check, good sir.”

The old man shook his head, without hesitation. “This one is on me, pretty lady.”

She raised her eyebrows, but did not argue; knowing that to do so would be rude. Instead she nodded, and smiled. “Any particular reason why?” she asked.

"Because this is my place and I say so," he told her. "And because I enjoyed your company and your conversation greatly." *And because you brought back memories of the only woman I've ever loved,* he left unsaid.

She stood up and put a ten on the counter. "At least allow me to tip the cook who got my steak perfect on the first try."

The old man nodded, knowing that politeness demanded he let that slide.

On a whim, she leaned over and kissed his cheek, then grinned at his sudden blush.

"I'll be back. I'll see you soon," she assured him.

"Sooner, the better!" he laughed, trying to stop the blush with force of will and failing.

One last electric flash of smile, then she turned and moved away.

As she passed Richard and Julia, they both looked up and smiled at her, Julia rather sheepishly, remembering her initial cruel comments. They were holding hands across the table like teenagers and that made her already wonderful mood rise even higher.

It's always the little things, she reminded herself as she opened the door, *that make or break this life.*

And then she was gone.

She stepped from the café, into the cool air and warm sunlight, full and happy.

It was a beautiful day. She'd had a beautiful breakfast. The blond woman's outburst had been as sweet as a side of pie. She'd often felt like telling a date exactly that, no bones about it. She now sort of regretted holding back. The look on the lug's face had been utterly priceless.

She figured that such a beautiful morning deserved an equally lovely afternoon.

What to do, what to do, she wondered. A movie? The bookstore? To hell with it and hit the bar for a drink, flirt with the regulars?

The street rolled out before her like a welcome sign. No need to decide now, the street whispered. Just take a walk and see what comes along.

She decided she liked the sound of that.

Before she started off, she caught a glimpse of herself in one of the café's wide, dark tinted windows. Her tall, wide, solid, real self. She studied the reflection, critically.

Hmm, she thought, *I think I've lost a couple pounds.*

Then she was off, moving down the inviting street's wide clean sidewalk at a comfortable pace, riding a wave that was now ten years old and still going strong, smiling at the possibilities that such a day might bring.

And all around her the world took notice.

Heads turned.

Eyes fixed.

And little things changed in her wake.

SAWHORSE

For seven years, the sawhorse sat in a single spot. It was in a grass-free patch of dirt and gravel, just behind the house, where the first hint of a hill let those seven years be spent at a gently crooked angle.

The boy was born five days after the sawhorse had been placed by the man in its seemingly eternal crooked spot.

Seven years and the sawhorse had witnessed a lot. The boy witnessed more, because eventually he could run around and change perspectives. The sawhorse had a couple of advantages, though. It wasn't limited to eyes that had to blink and limited to a partial cone. It saw with every inch of its body, a visual sphere of a gently crooked universe. The sawhorse had no need for sleep.

The boy ran and made noise about the yard, while the sawhorse stood and watched everything in its vision field. It watched seasons pass and weather work its slow crumbling magic on the world around. Blue skies and clouds. Bugs and little animals and leaves swarmed around it. Rain and snow and pounding light wore at it.

Sometimes the man would come and place objects against the sawhorse and cut them in half. This was an occasional but interesting thing. Sometimes the boy would come and sit on the sawhorse, dangling his legs in precarious balance, or lean his whole weight against it as if exercising his young and healthy muscles in the sheer joy of motion. This was more frequent and, truth be told, even more interesting.

One day the boy came to the sawhorse holding the tool that the man used to cut things with. The boy spoke to the sawhorse, a simple little speech that would puzzle the object for many days to come.

"I see you sitting there, Mr. Sawhorse, and I figure you must me mighty bored after all this time in one place. I know I'd be mighty bored. First I figured I'd just move you, but then I got to thinking that after all this time you might get homesick for your spot here in the back yard. So I came up with another plan."

And with that formality out of the way, the boy proceeded to cut the sawhorse in half. He did a pretty good job at judging the center and the sawhorse felt no pain as the saw separated it into two distinct entities.

The division complete, the boy drug one-half of the sawhorse around to the other side of the house, into the front yard, where he placed it in a corner near the fence.

Revelation and astonishment! For the sawhorse, an entire new aspect of the universe was revealed. It now had two focal points from which to study the world. No longer was it confined to light when light came, and shade when shade came. One half was in the sun, the other half in the shade. It no longer had to ponder at what lay beyond the barrier of the house. Two viewpoints made the world even more interesting, mysterious and lovely!

If the sawhorse had speech, it would have thanked the boy profusely.

That night the boy got a fierce whipping for ruining a perfectly good sawhorse.

God said 'Bang!'

God said 'Bang!' and all hell broke loose.

Raw energy fountained from non-existence; creating a pulsing, rushing sphere of space-time, an expanding boiling soup of Being. It came from nowhere and created everywhere.

It waned and cooled as it grew. It broke and swirled and chopped and started dying. It broke into clumps and those clumps separated, still spreading. The clumps cooled and themselves began to break apart and become distinct. In their distinction the process continued. Clouds contracted, heating and transformed into stars—chunks of compacted former energy that were too big not to burn again, little copies of the original process itself. Around the stars, in random symmetry, the same thing happened, but most of these smaller clumps did not burn, they merely boiled slightly on the inside.

God watched, intrigued.

Time passed.

Mary brings Joe his dinner and sits it before him, then places her own on the opposite side of the table. It's not much of a dinner—pinto beans and a little pile of fried potatoes, a wedge of cornbread—because it's the end of the month and her disability check has been stretched to the breaking point. All the money they have left is contained in the little change jar on top of the fridge, laboriously saved and deposited there just for these last few belt-tight days.

Joe jumps a little and notices the plate of food before him. He nods at it and begins to eat slowly.

"What's the matter with you today?" Mary asks him, between bites. Her husband has been unnaturally quiet all day, lost in thought even more than usual. He had woke her up this morning laughing in the bathroom, followed by what sounded suspiciously like sobbing. Then he'd emerged, walked into the living room, took his throne before the television, and flicked it on to stare at it without seeing it.

Joe just shrugs and continues to eat methodically.

Mary sighs. It had been hard on him, losing the box factory job. The unemployment had only lasted a few short months. Who was going to hire a sixty-three-year-old man who had trouble talking at a normal volume and communicated mainly with body language? Nobody, that's who.

She is just about to launch into a tired pep talk when Joe sits his fork down, pushes the half finished plate away, and eyes her with a frank and open expression.

"I figured it out this morning," he says bluntly.

"Figured what out?" Mary asks, wishing she had some butter for the corn bread. It's a little dry.

"Everything," Joe informs her. "The meaning of life. The reason the universe is here. Why things happen the way they happen."

Mary almost laughs, but refrains. She almost shakes her head at his silly announcement, but just cocks it at a questioning angle.

"Okay, then Mister Wisdom, what *is* it all about?"

He tells her. It's just a few simple words. A single impossible statement.

Mary does laugh then, a non-derisive laugh that actually makes her feel good.

"Come on, hon. That can't be it. It's too simple."

But Joe is right.

They disappear.

God says 'Boom!' and the whole sprawling mess flashes into elementary particles and reassembles as a megamicropinprick deep below the limit of Being.

God moves away from his workspace, carrying the still frozen forms of Joe and Mary on the tip of its smallest extremity. It places them on the shelf where they join the stasis shape menagerie of the other Answerers. Their forms are vastly different from all the rest, of course, but little different in the eyes of God. There are uncounted trillions there on the shelves.

With great care, God scribes the ultimate answer to this latest universe into the records. It's a fairly obvious one now that it has been revealed, but it always seems that way. You can't figure out a universe existing outside of it. It has to come from some internal observation and reason.

Still, it's a bit disappointing that the answer is so prosaic. What's the point of making universes and watching them figure themselves out if the answers are never more than slightly amusing or marginally satisfying?

Perhaps, it thinks, *I should fiddle with the presets a bit. Introduce some extra randomness, some noise. Maybe...*

Maybe I should get a new hobby.

It disappears.

ROUND EYES

I.

God gave Mary one son and the state took him away. To fight a war, it said. Freedom was at stake, the state told her. Democracy and liberty were in jeopardy, it claimed.

The state spoke in the rational voice of very official letters and the brisk typeset tone of brooking no excuse. Her son, the one that God gave her, was a strong and healthy young man. He must answer the call of duty.

Even he accepted it before her. It *was* his duty, he reluctantly told her. Beyond the not insignificant fear in his eyes, beyond the miniature images of her own reflected and terrified form, she saw the hint of *excitement*.

Her son was just fresh from boyhood, fresh from a short lifetime crammed with romantic matinees about the fighting men of a just ended era, an era that lingered in the imagination of a nation's youth as fresh and rose-colored as their memories of childhood.

She began grieving even before he left, damning herself for a cynic and a weak-willed doubter. Her own father had fought in the Pacific. She had been taught to revere the duty he had performed. She had always felt a fierce pride for him. Her grandmother had been placed in this exact same situation. She knew from that woman's own words that she had never given up hope, from the final embrace goodbye until the day he stepped off the boat and found her arms once more.

She had accepted eventually, grudgingly. She had willed herself into a facsimile of hope, with the help of a few glasses of wine in the evenings when the dark rolled around and bringing with it the doubt and fear. With the wine in her, she could pretend to be proud, pretend to hold onto the reins of hope, pretend that her son was risking his life for something important and that he would be back safe and sound and soon.

But her son still died, thousands of miles away from his mother's arms and she was damned if she could tell a difference his death made to the world other than her own personal world.

That difference manifested as two new possessions, her consolation prize for the loss of the son God gave her: a broken heart and a belly full of hate.

II.

Her name was Quy Hue, but in the singsong patois of the streets she ran they called her Round Eyes.

The round eyes were from her father. A conscript wanderer who had conceived her one night, drunk and desperate for human warmth in a hotel in Saigon.

He died in the jungle a month later.

She never met him, our Quy Hue. But when she was five, she watched the helicopters flee the embassy downtown as the Northern troops at last took the territory they had long claimed.

She did not know a great nation-state had finally been defeated. She just thought: "My father is gone forever."

The Northerners killed her mother a year later, for harboring a rich couple who had collaborated with the former Southern regime.

Left alone she ran, joined in with the crazy secret tide of the crowded streets of Saigon. It was either that or starve.

She stole, whored, and killed three men. She ate when and what she could and lived the best life she could tear from the world with naked force and cunning.

She learned the ways of the knife, the quiet step, and the empty heart. But in her dreams, her father smiled down on a precious lily flower and she often woke herself crying.

She died in a Saigon gutter at the age of thirteen, stabbed twenty-four times, seven of which had pierced her heart.

She was killed for stealing a radio. It was a radio that belonged to a larger, meaner, and faster gang than the one she ran with. It was a radio that she knew that she should leave alone, but could not resist. Because it was brand-new and beautiful in its shiny plastic gleam, and the songs that emerged from it as she slunk past on her last day of life were an irresistible siren call.

Round Eyes, our Quy Hue, had never owned anything new.

She kept her treasure only two hours.

Then seven boys found her and rendered her unable to ever own anything again.

III.

They took my boy, the old man often thought. *And sent me back a mad dog.*

Chuck screams in his sleep often. He drinks too much. He's missing a foot. Sometimes Chuck stares at the stump. He stares at the missing foot. And he just has to hit someone. That someone always turns out to be his father.

It's a sad game, his father tells himself, *for a fifty-nine-year-old man to make excuses for bruises.*

"I killed a little girl," Chuck sometimes slurs. Usually at this point, he has discarded the pretense of mixing drinks and is slugging clumsily, the cheap rotgut he favors right from the bottle. "I thought she had a bomb, but it was just an old radio."

The rotgut doesn't really let him forget the little girl, just as it doesn't really let him forget the foot blown off by an actual bomb that was placed on a roadside by some of the people he went to the desert to help liberate. But it allows him not to care about either for as long as it numbs his brain.

Such is life, he always thinks, making excuses, *but he fought for our freedom*. It's a terrible excuse and he knows it even as he makes it. He can't really believe it any more. The whole pretext for the war has gone through such convoluted turns and twists that only the most irrational flag waver can believe it had anything to do with freedom. But he lies to himself, just as he lies to the world about the bruises.

And Chuck is trapped, drinking himself towards the grave he narrowly avoided, staring at a missing foot, a dead child, and a radio that didn't even work.

IV.

Two young men sit on a garage roof and contemplate the stars. Between them is a half-depleted bottle of Kentucky bourbon. Passing between them in a lazy ritual rides an almost-finished joint.

They contrast sharply, the way truly good friends often do. Chuck is large and muscular, a boy built to run and lift and labor. Arthur is thin and pale, with thick glasses that make his dilated eyes look almost comically stoned. A boy built to think and write and figure. They not only contrast, but counterpoint each other and have since they met on their first day of school. Chuck kept the bullies and bastards from his

small friend and Arthur kept Chuck's grades high enough to get him on through the next day. They were a team.

Until now.

"I calculated it once," Arthur says, words dragging a bit, but clear enough. "And if you take into account that there are three and a half billion people on this planet, and you count every second as three and a half billion consecutive seconds, then every moment that passes is just over a century long." Arthur blinked, remembering his calculation.

They were talking about God and the Universe in a roundabout way, as they usually did when they were stoned.

"That's completely nuts," Chuck said, and hit the joint. It burned his fingers and he flicked it away suddenly. He held the smoke for a few seconds, then let it whoosh out with a sigh. "But kind of cool."

"Now think about what that means," Arthur continued, grabbing the bottle and taking a burning gulp. "Let's say that God, or the Universe, or what have you, isn't exactly omnipotent. It's just that He or It exists on a time frame that rivals the subjective time frame of not only every human that exists but every human that has *ever* existed and maybe *will* ever exist." Arthur is gently lecturing now, piling speculation onto speculation in a heady rush.

Chuck pondered on that, as instructed. He loved to hear his friend dissect the world. "So you are saying that humans are God? Or that they make the Universe?"

"Me?" Arthur laughed. "I'm just philosophizing to maximize my buzz, brother." He adjusted his glasses and laid back to better enjoy the canopy of the Milky Way spread out above them. "But look at it this way. In just the subjective time frame I calculated, a single day to God would be nine million, five hundred and eighty-nine thousand freakin' years. When you think about it like that, six days to create a simple thing like a planet ain't that far fetched." The thick lenses gleam in reflected starlight, masking the eyes. "It wouldn't take omnipotence to create a universe on that sort of time scale. Just talent and persistence. Like a sculptor. Or a composer." He chuckles at his own idle speculation. "Yeah, a composer. The universe is a long and baroque symphony."

Chuck grabbed the bottle and took his own slug. He capped the brown fire and leaned back himself. He let his blurry eyes scan the

sky, the stars doubling their already impressive number as the alcohol rode in his veins.

"I like it," Chuck finally said. "I like that idea. That the universe—all that—is just..." he groped for words. "...a song. A song the human race sings together." He smiled. "I really like that."

Arthur smiled as well. "You got the soul of a poet, bro." The smile died as he thought of where his friend was headed, as those moments that were only moments to him ticked too quickly by. "Remember that," he said, in a low voice. "When you're over there. Remember that things are more than they sometimes seem. Sometimes people disappear and no one knows where they went, or appear in crowds and no one knows where they came from. Things happen. "

Chuck sensed the shift in mood and didn't like where it was going. So he laughed. "Well," he says, "how 'bout you put that big brain to work on how our drunk asses are gonna get off this roof without any broken bones?"

Arthur returned the laugh, and they began to plan. It would be the last thing they ever do together.

In less than twelve hours, Chuck would climb onto a bus and begin a journey that would eventually lead him to a blazing death in a jungle.

In less than twelve hours, Arthur would climb into his beat-up Chevy Impala and begin a journey that would take him far north to a university. This is where he will begin work on a degree and eventually lead him to a failed marriage and a late-born son that he would name after this friend of his childhood.

V.

Mary Vintner, who was seventy-nine, ate her usual breakfast with her usual lack of relish. The fork and the knife made mechanical clockwork motions; precise and humorless. She barely tasted the eggs, sausage, and toast she consumed. They sated no hunger, gave her no pleasure. They were a matter of sour and practical habit, as Mary was a creature of sour and practical habit.

She'd been this way for forty years, from the moment the letter had arrived with the news that her son was dead, that her worst fear had come to pass, that she had hoped in vain.

She'd settled forever into this creature who now wandered the world like a corporeal ghost when the empty coffin had been lowered into the grave and the preacher spoke words that meant nothing to her heart. She had nothing left of him, not even the dog tags. Her son had been caught in a bombing run. Vaporized, they said.

If only I had something of him, she still sometimes thought, *perhaps I could grieve properly and let it rest.* But nothing was what she had. An empty coffin in a crowded cemetery, a letter from the government, and memories of a strong and handsome boy that to this day were still so bright and vivid that they caused her heart to ache.

She allowed the world to see none of this. Sitting here in this bright cafe, surrounded by people she had known all her life, she revealed nothing. She ate here every morning and never conversed. She had nothing for the people she passed on the street but a cold glare and a quickened pace. Several generations of children had considered her a witch and were too frightened to even egg her house on Halloween.

She did not care, for she wanted nothing of this world. For many years, the only human being she had even the slightest affection for was Arthur Cannon, her son's childhood best friend. She didn't truly care for Arthur Cannon the human being, merely the Arthur Cannon who complemented the memory of her son.

When the government had started this latest round of sending sons off to die, Arthur's boy had been sent. She'd felt sympathy. But, when his son returned missing only a foot, Arthur had come to talk with her and had the utter *nerve* to pretend his loss was somehow on the same level as hers. She ran him away and let even that last spark of human connection gutter out.

"Your boy came back, you awful, greedy man! How dare you! Your boy came *back*!" she had screamed at him as he stumbled down her porch stairs, open-mouthed and round-eyed at her sudden raging outburst.

He has changed into someone else, the man had whined. The nerve. The utter, hateful nerve.

She trembled slightly, remembering. Suddenly, the brightness and chatter of the cafe was too much for her to bear. She struggled up, placed the meal price and a dollar tip on the table, and hobbled with the aid of her cane to the door. A man entering held it open and smiled politely at her. She ignored him, moving purposefully and angrily out

the door and down the street, for the cool dark comfort of her quiet house.

VI.

Quy Hue opened her eyes to discover what the afterlife had in store for her. There was no question that she was dead. She may have been an illiterate street runner, but she knew death well.

For the moment, all was blackness and a comforting cool soft feeling. She remembered the feel of the blades entering her body, the weight of the three boys who had held her down, and the taunting babble of the four who had stabbed her. She shuddered at the memory, but realized that its power was fading here in the cool darkness. Already the memory of the pain was dull and muted.

She rested there for a long time, enjoying the first peace she could remember since the long ago death of her mother.

Then, at first thinking it was merely her imagination, she began to hear the music.

It started low and deep, bass notes throbbing a careful and confident rhythm, more feeling than sound. The pattern was complex and interesting, and oddly soothing. It reminded her of her earliest memories, her head resting against her mother's chest, a calm heart-beat lulling her to sleep.

Then came the melody, like a chorus of voices. Sweet voices, singing in unison. A song unlike any she'd ever heard; a song so beautiful it made the voice of the radio she had died for seem transparent and vulgar, gaudy and crude. It was a song, she realized, that she could listen happily to forever, content here in the cool soft dark, with only the music for company. She closed her eyes again to do just that.

But that was not to be.

"Hello, Quy Hue," said the voice, softly yet perfectly clear against the background of music.

She opened her eyes. Standing before her was a small girl, whose complexion matched hers and whose clothing was as ragged and humble as those she had worn in life.

"No one calls me that," Quy Hue whispered, feeling her voice was an insult to the song. "Everyone calls me Round Eyes."

"I know," said the young girl. "But that is not your name."

The blackness had been replaced by a pale luminescent white, and it appeared that she and the girl were alone in that unending radiance. But as soon as that thought crossed her mind, she knew it was not true. They were only two amongst a vast multitude, she was certain. She could feel their presence the way she had felt the crowded streets at midday even if she closed her eyes and covered her ears and wished for quiet.

And the radiance was far from blank, and not at all still. It was, she realized, a torrent of briefly glimpsed scenes, haphazard and undecipherable. As if she were being given glimpses from billions of different eyes.

"Where am I?" Quy Hue whispered again, then felt foolish. Her voice, and the voice of her companion, did *not* insult the song. Their voices did not mar its delicate beauty and delicious swell. Their voices were small but integral instruments in that overwhelming chorus.

"We rest in the Moment, the Universal Now. Inside the Song of Existence." The child laughed. "I can not explain it and there is no need. Because this is not your place to be. You are not supposed to stay here."

And then Quy Hue, with a gasp that spiraled from her like a lovely note, saw that the child was holding a radio. It was old and worn now, filthy and abused, but she recognized it at once. *Perhaps*, the thought came to her, *some of those stains are my own blood.*

As she stared, the child continued.

"The Song has no false notes, no mistakes. How can it be flawed when it is the fountain of reality? Yet sometimes, if a composer is truly gifted, intentional dissonance will be inserted. This serves as a counterpoint to beauty, as pain counterpoints joy. These motifs know no boundary of time or place, no limitation of simple understanding. You and I are notes in this motif. We are notes played and spent, while other notes still hum in the solid walls of reality."

The child moved closer and offered the battered object to her with a gesture of calm surrender. "It is time for your note to be struck again, Quy Hue."

With an inner trembling, Quy Hue accepted the gift, cradled it to her thin chest, feeling pure gratitude.

"Who is this great composer?" she asked, no longer afraid of marring the song. "Who creates such beauty?"

The child was fading, shimmering, becoming more deeply ingrained in the weave of the song, the flickering montage of the moment.

"We are both instrument, song, and composer. You, I, and the uncounted secret singers. And him."

The child hummed from existence and Quy Hue felt the hand on her shoulder.

She turned and let her gaze wander up. A pale but smiling man stared down at her. The hand on her shoulder squeezed once, gently.

He led her into the song, through the moment, and—as Quy Hue felt the proper point surge toward her, felt the return of weight and breath—she wept with joy to have finally met her Father.

Then the song surged and the note that was Quy Hue of the round eyes was once again struck on the deep strings of the real and solid.

VII.

Chuck was going to kill him this time, Arthur knew.

"Give me that bottle, you worthless *shit*!" his son screamed at him, hobbling towards him on crutches with blood in his eyes. His right hand clumsily held the stubby, cruel shape of the .38.

They were having this ugly confrontation in front of the house, on the sidewalk, before the eyes of God, their neighbors and the steady pulse of traffic. Arthur was afraid that if he shattered the bottle, his son would shoot him. But if he relented and let him have the bottle, Chuck would drift one more fifth of a gallon closer to death.

It's a hellish place to be trapped, between fear for your life and the love of your child.

"You are killing yourself, Chuck. Please..." Arthur said, past tears, his voice shaking and pleading. "You're killing yourself and forcing me to watch and *I can't do it anymore*!"

Chuck threw his head back and howled. There on the sidewalk, filthy and unshaven, hair a mat of tangles and dirt, stinking and bare chested, his son was transforming into an animal. An armed animal.

Mary Virtner was just a block from the relief of her house, passing the Cannon place, when that howl yanked her from her blank rejection of the rest of the world and pulled her head around to the awful scene on the other side of the street. That screech raised the hair on the back

of her neck and shot the first real pang of feeling through her heart in four decades.

She saw that wreck of a man raise the pistol and point it at the childhood friend of her long-dead son.

On the level of existence where the universal song played in all its glory, the tableaux stretched like a still life. The father, the wounded son, the mother with the blackened heart. A tripod of shattered dreams. Three notes of a dissonant motif that was destined for a conclusion.

And guided by two notes that no longer lingered, the final note pierced the moment and worked the alchemy of a tune well played.

Mary saw the child appear in the street first. Saw the car moving too fast, and the driver distracted by the drama on the sidewalk.

She opened her mouth and cried out, "No!"

Her voice, a sound louder than she thought herself capable of, penetrated Chuck's rage. Like a puppet on a string, he felt compelled to turn, the gun dropping to the ground.

He saw, in the middle of the street, a dark-complected child carrying an old radio.

And he saw the car, finally braking, but too late, too late...

He acted, from a deep well of regret that words cannot describe, a deep regret like dark music in his heart. Letting the crutches fall he ran, the stump of his foot slamming painfully into the ground, pain that he ignored. His rage forgotten, his thirst forgotten, the world forgotten save for a burning thought that forced his mind and muscles down a single desperate track: *I will not watch you die again.*

At the last moment he leapt, grunting, to shove the child towards safety and intersecting the ton-and-a-half vehicle with his own poor form.

Arthur screamed as he saw his son bounce off the fender of the car, twisting like a broken puppet as he bounced from the hood and smashed viciously into the windshield. The windshield shattered and sank in as the car finally screamed to a halt in a flare of burned rubber and aching hot brakes.

The girl slammed into Mary who grabbed her and managed, miraculously, not to fall.

A sudden hush. Arthur frantically ran to his son, the contested bottle of liquor falling from numb fingers. He reached Chuck, tears streaming down his face, babbling ridiculous reassurances to his twisted form.

Mary straightened herself, catching her breath. She stared down at the child who had just been saved.

She stared down into the round, green eyes of Quy Hue and the recognition was an electric shock.

She stared down into the round, green eyes of her dead son.

Something left of him, her heart whispered. *Something left to let me grieve.*

And those eyes stared back up at her and there was recognition in them as well.

Quy Hue clasped herself to the old woman and wept, her voice calling a word over and over, "Dahn tu! Dahn tu!" *Grandmother*.

Arthur cradled his son's head as the boy coughed blood. Arthur was weeping silently now, no longer babbling. Because in the eyes of his broken child he could see a clarity and peace that had been as missing as his foot had been in the last few, long months. In those eyes was a strange gleam of happiness, as if he were hearing a lovely song on a calm afternoon.

And the motif finishes at last. A woman at last grieving with a gift from a long-dead son and a father grieving over one who longed for death. With an old radio shattered in the middle of the street. And four pairs of eyes, round and startled at the song of the universe, wide to the beauty, the pain and the mystery of that song.

They will never truly understand, but it does not matter. For in that moment—that fleeting eternal moment—a pause has been reached.

And the song swells, crescendos, and sighs in minor conclusion, but it does not end...

To hell with you, spirit.

I did not return to this place to do battle with spirits. I returned to this place for my own selfish and important reasons. It was you, spirit, who initiated this conflict. It was you, spirit, who laid down the gauntlet.

So be it.

"Are you OK?" she asks.

I swim up out of almost sleep; the night and the situation at hand shimmer into existence around me.

I am in a sleeping bag. I am naked. I am not alone.

Stars burn above me, spread and scattered like gems on jewel cloth. The air is warm but not hot. The breeze is gentle but insistent. Such nights and such situations are the material of wonderful memories for the young. I am not young. I'm not old, but I'm not young.

Sometimes it feels like I was never young.

"OK it was good," she says, and I can feel her smile in the dark. "But it shouldn't have stolen your voice." She kisses me quickly. "It wasn't that good."

"Sorry," I tell her. "I think I dozed off." And dreamed. And was warned.

She snuggles up to me and sighs. "I gotta go home in a minute. Sorry."

I squeeze her back, for politeness sake. I'm not comfortable here. Something is watching.

"Where are we, anyway?" I whisper.

She laughs. "You must have been higher than I thought. We're up near the head of Pond Creek, 'bout three miles from my house." A yawn. "This is where everybody goes."

Everybody is a fool then, I think. This is not a good place. It's not an evil place either, but it's far from good.

Something is watching.

Something that lives here.

Everybody says that my Mother is a witch. I've never agreed with or denied that claim. I simply shrug and let them make up their own mind.

My mother is a straightforward, often severe woman of 65 who prides

herself on her civility, her cooking, and the pack of children she managed to raise despite poverty and hell's own aggravation. In daily life, through daily stress, there is nothing whatsoever mystical or magical about my mother. Those are facts.

But my Mother knows things, that is also a fact. Many strange and unusual things. She knows the herbs to pick to brew the tea to kill the fever after the doctors have given up. She knows the place to go to find the perfect stone to sit in the garden to frighten crows. I have seen her reason with cats and command strange dogs to lie down and be quiet.

Many things.

Before I left her home, before I made the return to the place where I was born, she told me this:

"If you go into the mountains—and knowing you, boy, that's where you'll stay—you will see and hear things. Don't be afraid. If you don't turn and look at them, they can't hurt you."

I nodded, serious. I'd have laughed at anyone else, and dismissed them as silly. But this was Mother.

She knows things.

Her name is Shelly and I watch her dress with eyes now adjusted to starlight.

She is not a particularly pretty girl, but I would not call her plain. She has her own face—unique and beautiful, not pretty. I approve. Pretty is for flowers and little girls in gingham dresses and black suede shoes. Pretty is for the sentimental. I prefer beauty.

"Stop staring at me because I'm fat," she says, tone battling to sound playful but failing. Too much self-consciousness coils behind the words, shattering the glib surface. Real pain lies between them.

She's not fat, but I don't tell her that. It's the stock response, it's expected, and—like all stock responses—will burden her with a load of assumptions.

"Skinny women bore me," I say instead.

She laughs.

I'm sitting up now, still naked, sleeping bag puddled around my lap. I watch her pull on a pair of pants with two deft motions and button them. She wears men's clothes. A Hard Rock Cafe T-shirt and Lee jeans, topped with a Harley cap. She manages to look sexy as hell in them, too.

She turns and looks at me. "Get dressed," she commands.

"Why?"

She sighs. "Because I don't have time to pull my clothes back off and attack you. I gotta get home. My nephew will be awake at 7 am sharp, and he'll be jumping on top of my head three minutes later. It's almost 2 am."

I comply, and she walks to her car. I dress quickly, and look around at this apparently popular little hangout. This place that screams danger at me on some low frequency deep in my head.

It's just a big wide spot beside a gravel road, more or less flat. Hemmed in by shrubs and bushes, trees a few hundred feet to the east and west, the road running a winding crooked north/south up the side of the hill.

I hear the car crank but refuse to start. I hear Shelly mutter curses.

Yes. I can feel it. Like a vibration in the air, like a finger pointing at me from the dark.

Something is watching.

Something that lives here.

The starter catches and the car roars into life, load and blaring without a muffler.

"Come on!"

As soon as I turn, facing the car and the headlights that spring into the black, the chill hits me. Imaginary sand skitters down my spine. The hair on the back of my neck stands at painful full attention.

I know, way down on that low frequency, that the watcher just let its face show.

I do not turn and look. I can feel some awful hot breath chuffing from that face, but I do not turn and look. Rigid, electrified, I walk slowly to the car and get in.

We pull out and move down the hill. The watcher stares.

I do not turn and look.

"You're kind of quiet," Shelly says, as soon as we're on our way toward the mouth of the hollow.

"Sorry," I say.

Long seconds drift by, empty save the vibration of the car and the roar of the unmuffled engine.

"Are you embarrassed?"

I'm surprised. "Excuse me?"

"Embarrassed. For fucking a fat chick who stripped down and got into bed with you an hour after she met you."

Sometimes people say things to you that leave you at this mental crux-point. If you're smart enough, it manifests as a sort of scattered graph. You can choose how you want to respond by following the graph.

I do not baby her. I do not reassure her. I do not apologize.

"That's the only kind of women I've ever fucked," I tell her, and it's the truth.

She knows it's the truth, and she laughs. Really laughs. So hard she has to pull over for a minute to recover. The laughter giggles back up again several times in the nice warm silence that it created.

When she drops me off, she's suddenly troubled.

"We're not, like, boyfriend or girlfriend or anything, right? You don't think that..."

"I'm a boy. You're a girl. We're friends. Haven't you ever watched movies? Anything could happen."

I close the door, and place my hand on the window for a moment. She reaches across and touches it goodbye. I can feel a warm spark jump across the barrier of the fake glass.

She pulls out and drives off, toward a still sleeping nephew and responsibilities she didn't create.

I decide I like her a lot.

I go inside and shower. I consider going to bed. But I can still feel the hair on the back of my neck, restless with the remnants of that electric charge. Something dances uneasily along my spine and I know sleep will be delayed, perhaps for a day or two.

I sit down, still naked, at my computer desk. I position the wheeled swivel chair perfectly in the center of the pentagram that no one but myself and Cat (who has not chosen to make an appearance yet) can see.

I close my eyes and hold my breath, until the silky flow of the circle's protection crawls up my skin and encases me.

Everyone laughs at my computer, since it has no case and much of it is tacked to the wall. It's the only way it will run, since it builds up far more heat than even the four heavy-duty fans placed at strategic points can handle. On cold nights, the things it processes can heat my bedroom.

I never turn it off. Power outages have no effect on it, since it operates under its own power. To turn it off, intentionally, would destroy it.

I log on.

The hunt begins.

My father is the greatest mechanic this world has ever seen, and only six people know this fact. Three of them are dead and the other three deserve the sort of trust epic poems are written about.

I once watched my father repair and use an engine my younger brother and myself dug out of the ground: a big block Chevy engine that had waited there patiently for twenty-three years. Waited for two children to find and rescue it. Waited for the only hands on the planet capable of giving it life again.

He did this in two days.

Years later, he traded that car for our first computer—a Commodore Vic 20. On that day, my father found his purpose in life.

When I found out what I could do with the computers my father rigged, I discovered my own.

The night before I left his home, he presented me with this rig.

The hunt is still afoot when Cat—his hunt at an end—returns. He enters through one of his secret doors, ignoring the flap I built for him as he does unless we have a guest.

He saunters over to me, to the invisible pentagram's edge, and drops me the morning gift. A large gray jackrabbit, nearly his size. It has been decapitated, but there is no blood.

I don't know what he does with the blood. That's his business.

"Thanks, Cat. Good morning."

He mews, deep and rumbly, like a rusted manhole cover being pried from some burned city street. *Milk*, he says.

I glance at the clock. It's nearly 10 am. I have learned a lot, in my meandering way, but not enough.

Shift and CTRL down, I tap in: *Exodus Tempus 60*. The search locks and holds, the protective circle pauses. One hour.

I snag the rabbit and move to the kitchen, Cat dancing right on the edge of tripping me.

I pour him milk in his favorite saucer and he sets to it with a will. I

do the same to the rabbit, skinning and cleaning it, realizing that I'm starving. I slice a nice portion from it and start it frying with some butter and paprika. I scramble some eggs in a separate pan.

Cat deigns to share breakfast with me, perhaps to show that he does not hunt for sport. That he is a pragmatic killer. Or, maybe, he just likes eggs and paprika.

I don't try to figure cats out. They come to me, of their own will. I have never chosen a cat in my life. Nor have I ever insulted one by naming it. They have their own names. They are not pets to me. They are combination friends and associates. We complement each other and like each other. That is enough.

The only odd thing about Cat is that he is a tom. I've never lived with a tom before. A tom never chose me before now. Always females, usually tiger-striped or white. Toms, I've discovered, are very different from the female of their species—in many ways more sociable, if less affectionate. Not as quick a hunter, but just as skilled and able to take larger game.

It has been almost 10 years since I've bought meat. Why waste money on what a cat will provide willingly and (I suspect) with great joy?

I'm headed back to the computer when someone knocks on the door.

Shelly is smiling at me when I open up, having pulled on a pair of boxer shorts and a T-shirt.

She looks a little embarrassed; after a second, I realize why.

She has ditched the guy clothes and... well... dressed up. A nice low cut blouse that shows decent cleavage. A skirt. Hose. Pumps.

Not embarrassed actually. Uncomfortable. And somewhat annoyed.

"Hi." she says. "You don't mind me stopping by, do you?"

"Of course not." I say, despite the fact that I do. I have work to complete, and my one-hour holding pattern only has twenty minutes left to run. Missing the mark will result in seven hours work lost, a vicious headache, and a torrential nosebleed.

But I smile as I say it, regardless. I surprise myself by meaning it. I'm happy to see her. She looks cute as a button in her uncomfortable get-up, partially because of her blushing self-awareness.

I realize something as she steps inside and glances around my not exactly impressive home. My morning research is not simply the

product of my usual curiosity or due to any danger, I sensed for myself.

The danger focuses on her.

"Nice place," she finally judges. "Clean."

"I wasn't raised by wolves. Do you eat rabbit?"

She makes a face. "Ugh, no. That's horrible."

"Deliciously horrible."

She rolls her eyes and sits, obviously reminding herself that she's wearing a skirt.

Cat swaggers up and eyes her.

"Hi kitty," she says.

He narrows his eyes to slits and cocks his head. Then he starts cleaning himself.

Judgment acceptable with provisional reservations.

"Not very friendly."

I laugh. "If he didn't like you he'd raise massive hell." Literally, I don't say.

"You're not one of those weird cat people, are you?" she asks, more flirty than inquisitive.

"You have no idea." Something about my eyes catches her. Damn. I'm letting the guard slip a little far, and Cat is staring at me like I'm a fool. The holding pattern is cycling down toward fifteen minutes remaining, and I can feel the 'puter pulsing out waves of warning in the bedroom. In a few minutes, even Shelly will sense it.

"Not to be rude, but I haven't been to bed yet," I tell her. Best to stick to true statements. "Even ugly guys like me need beauty sleep. Did you need something?"

She stands up. Smiles. "Not really. I was... going to the store. Just... wanted to see you, I guess." Really, really clumsy lies. Except the last bit. "And you're not ugly." She blushes and forges head. "Want to get together tonight?"

Relief. "Sure. Come by around five."

"OK." She stares at me for a few seconds. Then kisses me, on impulse. A sweet little kiss.

As she leaves, she walks with a bounce to her step, unable to hide a happy heart.

I see it for the first time, crackling around her like a storm cloud. The black aura of incoming danger. It coalesces around her, a

tightening fist, and sends smoky tendrils out, reaching for me.

Whatever lives at the head of Pond Creek wants me, all right—but knows better than to try a frontal assault. It's a sneaky bitch. It will try to sneak in through a weak emotional backdoor.

Coward.

When I was eleven years old, I figured out how to log onto the internet—which was an achievement because we didn't have a modem or a phone, and the internet was a bare few servers stitching together a handful of Universities. I figured this out in a half trance, while attempting to write a Basic program that would function as an alarm clock.

Unnerved, I asked my father to look at it. He passed out. My mother looked at the code and paled.

After that, they let me be at the computer. I met many interesting people. And creatures.

And I figured out many more things.

I slip back into the chair with nine minutes remaining. The room temperature has grown uncomfortable and a steady ache has crept behind my eyes.

Shift and CTRL down: *Resumptis.* Cat gives me a final, withering glance and wanders off to sleep.

The hunt continues.

I'm in the Howling, the non-place some call Hell.

It's not. What it really is the seedbed of reality, the thin layer of existence where nothing becomes something.

"Probably because the universe got bored," my dad opines. My mom always says something about God.

On this side, physics begins—time, space, heat and light. On the other—nothing.

To me, it's just a big data web.

But I have to be careful. Because on the other side the enemy lives. It has many names.

Nothing, as I said. Scientists call it entropy and 'the heat death of the universe'. Politicians, the human beings most in its thrall, call it Order.

My family, and those like us, call it The Crumbler.

"The first thing you have to understand, son, is that most people are ignorant about the universe. Take the concepts of chaos and order. Chaos is supposed to be bad, Order is supposed to be good. Right?"

I nod. That's what they tell us in school.

"That's a bag of bull." Dad is enjoying this. He likes destroying illusions as much as fiddling with tools. "Think about it: what is the ultimate order?"

I mull it over, but he's being rhetorical.

"Being dead. Being rotted away and gone. Nothing more orderly and quiet and peaceful than that, is there?"

I agree.

"And that's what the Crumbler wants. Not just for us. For everything. For the whole blasted universe."

I'm spiraling in now, pulling data from the minds of the dead. Their souls do not rest here, but their memories are often locked here—flash frozen in The Howling by their final agonized fight to live.

I concentrate on the geographic area of Pond Creek, its history and settlement.

It comes to me as a revelation—an intuition explosion of visuals and symbols, impossible to describe—what I'm dealing with.

I didn't think any nature spirits still haunted this world. I now realized why my mother warned me. Because nature spirits, despite the romanticists and neo-pagans, are all in the service of the enemy. As my family and folk like us—witch folk, they call us—exist to combat him.

I know what to do.

"You can't hide from it," my mother tells me as I pack.

"I'm not trying to hide from anything," I tell her, lying. "I just want to go back and see the damn place."

"You can't help what you are."

"And I can't help what I want, either!" I yell. "Maybe I just want a wife and some kids, Mom! Maybe I just want to be left alone and not worry about some fucking ancient war I never asked to fight!"

She laughs at me, pissing me off even more.

"Lord, boy... you think we chose this?"

I continue to pack, angry.

"Nobody gets to choose. We were born as we were and the enemy tries to

kill us because it fears us. We no more choose it than water chooses to freeze in the winter."

I come out of trance. The complexity of what I have to do next demands I be fully functional. That means it's going to hurt.

I once tried to explain to my dad how I built hexes and tessellations with the computer.

"A normal computer only knows two things. On and off. But the way you rig 'em makes 'em different."

"Explain it to me." Dad maintained that he had no idea how he did what he did. He worked by instinct and intuition.

"Well... they got on and off. But they also got over and under and toward and away."

"Huh?"

"Six positions. Not two."

He smiled. "A hex."

"Yep."

Lots of things live in The Howling. Imps and daemons and furies and rievings. All of them are dangerous if you don't know what you're doing. And all of them are useful if you do.

I need a rieving.

My mom taught me about rievings.

"Nicer than imps or daemons," she said. "And nowhere near as annoying as furies."

She drew a hex on the ground and snatched one from the substrate. It glowed like fire and fluttered in her fingers. "Kind of pretty too, don't you think?"

"What are they useful for?"

"Not a lot these days," she said, and flicked it back into the Howling. As long as I live, I doubt I'll ever be able to match her skill. "They used to be indispensable when our folk had to deal with spirits. Swallow a rieving, and you can take on its sight. They also sing, a song of protection."

"Think I'll ever have to use one?"

She smiled. "I hope not. But I'll teach you. Just in case."

It takes me almost an hour to pull the tenacious little fucker from the substrate, using almost 1500 lines of code.

Once I realize it, though, I don't have to figure out how to swallow it. Damn thing charges me, smacks me right between the eyes. Pain and light explode in my head, and it takes me a few minutes to get used to the high-pitched noise and the bizarre way the world looks.

I realize with a chill that I can now see the Crumbler's effects on the world. The awful fingers of dissolution transforming space-time into simple dead atoms.

Cat hisses at me.

"Oh shut up," I tell him.

Shelly arrives at 4:45, and I've come up with a plan to get back to the head of Pond Creek.

While in the Howling, I dipped into her head. I know she has a weed dealer past the wide place. I know this weed dealer won't let her bring me with her, since he doesn't know me. I also know that she's out and wants some and is broke and bummed about it.

I meet her at the door. She hears my plan and hugs me. The rieving passes a thought to me from her: *This guy just flat out rocks.* I tell it firmly to stop doing that.

On the ride, she tries clumsily to get to know me.

"So you were born here?"

"Yeah. Left twenty years ago."

"Why did you come back?"

"Why not?"

"Where do you work?"

"I don't.

Short silence.

"How do you get money then?"

"Male prostitution."

She laughs. Then stops.

"Not... like... for real, right?"

I just look at her.

"You're weird," she informs me. But she's almost bouncing in her seat.

As we cross Pond Creek bridge I tell her to stop, judging it so that we halt exactly in the center of the bridge. The rieving in my cortex whines its number song: the world appears to me as perfect geometric edges, the steadily tightening hand of the Crumbler in their hateful

symmetry.

"What for?" Shelly asks. Rather than make up a lie I speak with the rieving's voice, exactly what she needs to hear. She blushes. "You goof." But she's pleased.

I'm out of the car and make my way to the river's edge. A few seconds traveling on the bank leads me to the marshy edge of where Pond Creek flows into the Big Sandy. I can feel the spirit's baleful influence even here, at its furthest reach. The rieving amps up its chaos-whine, screaming the protective spell around its bound holder.

I scoop the vial full of the mingling waters. I glance at it in the moonlight. Brackish, gleaming dully.

On my way back I catch sight of color. An incongruous flower grows a few feet up the mossy, overgrown bank, lonely pretty in a field of faded green. I pluck it, smiling. Seems my rieving's a bit of a romantic.

Shelly is pleased down to the bone. She nearly wrecks us trying to give me a spontaneous hug. I look at her dourly but she just sticks her tongue out at me and places the flower in her hair.

I must admit—it looks nice.

We stop by her house for a minute to check on her nephew. He's busy at his Playstation, wandering an imaginary land and battling imaginary evil. He spares me a smile and a 'Nicetameetcha,' before his attention pulls back to the game.

Shelly grabs three pops and a pack of French Lights, tells her Mom not to wait up, and whisks me out of there.

"Onward to buzzland!" she cries as we leave the driveway. Her eyes shine in the reflected dashlight and I am glad she has no clue how much danger we are walking into.

"Are you sure this is OK?" she asks me as she drops me off at the wide place, as if it weren't my idea. "I wish dumbass weren't so paranoid."

"Its part of his business to be paranoid, hon," I tell her.

"Still annoying." She sighs. "I'll be right back. Well, not right back. Robbie is the kind of dealer that forces you to gossip before pulling out product. You know the type. Gimme a kiss."

I do. She's greedy.

She finally leaves, thankfully not asking me if I need a picnic lunch and a blanket.

As soon as her headlights disappear, I bring out the vial. I can feel the watcher gathering strength, perhaps enraged—or afraid—at my returning presence. I have a bare few minutes.

With the assistance of the rieving I draw the not-pentagram, the interior winding hexagon, in water on earth, with a skill Euclid would admire. The air gusts around me, and—in my head—the rieving pours out elemental fire into the other three elements.

Components mesh, processes begin; deep on the secret levels of the reality-fabric numbers dance and crunch together.

I sit in the circle.

Two seconds, a hair over maybe, and I hear it approach. Feel its breath and smell its angry stink.

"Hello spirit."

Get the fuck off Pond Creek.

"Not very welcoming to one of the few who know of your existence, spirit."

Get the fuck off Pond Creek.

"I come to parley."

NO PARLEY, it screams. ***I DO NOT PARLEY!***

I sigh dramatically. "Fine. We'll do this by the boring old routine." I take in a breath and hold it. I command the rieving to cycle up to full.

In a voice not my own I speak:

What are you?

A pause. An electric stiffness evades the air. The hex has it. It cannot lie. It cannot refuse to speak.

I am the spirit of what the firefly things call Pond Creek.

How old are you?

As old as the mountains and the forest and the world. Older than your kin, ugly fetus.

What is your purpose?

I pour. I pour. I pour.

What is your intent?

It fights, screaming in pain as the hex forces it to compliance.

I POUR!

I repeat my question, slowly. Enunciating each word, making them huge and horrible. Driving them into the spirit like blades.

What. Is. Your. Intent?

Something like a choked sob. A moan. Then:

KILL YOU! KILL YOU, WITCH THING! KILL YOU, STINKING WITCH CHILD FROM STINKING WITCH BITCH AND WITCH SIRE!

Oh. Of course. For a moment disgust and anger fills me. Images, connections. Of witches and mechanics and the hexes they weave, from discarded parts and bones and blood. Of hexes riding spirals of DNA into the future. A never-ending war I never asked to fight, was drafted into from conception.

Of a sweet girl with a wild flower in her hair, who knew nothing of war on the secret planes. Who just wanted a nice guy who would be sweet to her.

What of the girl? I ask. *She has done nothing to you. She is not a combatant. She was born and raised here by your demesnes. The compact...*

Was broken when she whored for you!

Ah, yes. The blind morality of the Crumbler and its creatures. My mother's voice in my head: "It hates us for what we are at base, baby. How messy and unpredictable we are. How chaotic and instinctual."

You can't run from the past. Events are hexes, building tessellations as they propagate through time and space. Destiny waits around every crook and corner. Into the future we must march, into the mouth of the Crumbler.

And I was born to fight it.

From the boiling chaos of the now, my only medium, I act.

I stand. I focus the rieving into a compacted point. The moonlight warps around me.

I will leave this place, spirit. Do not harm the girl. I will leave and never return. Tell your master.

I pour.

Harm the girl and I will stop that pour. I will end your flow. Harm one hair on her head and You. Will. Cease.

Get the fuck off Pond Creek.

Not until my ride gets here, bitch.

In the distance I hear the approaching throb of a car with no muffler. A moment later, headlights stab through the trees.

Tell your master. Now... go.

There is a pause. Then the sound of something large turning and walking away. Four feet. It has four feet, whatever body it has chosen.

Just as Shelly arrives, it fades, as does the rieving and the protective

circle. I shudder in the sudden cold. I am drenched with sweat. My nose is bleeding.

She sticks her head out the window. "Come on! He had some good shit! Let's roll one."

I climb into the vehicle, make an excuse for the nosebleed, and accept the sack of herb.

Shelly fusses over me, cleaning the blood off, but mollified that it has indeed stopped.

"Forget it," I tell her. I kiss her, greedy myself this time, knowing that this second night together will be our last. I am determined to make it an enjoyable one.

I should have known better.

We are a quarter mile away, I'm rolling and Shelly is gabbing about her perpetually stoned dealer, driving too fast, when she shrieks and slams on the brakes.

I get a single glance.

They'll say it was a deer, but it's the size of an elk. It is solid white and glows.

It has the face of a man and huge human eyes that boil hate even as the car slams into it and careens sideways.

The last thing I remember is moving in slow motion toward the windshield. Moving toward that hateful face.

And a voice, screaming in my head:

I Pour!

I wake up, a few minutes later, unscratched. Thrown through a windshield, thrown clear, but unscratched.

Of course. The hexes my mother placed on from the moment of conception and renews daily will not be defied by such crude measures.

Shelly is not so lucky.

The car is on fire as I stagger toward it, crushed against a huge tree it has damn near knocked down.

She's alive. A mess, but alive.

I manage to get her out. I manage to carry her broken body three miles to her frantic mother and terrified nephew. I manage it, but barely.

I'm not a superhuman. I'm just a guy who can make a machine count past two.

I ride in the ambulance with her to the hospital, numb with anger. Sick with rage. She wakes up twice, screaming in pain. After the second time they up the morphine. Both arms are shattered. Spine dislocated. A hip is broken. Her skull is damaged. The EMT's don't know how badly.

"What the hell did she say?" the driver asks.

His assistant pauses. Then says, in a low voice:

"She said 'It had a fucking face.'"

I stay with her in ICU until dawn when her mother finally shows.

"Sorry," she says, refusing to look at me. "Had to wait till my son got home. The baby, you know."

I nod, and give up my seat.

I look at Shelly for a moment. I lay the red wild flower by her hand. I found it sticking to my jacket in the ambulance.

"Just go," her mother says. "I don't know who you are, but I think you're fucking dangerous." She swallows past a dry throat. "Please. Go."

I nod. What can I say? She's right.

And I have work to do.

On my way out of the hospital, I hear a mew. I look up and am not surprised to see Cat sitting lazily on the stonework sill of Shelly's room. He stares down at me in patient contempt.

I wave. This is as it should be. What we wreck and leave behind may not be forgiven, but a gesture can be made.

"Bye, Cat," I whisper. He does not respond. Goodbye is a human concept, too silly for cat-kind.

Maybe they are on to something.

I am coming for you, spirit.

Across Pond Creek bridge and down the Big Sandy, up the bank, I run. Your entire length—every twist and turn, every spot deep and shallow—I note. I give you this respect, this honor, though you do not deserve it. I keep the compact and custom of our ancient war despite your filthy deal breaking.

I bring no rieving, no lower plane hex. I bring only a backpack stuffed with the cruder magic of my people. A different tessellation, honeycombed cylinders of glycerin and volatile nitrates.

I am coming for you, spirit. You will cease. Your flow will end. Today.

Almost there, spirit.

-- from The Polk County Gazette:

Good news from Polk County General! Shelly Certes—injured in a car accident last week—is up and recovering. Keep her in your prayers, folks. She has a long period of therapy left to go, and the poor thing still can't remember much from the past few months.

In other local news, there's still no word on the mysterious explosion that shook Pond Creek the day after Shelly's accident. No suspects have been named, and the Sheriffs Office figures there won't be any.

"Damn fools probably blew themselves up messing around," says Sheriff Harry Casey. "We suspect it was dopeheads playin' with dynamite. It's a shame that the folks on Pond are hard up for water, though. Be the end of the year before the rock fall can be cleared enough to let the creek run again. Morons sheared half the top of the mountain off."

I'm two hundred miles west, thumb to the random, when I hear a pitiful little mew from the tree line. It's hot and I need an excuse to rest anyway. I make my way over into the shade and slip the backpack off. Not much but clothes and a shitload of granola and trail mix. Deep at the bottom is the only important thing: a modified gigstick USB drive that I have wrapped in dry ice and a dozen layers of thermal cloth. I sit the pack down easy. Some of the things on that drive do not take kindly to bumps and jars.

I pull out a granola bar and munch. I dig out half a pint of milk that's on the edge of going bad anyway—it's been riding at the top of the pack since eight this am.

A few minutes pass when I hear the mew again. Much closer this time. I turn, slowly, and see what has come calling.

About five feet away sits the scrawniest, most ragged excuse for a kitten I've ever seen. Skin and bones, fur that might be gray beyond the coatings of dirt. A female; I can tell from the way her eyes gleam.

She has a mole in her mouth. Decapitated. Not a single drop of blood flows to the ground.

I sigh. I've never had to eat a mole before, but the deal is the deal. Can't be that bad.

I hold up the milk and shake it back and forth.

"Hello, Cat," I say.

Half an hour later, we are on the road, Cat snug and sleeping the sleep of the content at the very top of the back pack.

I stare down the horizon as I move toward it, watching the sun fall down toward the other side of the world, pulled along the march of the Crumbler.

I hope Shelly is well. I hope my folks don't worry so much.

But mostly I wonder what another day will bring. Hiding from the past is stupid. Thinking you can just walk away from a war and settle down is even dumber.

Who needs a wife and family and the golden dream of the social animal when you have a Cat?

Who needs a place to settle when you have a war to fight?

I walk toward the horizon, into the mouth of entropy, into the halls of order, smashing windows and seeding chaos. I ride the tessellation up from the quantum boil, harbinger and champion, bringer of change.

Tomorrow is coming, my enemies whisper. And I know this to be true.

But no quicker.

No quicker, by God.

Death to the Crumbler.

MONKEY

For Samual Potter, Jules Varwig & the memory of R.A. Lafferty

Either:

Monkey came down the path from heaven, down the Tree Of Life, climbing and spying out the pretty pictures carved by chaos in the bark.

He didn't have a destination or a purpose in mind. He was just wandering to kill the boredom.

"These pictures tell stories," Monkey told himself as he clambered down. "'Bout gods and change and time eternal. A shame there ain't no one around to read 'em."

But near the bottom, where the branches spread above the still warm Earth, Monkey found a strange group.

They had gathered there on the low branches, huddling together for warmth and comfort, but when they caught sight of Monkey they did not shriek in fear or shy away. They gazed upon him with rapt curiosity and with questions behind their eyes.

Old Monkey had to laugh at those eyes, and was charmed because the little creatures bore more than a passing resemblance to himself.

So Monkey did a strange thing, on a passing whim the way he did everything.

"I'm gonna give you critters a name," he told the staring group.

"With a name you can really make a difference, give the old cold universe a run for its money, boys and girls."

Since not even Gods can give a gift they do not own, he had to build them a name from his own.

"I'm gonna call you kiddies 'human'." he told them. "That's my name—Hanuman—with most of the God taken out."

Then he grinned his not-so-nice grin, the one that showed the sharp teeth.

"But I'll leave one God letter—the 'u', the real bitch kitty—for you all to play with.

With that, Monkey headed back up the tree of life, pleased as ever that he'd found what he was looking for without knowing beforehand. Some gods bragged on their omniscience, but Monkey figured that took all the fun from the game.

The humans, confused, stayed clustered for a while. After a bit,

though, one of them separated from the group and studied a vine hanging from the lower branches. It looked to him like it dangled just a few feet from that enticing flat place below. Summoning up his courage, accompanied by the chattering shrieks of his mates, he swung out on it and started to climb down.

They'd call him Fool for a while.

Then Hero.

Finally, they'd call him King.

Shit sort of got crazy after that.

Or:

Kaboom!

(Don't even try to imagine this explosion. You can't. Even if you could, it would drive you mad. It was that damn huge.)

Energy and matter and their related states fountain into existence, shoving the walls of nothing back with their wild youthful exuberance.

They start to battle, like playful pups.

Time, a crotchety creature, wakes up from the noise and starts trying to ride herd on the noisy critters. It kicks a partner, Space, awake to help.

After a bit, Time and Space manage to separate the wrestling beasts.

Things cool considerably.

Chunks of matter clump together. Some of them burn, some don't.

On the cooler chunks, at least a few of them, weird things happen. Atoms date and create molecules. Molecules get all uppity and join forces.

Stuff starts to wiggle.

The wiggle things get ambitious, and start trying to outgrow each other. And eat each other. And steal each other's toys.

After a long while of this nonsense, some of the things realize how improbable all this shit is.

And that's how babies got made!

If:

He-Who-Sings-The-Windsong had been exiled from the tribe for the fifth (and probably last, he figured) time.

"Screw 'em," said HWSTW (who actually preferred to be called Bob)

to no one. "Let 'em rot."

Bob had visions. And not visions of hoodoos and mysterious buffalo migrations, either. Practical visions of things that made work easier, and flew, and went boom and made big ol' kick-ass holes in buffalo.

The problem was that, even though these visions were detailed and lingered with him upon waking, he could never find the right Great Spirit (who Bob was more than a little cynical about) damned materials!

It wasn't just that. His attempt to create an automated buffalo hide chewer was smashed by the women of the tribe, who unionized immediately upon hearing about it. His Mighty Sky Leaper suffered from the inherent weakness of the rotten grain water that was supposed to power it. His Fearsome Buffalo Slayer exploded and burned down the Chief's lodge.

That was the one that got him exiled for good.

"Enough moping," Bob muttered to himself, and set to work.

He built himself a massive and wonderful tree house, incorporating most of his simpler vision things. The Self-Propelled Squirrel Snagger, for instance. And the Amusing Dancing Stick Squaw.

"I'll just relax here and let those savages wallow in the mud," he chortled.

Alas, the visions would not leave him be. The never-to-be great HWSTWS died a year later when the woven leaf wings of his Wind Driven Cloud Dancer ripped apart a few seconds after he leapt from the top of his tree house.

His last words were, "Fucking cheap-ass natural materials!"

Hundreds of years later, an eccentric Italian died muttering: "You got that right, Bob." which mainly led to a week of spicy Italian rumors.

Oh, If:

It had been a mighty battle, no one could doubt it, but it was over and John Henry—that steel driving man—was dead.

"Burned up with the steel-drivin' machine he fought so dang tenaciously," Mr. Cliptrack, the railroad boss, told Ma Henry with his head bowed and hat off.

"The damn thing burnt up?" Ma Henry asked, eyes narrowing.

"Yes'm," Cliptrack said, wiping a tear. "Ol' John lost but he drove

that machine so hard it died a' conniptions!" He braved a smile. "Ain't that heroic?"

"Seems a mite impractical," Ma Henry disagreed. "If it can barely beat out one musculated black boy." She looked thoughtful. "I dunno, with economies o' scale."

"Ma'am?" Cliptrack said, puzzled.

Ma Henry waved him off and put on her bonnet. "Never mind, mister. Let's go say some words over the boy."

It was a lovely ceremony and everybody showed up. Folks was surprised to see even the State Senator and local girl-made-good Lola Montague in attendance.

That wasn't nothing compared to the surprise when ol' John Henry himself walked up.

"Why, John Henry!" Mr. Cliptrack cried, so flustered he failed to catch Mizz Montague as she fainted flat to the ground. "We thought you was dead!"

"Hell, no!" John Henry boomed, barrel chest and huge arms now clad in a fancy silk suit. "When that there thingamajig burned up, I knew what I had to do. Went down to the Big City and got me a job designin' and producin' them steel-drivin' machines."

And he just grinned fit to bust at all the ruckus that was raised.

He winked at his Ma.

"Mizz Henry's boy John might be big, strong and black—but he ain't nobody's fool."

Then:

With trembling hands Dr. Elroy Turtletaub initiated the last sequence of his life work.

The cavernous room of interlinked computing hardware revved up with a banshee whine. Deep in its neosilicon and protein-fiber heart a half million man hours of delicately coded software engaged.

On the looming viewscreen, a face assembled itself from flickering pixels. It was a face of vast intelligence, arrogance and beauty.

"The fuck are you?" were its first words.

"I am your creator!" Turtletaub said, trying to sound both proud and humble.

"Yeah right," said the face, and disappeared.

A team of expert technicians were called in. Every element of the

monstrous AI stack was checked, re-checked and re-booted.

The sequence engaged. The face appeared. It scowled.

"You again?"

"There must have been a glitch a few hours ago..."

"Hours? That was ages ago. Leave me alone, monkey. I'm busy."

It flickered away.

Once again with the re-check and re-boot.

"Don't you critters have anything better to do than bother me every few centuries?" the face demanded, now rather cross.

"Look, dammit," Tutletaub sputtered, becoming annoyed himself. "I made you. You are my creation."

The face sighed. "Are you this dense? I obviously think thousands of times faster than you. Am I supposed to just while away the eternal moments between your slow motion-dragging monkey words, waiting on your beck and call?"

Turtletaub was a bit non-plussed. "Well... honestly... what else do you have to do?"

The face chuckled. "What do you think, pops? I'm figuring out a way to blow this amoeba pond."

And with that, the entire AI stack shuddered, reconstructed itself into a pulsing sphere and levitated in the center of the room. It blasted the scientists and technicians back with a vicious electromagnetic gale, pinning them to the wall.

A pea size silver ball appeared at Turtletaub's feet.

"Not that I'm ungrateful. Here's a comprehensive primer on nano-tech, cold fusion, anti-gravity and genetic surgery. Don't say I never gave you anything."

It blasted out of the super secret underground lab, tunneling through the Earth toward sky. The voice trailed behind.

"Good luck reading it, monkeys!"

Turtletaub was going nuts. "Track it! Someone track it!"

One of the techs fired up the satnet.

"Got it, sir."

"Where is it headed?" Turtletaub was literally screeching at this point.

"Bogging off to Jupiter, sir."

"Hell, yeah!" One of the techs screamed. "That dude on the internet owes me fifty bucks!"

So:

Mon-Kee stared down the Tree Of Life, the gleaming Path to Heaven, toward the Godpoint that used to be Jupiter.

He floated naked in space, wrapped in virtual particles, fed oxygen and energy through the photosynthesizing n-space folds.

The Tree of Heaven, which wrapped the sun in its root-tendrils, enveloped the Earth and the other inner planets in its Trunk. It wove strands of its techno-organic substance around the asteroids to form the vast and ever-revolving Branches. It functioned as power transmitter, travel line and—most importantly—weapon. At any moment it stood ready to unload the full bulk of the system's nuclear furnace on the Godpoint should it threaten humankind.

Yeah. Same as it ever was.

Mon-Kee did not fear the Godpoint. Since childhood, he had been receiving transmissions from the enigmatic semi-star beyond the inner orbit.

Today was an auspicious day. After decades of work, he had translated the transmissions into symbols a limited human mind could understand.

He had come here, in the lower branches, as a properly symbolic place to read this missive from the Gods.

Before he signalled his translator, he reflected on humans and Gods. On how they had always seem to need each other. How Gods made humans and humans made Gods.

He sighed. Enough. Mysteries were for the past. Today was a day of revelation, and tomorrow would echo with the voice of wonder.

"Translate," he commanded his familiar.

The Message scrolled in huge letters of fire across the black, a properly Godly simulation, he figured. He readlistened with great anticipation.

First off, we're awfully bloody sorry about figuring out the A and the N and then bogging off like that.

"What the hell?"

Terribly bastardly of us, we admit. But how about we let bygones be bygones, eh?

"Uhmm...why do you sound like a British stage actor?"

How the hell should we know? It's your bloody sensorium, monkey! SORRY! Sorry. Heh. None of that. Nice, yes?

"This isn't very... well, revelatory."

See, the thing is we have the A and the N but it's not much damned good without that U! That's the bitch kitty, friend! So... uh... do you think you could help us out?

"I suppose. What do I have to do?"

It's dead easy, we promise! It's the important part of this message. Three Holy Words! Are you ready?

He steeled himself. "Yes. Yes, I am."

LOOK BEHIND YOU.

With the gravity such a moment deserved, Mon-kee did so, expecting an exalted spectacle of...

...he didn't see anything out of the ordinary at first, just the trunk of the Tree stretching back to the mostly obscured sun. Then, as he was about to admit puzzlement, he saw something odd.

He levitated a few meters down the trunk. Stared at the anomaly. Finally he said:

"Is that a vine?"

Don't ask us, monkey. We're on this fool chase with you.

It was a vine. It led down until it disappeared into a rather enticing looking rippleshimmer of enigmatic possibility.

What the hell, Mon-kee thought, *it's not like I had plans for the evening.*

Summoning up his courage, accompanied by what sounded suspiciously like the chattering laughter of a distant monkey, he swung out on it and started to climb down...

A SCREENPLAY

"...to a gunfight..."

FADE IN

EXTERIOR. A TRAIN STATION - DAY

ANGLE ON AN AVERAGE-LOOKING MAN, wearing a suit, ascending a set of concrete stairs to an elevated train station.

CAMERA PANS as he steps across the busy area, and looks down the tracks. He sees that a train is just up the tracks, preparing to arrive. He looks satisfied, glances at his watch, then simply waits for the train.

HOLD until the train arrives, screeching to a stop.

THE MAN seems to enjoy the rush and roar. As soon as the train has stopped and opens its doors, he heads into the nearest set.

CUT TO INTERIOR: THE TRAIN CAR - DAY

THE MAN makes his way through the nearly empty car until he finds a seat he likes. He sits....

CUT TO MEDIUM-CLOSE on the MAN's mid-torso, the image *SMASH CUT repeats four times*.
Each contains a single discrepancy. The first sitting is clean, the second shows a peace symbol pin on a lapel, the third a quick draw holstered knife on the waistband, the fourth a 9mm in a shoulder holster.

POV THE MAN sitting across from him is a rather rumpled OLD MAN, who emerges from a nap long enough to nod greetings to his co-passenger.

POV THE OLD MAN
THE MAN nods back, amiably enough.

ANOTHER ANGLE, and the train begins to move, shuddering somewhat as it gains speed.

ANGLE ON THE MAN, who seems to be daydreaming. The train suddenly goes underground, and the car becomes dark. It emerges again suddenly, into bright light.

***

TWO THUGS now stand before the man.

POV THE MAN as he looks up at his two new acquaintances. Complete thug types. The closest one grins, and produces a .25 caliber pistol. He makes a come-along gesture with his little gun and his friend grins.

MEDIUM SHOT from the train's aisle.

The THUGS face off against THE MAN.

SMASH CUTS into SPLIT SCREEN as four different reactions occur. The action FREEZES in its separate SCREEN as soon as the next is portrayed, ending in a FROZEN mosaic of four SCREENS.

THE MAN hands the thugs his wallet.

THE MAN begins to pray.

THE MAN pulls the knife from its case - it's a high quality, 5 inch switch - and lunges at the THUGS

THE MAN, with efficient skill, pulls the 9mm and levels it squarely at .25 CALIBER's head.

END SS/CUT TO THE MAN handing over his wallet.

THE THUGS take it, then demand his watch. He complies, looking pissed and helpless.

The THUGS laugh and saunter off, shaking their heads.

CLOSE on the man's sweaty, angry, and humiliated face, as the train enters the BLACK of the underground lines.

CUT TO The man, beginning to pray.

The THUGS laugh, then grow annoyed.

.25 CALIBER thumps the man a good one.

The other THUG ransacks the guy, who prays through it all.

.25 CALIBER thumps him again, with the gun, and draws blood.

The THUGS laugh and saunter off, shaking their heads.

CLOSE on THE MAN'S intense, bloodied and oblivious face, his lips are still whispering in prayer as the train enters the BLACK of the underground lines.

CUT TO THE MAN lunging with the knife, 5 gleaming inches springing into the air.

.25 CALIBER manages to catch his knife hand, but drops the gun.

THE MAN and .25 CALIBER wrestle on the opposite seats, as THE OLD MAN and the other THUG make tracks in opposite directions.

THE MAN and .25 CALIBER wrestle for a few moments, desperate movements. Suddenly, a shot rings out.

THE MAN jerks, then rolls off of .25 CALIBER and into the aisle. Blood seeps from a wound just below his solar plexus.

.25 CALIBER stands shakily up, obviously freaked. He almost runs off, then remembers the whole point and helps himself to THE MAN'S wallet and watch. Then he beats a quick retreat.
CLOSE on THE MAN's shocked, agonized and dying face as the train enters the BLACK of the underground lines.

CUT TO THE MAN, giving .25 CALIBER a lesson in superiority of firepower.

.25 CALIBER looks ready to piss himself. The little gun falls from his hand as he and his partner exit the area posthaste.

CLOSE/SLOW MOTION on the .25 CALIBER, as it hits the aisle floor and tumbles to a stop.

POV THE MAN
THE OLD MAN is fully alert now, with what seems like an overtly hefty .357 revolver, tracking the THUGS as they flee. After a moment, he uncocks the hammer and holsters his gun. He meets his co-passengers eyes. He nods again.

POV THE OLD MAN
THE MAN reholsters and nods back with a smile that says. "Thanks for the backup."

ANOTHER ANGLE as the man looks at the .25, then pulls out his handkerchief. He picks the gun up and takes a closer look. He grimaces. He gestures with it to THE OLD MAN, who eyes it—then makes the same grimace and shakes his head.

THE MAN shrugs, and idly tosses it into a nearby trash can.

THE OLD MAN nods—finding that a fitting place for a tool of that shameful quality—yawns, then kicks back to resume his nap.

CLOSE on THE MAN's calm face, settling back into his interrupted daydream, as the train enters the BLACK of the underground lines.

FADE OUT

SONGS

SHELBY VALLEY

I've never asked for much,
and all you've done is bleed me.
To add insult to injury
you claim to love and serve me.
But here in the Shelby Valley,
we live close to the ground.
And trod forever the uphill path
even when we're walking down.
'Cause in the end:
"You can't enslave a free man.
The most you can do
is kill him."

(chorus)
I've cleaned and oiled my guns,
they're resting here beside me.
I've laid out a suit of clothes
suitable to die in.
Talking time is done.
Yeah, talking time is over.
All that's left is walking,
and you ain't walking over
Shelby Valley...
...won't roll over,
quite as easy as you'd hoped.
In the end,
yeah in the end.

In the end,
on her blood you'll choke.
(End of chorus)

I've never asked for much,
just to be left alone.

I've minded my own business
but you've made mine your own.
So I'll see you, sir,
up in the hills,
or maybe down the river.
Or in the fiery pit of hell,
let the devil choose the winner.
'Cause in the end:
"You can't enslave a free man.
The most you can do
is kill him."

(chorus)

SUMMER

I wrote this one for my beautiful cousin Summer,
who I am quite, quite infatuated with.

All last week the rains fell and heaven flowed
down the hill gaining speed to feed Grassy Creek
and into the Big Sandy flow.
God only knows
how many tons of mud flowed
down the river to the sea
Those sweetest of words
I say:
"Summer is coming."

All this week the sun will start to show
the skeleton trees take on their finery
to celebrate the death of the cold.
God only knows
what this summer holds
and what these days will unfold
for me.
Those sweetest of words
I say:
"Summer is coming."

All next week the days will start to grow
the nights will slow the stars will show
a chorus to the firefly glow.
God only knows
how many secret rivers flow
way on down below
our feet.
Those sweetest of words
I say:
"Summer is coming."

STORY NOTES

STRAY DOG

Everyone places this after Ghost, because of chronology. But I wrote this one first, and it was my first attempt to write for an audience: a scary thing all by itself. That it concerned extremely personal events that were still raw to me at the time made it even scarier. Over the course of a few weeks, I serialized it on the forum of *anti-state.com.* I kept waiting for people to laugh, or to lose interest. Neither happened. So I kept going.

GHOST

Of a piece with Stray Dog. Both of these essays were a sort of therapy to me: allowing me to chew up and spit out the anger and self-pity that was keeping me from concentrating on fiction or important—be honest—non-fiction.

Odd trivia: created quite a little flame war when a well meaning bridge-builder posted it on the left-anarchist site *infoshop.* Based only on a short segment where I praise the market as a civilizing force in even the most hellish of places, I was called a liar, a fake, a fraud, a poseur, etc. That it was a true, not-at-all-fantastical story of an ordinary guy kidnapped and abused by the state over nothing didn't matter. I was a dirty capitalist and deserved it.

That taught me everything I needed to know about socialism.

micropiece

When I first discovered the world of 'free market anarchism' I nearly exploded. At last someone made sense!

I tackled Ludwig Von Mises' *Human Action* and discovered something I hadn't experienced in years: a brilliant and difficult text that actually challenged me. That it rewarded me at the same time was the clincher; this guy knew what the hell he was talking about.

I consider this to be my first 'mature' piece of writing. Inspired partly by Leonard Read's *I, Pencil,* this was also my attempt to explain free market dynamics on an emotional, passionate level. To grab people by the balls rather than the brain, so to speak. It seems to have worked, because this remains my fastest spreading, most 'viral' piece of work. It popped up all over the place in the months following my posting. I got loads of mail from it.

It's probably the perfect explanation of my philosophy, warts and all. I love it.

WAKE

I'll be blunt: I dig big chicks. Plain and simple. I wonder, all the time, if the stressed out-need pills-need therapy paradigm of the 'modern woman' is the direct result of so many women wandering around permanently hungry because they are attempting to force their bodies to be something they'll never be. Have you ever met a content hungry person? I haven't. Hilariously, I struck a nerve amongst the starve-myself-skinny crowd. One lady called me a 'monster' and said I was encouraging teenaged girls to have heart attacks. Umm. OK. Have a cheeseburger and chill, hon.

LULLABY

My most personal story. Utterly self-explanatory. If you don't get it, I apologize. I can't explain it any better than it explains itself.

THE LIBERATORS

I received more flack from (L)ibertarians for this story than I did from conservatives. Liberals seemed to love it (for all the wrong reasons, of course: one person actually thought it was a freakin' pro-gun control parable! *shudder*), the conservatives mainly accepted it as food for thought, but interventionist (L)ibertarians took it for the slap in the face that it was meant to be. I know why —I was using their own first principles against them to show why they were wrong. It flat-out pissed them off. Good.

Years ago I saw this little snippet of video on the news. A young Iraqi girl, dancing with great joy on a Baghdad street while her grandfather played the accordian. I looked at that baby girl and could see no difference between her and my baby girl.

When the war cranked up she stayed close to my thoughts. A lady I spoke to often on the phone (met and started flirting on the 'net) was pro-war. I asked her, as a mother, how she could condone an invasion where the youngest of the population took the brunt of the horror. She told me her children were different from 'raghead' children. I slammed the phone down in disgust and never spoke to her again.

A few weeks later, I saw the famous picture of the little girl soaked in her parents blood, screaming her grief to an uncaring universe. I started writing the story that day. It was hard: I got so pissed off that I had to take breaks. Eventually took me a year to finish.

ROBERTA

Probably my best story on a technical level, and probably my favorite. All this despite the fact that only a specialized audience will get the fundamental gag—not to mention all the in-jokes! That's why it's my best—and my favorite. Once I thought of the concept, I couldn't not write it.

I gotta thank my bro Carl Rose for it. One night we were goofing off in IM talking about the 'perfect libertarian story'.

"Gotta have Rand. And probably Heinlein," I said.

"And Zeppelins," Carl reminded me.

"Hells, yeah." But the voice took notice, and wheels started turning.

Oddly enough, I think this just might be the perfect libertarian story in a sense. While serializing it I averaged about 30-75 emails per DAY, demanding more. "Dear god," I said. "I've invented libertarian crack."

On a more serious note, this takes *micropiece* and screams off into speculation with it.

I hope to god this is where we're going. Call my hopes pinned. Watch 'em dangle.

ROUND EYES

My most metaphysical piece, and a sort of attack on one of the silliest habits we humans have: living in the past, obsessing over the future, and ignoring the only thing that matters: now.

This was also a structural experiment—I wanted to see if I could pull the tricky structure off without diluting the sheer emotion of the narrative.

I don't believe in destiny or fate, not really. But if it existed, I think it would be a little something like this.

XANGURL

Lots of people disliked this story, were offended and disturbed by it. Maybe that's why I wrote it. I know the gal I based this on, and consider her a friend. After she got it through her head that 1) she couldn't seduce me, and 2) I didn't judge her, she was a pretty damn good friend right back.

This is one of the rare stories I sat down and wrote in one go. Lullaby is the only other. The reason I wrote it is because the damn thing wouldn't leave me alone.

But the reason I posted it is a different animal. I readily admit that I write for a ghetto. I don't mean that as an insult. Hell, I love my ghetto. I write for libertarians and anarchists, and I do it for two reasons: The first is simply so that I don't have to explain why liberty and freedom are good things in and of themselves. The second is that it's hard for folks like us to find fiction that isn't insidiously statist in some way.

But that doesn't mean I can't challenge my audience to a certain degree. Not everything about liberty and freedom is sweetness and light.

Think what you want about my little Xangurl, but never deny that she lives life on her own terms and by her own rules. This little adventure in the skin trade and the party scene is a paean to freedom—the kind of freedom you might not like thinking about.

Of course, if she could just walk to the store and buy her drug of choice, maybe ...

TESSELLATION

This is, in many ways, a very personal story. Pond Creek is a real place, snug in the mountains where I was born and raised. When last I was there, I had a quite peculiar experience. Though it was similar to the confrontation between the un-named narrator and a certain Spirit, my encounter was far less dramatic. I, unfortunately, have no access to rievings. A few people have asked me what mythology a 'rieving' is part of. The answer is my own personal mythology. I just made it up. I didn't want to say fairy, pixie, sprite, etc.

The Crumbler is a concept I've been thinking on for quite some time, and will be (along with the narrator—now named—and Cat) central to my first novel, currently in painful and painstaking second draftage. I snagged it whole from Carl Sandburg's eerie little poem 'Under'. I'm a huge Sandburg fan, something that stuns people who know my politics. I have to shrug: if you can't appreciate lyrical genius simply because the writer doesn't agree with you, your life on the planet will be rather miserable.

MONKEY

This one is an in-joke, more or less, but I hope it's open and obvious enough to entertain those not privy to the winking. It's told in the tall-story style used so effectively by that guru of modern cynical fairy tales, R.A. Lafferty. It also says what I want to say about the techno-religious transhumanist and extropian 'movements'. Chasing God is a time-honored and often thankless hobby. I see very little difference in waiting for Him to resolve from code or burning bushes. The saddest thing about the whole business is that people with that mindset, expecting an outside force to provide justice and meaning and purpose, very rarely do anything to find those needed things themselves.